Crowns

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/62445379.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Catra & Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Royalty, Queendoms, Matriarchy, Princesses, Knights - Freeform, Princess Catra (She-Ra), Knight Adora (She-Ra), Mother-Daughter Relationship, Physical Abuse, Emotional/Psychological Abuse, Feminist Themes, Violence, Blood and Gore, Angst, Fluff, Action, Other Additional Tags to Be Added, sun and moon wives!, fairytale

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2025-01-23 Completed: 2025-12-19 Words: 52,479 Chapters: 7/7

Crowns

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/62445379.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Catra & Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Royalty, Queendoms, Matriarchy, Princesses, Knights - Freeform, Princess Catra (She-Ra), Knight Adora (She-Ra), Mother-Daughter Relationship, Physical Abuse, Emotional/Psychological Abuse, Feminist Themes, Violence, Blood and Gore, Angst, Fluff, Action, Other Additional Tags to Be Added, sun and moon wives!, fairytale

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2025-01-23 Completed: 2025-12-19 Words: 52,479 Chapters: 7/7

Crowns

by Gazelles

Summary

Adora, the lost wanderer with a haunting past, finds knighthood thrust upon her. After the meeting of the princess and the resurfacing of old memories, she vows to be by her side forever. But many things are not as clear as they seem. As the relationship between them bloom into something bigger, they are forced to battle new and old enemies.

Notes

Hello!
First of all, thank you very much for choosing to click on this story, I'm so grateful!

Secondly, this is my first attempt at creative writing but not at having story ideas all the time, so I'm happy that you're joining in this journey. I hope you have as much fun reading this as I have writing it and even much more.

I adore these characters so much on such a deep and personal level and I hope that this story can reflect that.

And without further ado, enjoy!

See the end of the work for more notes

Chapter 1: Daffodil

"Our beloved queendom has been sung and talked about across the lands for many reasons. Our nature, for a first. No other place in the world would embrace as many domains as she does. From our high proud mountains to our lush grasslands, from the rich forests to the golden deserts. Not forgetting our surrounding seas, generous to feed us and mighty to protect us. Every traveler wishes to come here once in a lifetime. What more can you think of that makes the queendom of halfmoon what it is?"

An enthusiastic child, barely a decade, answered. "It's rich!"

"That is correct." The teacher praised. Enthusiastic students were his life's delight. "Owing to the abundance of resources buried in halfmoon's rocks or waters or soils, and the brilliance of our scholars and generosity of our leaders, we would soon complete half a century where no woman, man, or child would sleep the night cold or hungry."

His silence was understood as freedom to answer his previous question. "Halfmoon is magical."

"Ah," the teacher retreated from complete agreement. "All of Etheria is magical."

The boy who had supplied that answer sank his head in shame, so the teacher humoured him. "But you are correct in a way. Halfmoon's reputation of being a magical mother lode has some

truth in it. As opposed to many, our magic is rarely harnessed, rarely exploited or used, whether for creation or destruction. We respect our magic here. We let it flow like a breeze, like a river. Unbound and unsoiled. And so in return it gifts us its affluence."

"Don't the magicats help too?" A bodiless voice rang from among the crowd.

"That's a rumour!" A young magicat girl answered back, defensively.

"No it's not."

The teacher intervened and quieted them down. Intellectual disputes were necessary for education, but not ones built on hearsay. Besides, he knew exactly where this particular conversation was heading and he desired no part in it. Loosening his coiled tail, he faced his students with a smile and called to his question of before.

"It's always peaceful."

"Yes!" He said with renowned passion. "Even before the order of Queens, our people have always been devoted to their pacifism. Like few, we never prided ourselves on the false glory of bloodshed or conquests. Our orders protect us, but we never close them against those who don't wish us harm. And for that we are rewarded peace and benevolence.

“What about the battle of the castle-city?”

Sharp gasps sounded through the two half-circles of students surrounding him. All looking at the asker with wide eyes and wide mouths. The asker in turn, a girl older than most with tight mouth and stubborn eyes, didn’t spare them a glance.

The teacher accepted his now-found responsibility in answering that question and with a heavy grief settling on his heart, he began telling the two-decade old story.

“Almost twenty years ago, the port closest to the castle-city, where the queen and her wife resided, was invaded by a foreign empire. Despite the early warnings of this army, our valiant knights and warriors weren’t prepared for its relentless trek. The invasion was finally stopped a day before the army was estimated to reach our queen. But it was a worthless victory, for an important soul was stolen in that battle, the soul of our brave queen-consort. She refused to sit idly behind walls while her fellow knights, on whom she used to fight alongside with before her marrying into the throne, were slaughtered. And so with the blessing of our queen she charged into the battle and won it, but lost her life in the process.”

Teary eyes and quivering lips looked at him expectantly for the ending of the tale, and so with new rigor, he continued.

“Sorrowfully, the queen was in anguish. Her heart was stolen, and one cannot live without a heart. But her majesty endured it all. For she was growing a gift in her womb, a gift to lifeless lover and a heirless queendom. A daughter. So she held own. But her strength was finite. A year after the princess was born, the queen exhaled her last breath. Reuniting with her love at last.”

Sobs were faintly heard from the younger children, but another voice overpowered them loud and clear. “So the princess is all alone now?”

It was the same tight faced girl from before.

“No, thankfully.” The teacher was content with abandoning the talk of tragedies. “The sun shone on our dark night, and a saviour came to our aid. A regent with unmatched brilliance and unbound power. Who, while the nation was grieving the loss of our two queens, seized control benevolently and cared for us. We're all so thankful for her service. The princess is in her care now.”

“But who is she?” The eagerness in the girl’s voice told him this was the exact question she was leading into. “The regent, I mean. She’s covered in mysteries. From her origin to her personhood.”

“Some mysteries are best left uncovered.” Said the teacher in a flat voice, annoyance slowly careening in.

“But how can we trust her?”

Like before, she stood motionless in the face of her classmate's utter shock.

The teacher quickly composed himself, hurrying to defend his beloved regent's honor. "We trust her, because she has done unimaginable service to our queendom and our princess. Without her, we could've been a crownless, thoneless island wandering around in grief and sorrow. This secrecy is not only expected, but required. No one bore the scars of the battle more than the castle, and we all understand the lengths needed to ensure the princess's safety. All of halfmoon is grateful for the regent. That is why we trust her."

Something in his voice or his answer stifled the girl enough for her to lower her head and mutter something along the lines of her family's growing suspicion of the regent, the teacher wasn't surprised. Not all of halfmoon was attuned to change, no matter how much he wished for.

The ensuing silence was long but finite. Soon enough it was broken by other speeches and debates and tales of halfmoon's culture, or its council, or its many many corners of the land.

The teacher loved his profession, he had always adored the pursuit of knowledge and even more the transferring of it. And he had always adored his queendom. What is more perfect for him than teaching the future generation of halfmoon about their great queendom?

—♕—

The life of a nomad was exactly as Adora pictured, and also not at all.

She expected the physical adversity, the thirst and hunger and exhaustion, the burn of muscles and clinging of sweat, whether under a scorching sun or through freezing winds. Whether she was walking on armoured legs or atop her eye-stealing horse. Adora grew up inside marble walls, but she was no stranger to the hardships of life outside of them.

She didn’t expect the warm welcome groups and nomadic families offered her, she had prepared herself at the start to make her travels alone. But thrice a caravan saw her walking alone and invited her to accompany them. She offered services in turn, protection mostly, due to her sword and armour. But so did everyone on board. From the traders to the pilgrims.

She expected the strangeness of foreign lands, she had read all there is to read in translated books about the wonders of the queendoms and kingdoms in etheria. About their geography, culture and language. But it was so completely different from when she actually sat foot in them and beheld them by her very eyes.

She didn’t expect to find so many like her. Travelers, nomads, vagants, lost wanderers. People with no destination and no origin. No ahead and no behind. Some were poets, other explorers, others nothing at all. Just like Adora. They were wandering the

lands looking for something. Money, freedom, beauty, love. Many would die before finding it.

Adora wasn't looking for any of those things, she had had half of them in abundance. She, instead, was looking for the truth. And after a year of her quest, of its fruitlessness, Adora began to lose hope, lost dedication. She started to become like the travelers she swore she would never be. Trudging through life aimlessly, like a fallen leaf in the wind, with no will of its own.

Perhaps that's why she found herself in Halfmoon's soil.

She wasn't surprised that it was her current caravan's destination, they must have told her, even if she didn't remember when exactly, and Adora didn't have strength or reason to leave before their arrival.

It wasn't her first time in this queendom, halfmoon, etheria's crown's jewel, this so-called paradise. She had read and heard enough poems and songs and stories of its beauty and opulence and magic. Had seen some of her own eyes. Her companion's reasons wouldn't stray too far out of these three reasons and knowing her inevitable disinterest, she left soundlessly, leaving sacks of money behind as an excuse. She then turned her back against the castle-city's mighty walls and marched backwards.

As much as she didn't want to be, she was here now. And Adora was a woman of making use of one's circumstances. And since it wasn't her first time, she didn't bother with what most would do. Instead, she did what she doubted anyone did. She looked at the

portrait of the halfmoon's beauty and searched for the cracks in the canvas.

The rest of the queendom outside the walls was very different from what halfmoon was known for. Adora had ventured into paths that ward off strangers and foreigners, Where no one of nobility or education would deign to enter. She searched for what and who halfmoon hid in its belly.

When she reached its entrails, She wrinkled her nose, not in disgust, but in anger and disdain. Parentless children squabbling for scraps, too thin men and women who resembled corpses, many already were. No one saw this, no one saw halfmoon’s hypocrisy.

Her heart ached at a weeping child clutching his sleeping mother, who had no energy to stand. Adora made sure to kneel. Appearing as nonviolent as she could, even with her gleaming armor and scabbered sword. The child gasped at her and even more when she extended her hand, finding the golden coins inside. Adora’s eyes misted when the child began to cry out of happiness. And then her heart filled in anger again at the fact that this shouldn’t happen.

She had stood and only took three steps when she heard commotion from behind, an elder had wrestled the child for the coins and was making his escape.

“Hey!” Adora called behind him before quickly blocked his path. “Give them back.” She gestured to the coins held tightly in his fist,

now at the centre of his chest away from prying hands.

“His mother was already dead, he wouldn’t survive a month without her, even with the gold.” His voice was scorched and barely audible. “I have a family to feed, they need it more.”

Adora held firm, “I can give you too, but you must give them back to him.”

The surety in her voice lit up a small tinkle of hope in his eyes, but it was quickly dimmed down. He shook his head, not trusting her word. He had been let down by the world too many times.

Adora clenched her teeth. “I’d hate to have to take the coins by force, I’m telling you one last time, give them back.”

He revealed a shappy knife and pointed it at Adora. He wasn’t backing down but his hands were shaking, taking in the entirety of his opponent. At her metal armor and blade and wide frame. At the set of her brows and surety in her voice. Adora took a step forward.

She didn't attack him, she would never. But the step had scared him enough to be foolish. He ran backwards and grabbed the closest child in his range, aiming the knife at their throat.

“No!”

The child was weeping, too frozen in terror to try to escape. The man was just as trembling. He stammered in his words as he commanded— begged Adora to go away. To let him go. But Adora couldn't. She couldn't leave any of this. She needed to bring those coins to that child who probably ran away now from his mother's corpse, she couldn't leave this armed man with his knife too close to drawing blood. She needed to stop this, she needed to do something.

She was about to take another step forward, and when he drew the blade even closer, she snapped. She lunged at him with speed he couldn't evade, she struck him by the length of her forearm against his nose bridge, throwing him to the opposite direction. She pulled the now freed child away. She wanted to comfort her but the man was still armed and Adora had to protect her, so she threw nongently to the side as she bounced on the fallen man, taking his knife out of his too weak fist.

Adora was breathing hard as she stood above him with the blade in her hand. It wasn't from the physical exertion, this was nothing compared to what she's been through, this was nothing. And yet her heart was ramming in her chest.

"Please! Please, spare mercy!" The man was openly weeping now at her feet. The coins scattered and forgotten around him. There was no care in his heart now except for his own survival. To live another day. Nothing except for the fear from the woman standing before him with a knife in her fist.

Adora’s eyes were wide at the pitiful display, she looked around her and only then noticed the petrified crowd around her hiding from her and her gaze, all afraid, all scared of her.

“Mercy!” The man begged some more when Adora didn’t step back.

Adora felt sick. She loosened her fist, letting the knife clatter to the dirty floor. She wanted to apologise but she couldn’t speak. She kept her head down as she went on her way outside, her horse silently following her.

She didn’t know how long she was walking but suddenly the sun was touching her face. She hadn’t even noticed how was shrouded in darkness this whole time. Adora felt the urge to cry. But she didn’t, for someone was behind her.

Even with the previous altercations, Adora wasn’t afraid to turn behind and draw her sword at who stood before her. She was always prepared.

It was a woman, who, even as they lay under the sun, was shrouded in shadows. Her attire was rich and her face was masked. The black halo around her signaled her so clearly as a sorcerer. That was what must have covered her tracks, as Adora hadn’t noticed her until she was directly behind her.

Adora didn’t speak and she didn’t lower her sword, she kept at eye point unwavering. Waiting for the sorcerer to make the opening, and she did.

“You possess great strength, warrior.” She drawled in a slithery voice, like poisoned honey dripping through fingers. Sticky and hard to remove. Her words echoed inside Adora's heart, she must be referring to the… fight she was having before.

Lowering her sword but not sheathing it, Adora said in a controlled voice. “That wasn't a display of strength.”

“Perhaps, and yet, those weaker than you cower in your presence. If that wasn’t strength then what is?”

Adora clenched her teeth. Words so familiar echoing inside her head. This exact definition of what strength is drilled inside her cranium, Adora was fostered in it. Of all the things to tie the lands together, false beliefs were the one.

“Can I help you?” She said, already making her way to her horse.

“You can, the question lies in ‘will you’?”

Adora didn’t answer her, but she also didn’t mount her steed. The sorcerer understood that as an invitation to make her offer.

“Your strength is needed inside the castle-city walls and inside the castle. Protecting halfmoon’s most prized possession: its princess.”

Whatever Adora was expecting, it certainly hadn’t involved halfmoon’s royalty.

Adora narrowed her eyes at the sorcerer. Sorcerers weren’t a rarity in Halfmoon, they were second only to magicats when it came to numbers. But royal affairs weren’t a concern to most of them. Most came here for the magical affluence superstitions claimed halfmoon to have and most stuck for the education and scholarly opportunities. So why would a common sorcerer meddle in the princess’s life?

A realisation jolted inside Adora, of news travelling from afar telling her of foreign politics and the latest change in halfmoon’s royal court’s hierarchy.

This was no common sorcerer.

With a voice full of a sleuth’s confidence Adora said, “is that an offer, regent?”

The regent didn’t seem surprised with her discovery and said in a voice with a surely hidden a smile behind her mask. “It’s a

challenge. Will you accept it, warrior?”

In a second Adora can think of a plethora of reasons not to. But another voice was heard, a voice tired of searching with no avail, of adventures and travels and people met and lost. A voice that asked her to entertain the idea that she might find her answer inside Halfmoon's castle after all. Adora listened to that voice.

Adora said with a long lost conviction now found again, “I accept.”

The regent outstretched her hand. It was clad in black silk and the fingers ended in talons. Adora stepped forward and clasped it.

“I’m not a warrior. Not anymore.” She said.

“No,” the regent answered. “You are now a knight.”

The world around them drowned in shadows and darkness.

—♕—

Adora had spent an entire week of her life inside the caste-city and she had still yet to meet the princess. The same princess she was tasked with protecting and never leaving the side of.

Ambiguous excuses have been given to her, but enough for her to get the picture. Halfmoon’s princess was sickly, with a frail delicate body susceptible to illness and fatigue that, in consequence, made her bed-ridden for the majority of her time. The reluctance and secrecy the castle's staff answered her with, led Adora to conclude that they must be ashamed of the fact. That halfmoon, the great gilded queendom that it is, couldn’t offer the necessary medical need for their own beloved princess.

But to ease Adora's confusion and fears, she was told that the princess would most certainly be up and healthy again and enough to make an appearance in less than a fortnight. But not for Adora’s benefit, which she had incredulously guessed at the start, but because they were nearing the princess’s two decade birthday ball. Adora’s arrival was most convenient.

That had explained the castle’s agitation, if one could even call it that. So, Adora, a knight without a princess, had spent that entire week and so doing only two things: exploring and training.

When the regent had teleported them with her shadows to the castle, or rather teleported Adora, for a mere servant stood in the same place in which the regent did a second ago, Adora was utterly shocked by what she saw.

Seeing the look on her face, the servant offered to show Adora the surroundings. Adora had cocked her eyebrow in affront. She was no spoon-fed noblewoman or a preening ambassador brought to be shown the goods. She was a knight, and also a traveler and

explorer, so she'd get her own feel of the land, thank you very much.

Postponing the discovery of what the castle-city offers to other days, Adora had dedicated her first week in halfmoon into exploring only the castle.

Even with the little time she was given, Adora saw enough. She was no stranger to wealth and royalty, but she could see clearly how different halfmoon was. Unlike gray stone and metallic spikes, the castle was colourful and soft. It felt as if it had grown out of the same land it stood upon. From the same soil. Just like a plant, like the flowers covered in the periphery and the palm trees lining passage ways. As if the castle was a living creature, just like them. It certainly was designed like it. There were no closed spaces, at least not in the landscape, for everywhere she walked the sunlight and breeze and floral aroma followed her.

The castle felt alive.

The foundational architecture was glorious enough but what truly characterised halfmoon's royal castle was the art. It was made into every piece. Carved and painted and engraved. Into woods and stone and marble. Into the columns and the window frames and tiles. Into the walls and the doors. Of every color seen by eye. Patterns and designs, some told stories others only showed beauty. The main ones displayed a synergy of geometric and foliate lines. The perfect representation of halfmoon's view on the world.

The Adora of yesteryear would have fawned over the beautiful artistry of it all. But the Adora of today could only see this beauty, this luxury, and remember the hollowed faces of starved children and the leaking eyes of corpse-like men. Instead of awe, all she felt was indignation.

She hadn’t finished half the castle on her first day, she doubted it was a quarter. But bile had risen to her throat and she could feel the sun waning behind her back, so she abandoned her exploration and made way to the tower the servant had pointed at as her new home. An elaborately built tall structure with a gleaming dome at the top.

The princess's tower.

Columns surrounded the garden that surrounded the tower. All leading to the entry arch. A cloud-high curve with leaf-like foils that pointed to the sky. It framed the tower behind it like a picture. The silk clad guards before it didn’t stop Adora when she entered. Either the news of the new royal knight arrivak was spreading quickly or Adora had seriously misjudged the difficulty of her new profession.

Adora had stood before the bejewelled doors of the tower. Knowing that if she crossed the threshold there will be retreat. She crossed the threshold.

The tower was big. Even bigger from the inside, or that must have been an illusionary trick of the spiral. Expectedly, not only she and

the princess resided in here. An entire entourage lived here to care for her highness. Maids and launderesses, cooks and guards.

The tower was assembled by every flooring being centred around an entire part of the princess's comfort, from the kitchens at the bottom to the baths at the top. Like a structured cake, or a tree, or a mountain. And of course, at the peak of the mountain resided the crown princess of halfmoon. Alongside Adora, now.

Upon finally reaching the top flooring, all meanings of the word lavish and its synonyms had sailed over Adora's scale. The princess's wing rivaled the entire castle's grandeur. It was perfectly circular, with closed doors leading to specific duties, the royal knight's chamber was evident, but not as evident as the princess's bed-chamber, which was, even in the literal sky, slightly raised by a dais.

The royal bed-chamber, Adora had come to realise a day later, was not barred by a door like all the other rooms, but by an inky blackness. reflectionless, eerie. Adora once had outstretched her hand to touch it, and it seized her like a living organism, like a parasite. It was clearly some sort of shield.

She had still explored after the first day, for practical and empirical use, to be informed of her surroundings and territory. But her appetite and wonder for more had been swallowed over by the stark difference of what she saw on her first day and where she stood now.

Which meant that, for the remainder of the days, she was only occupied with training. Or rather, the halfmoonian equivalent of it.

When she had arrived at the arsenal, she was supposed to be stripped of all foreignity, that included surface elements like armour and weaponry, but also deeper ones like her entire method of combat.

She did not let them take her sword. She would sooner let them take her hands or feet. Uncompromisablity must have shown in her voice or face, because they did not ask again. It was a good sword. Perfectly straight blade that infarcted the light against it as an irescendent, angular golden hilt with knife sharp wings sprouting from the same center that held a rhombus jewel, long, heavy. Anyone would fight its loss. But no one would do it for the same reason as adora's, no one would even begin to understand.

She relented on the armour part. Let them interchange her years-old red-caped rusted iron with gilded steel, one fashioned into what resembled a ceremonial attire instead of protective covering. Too much space of her body was unarmoured, her joints entirely exposed, the metal too thin. But after all, the native halfmoonians, the magicats, prized their mobility and agility over all forms of strength. Adora understood that, it didn't mean that she liked it. Whether it was applied in armour or in combat.

She had bested every guard who came upon her, both with weaponry and without. And yet the head of the royal guards, who had the regent's blessing to prepare Adora for her duties, criticised her every move. He said she was too heavy, too bulky, too slow, that she puts a solid front but lacks speed, which is needed when one is to protect someone other than oneself. He

said brute strength didn’t belong inside halfmoon’s castle. Adora had challenged him then and one and he told her feet were too attached to the ground. In teeth-gritting anger, all she could think about is how he was much more suited to be a dancer than a fighter.

But she was still under his tutelage, at least for the remainder of the week, and so she obeyed and trained as she was told. Until she finally gained his approval.

After the short-in-number long-in-spirits days, with the new found information of halfmoon and her place in it, Adora accomplished her first step into knighthood.

—♕—

Adora hadn’t slept a wink on the night before the princess’s birth-day ball. It wasn’t unexpected. She barely managed to fall asleep on a regular night. She was accustomed to it by now.

It had used be a problem, in a far and distant past, but now she saw it as an opportunity to make more use of the day. And that’s what she did. She stood up in nothing but her nightgown, grabbed her scabbarded sword and left the tower.

The sun hadn’t shown yet, faint start twinkling on the dark sky in its place, but Adora studied the stars enough to know it would

soon. The garden was abnormally quiet, only the sound of the leaves' rustles and the nocturnal insects were heard.

She had planned on training before she got here, but after finding this quite, this rare stillness, she didn't want to undo it. She felt like she was standing over a mirror-like straight lake, with a rock in her hand. Adora was tired over feeling like this. Tired with having rocks in her hands.

She lay her body and sword on the tilework, savouring the ambience she was in. The quiet before the storm. The knowledge that tomorrow, Adora of nowhere would die and Adora of halfmoon will be birthed in her place. She wasn't sure she loved that.

She closed her eyes.

Adora didn't know the exact duration of her closing her eyes, but when she opened them again, the sun's light blinded her and the noise of the servants in disarray pulled to her feet in panic. She raced back to the tower.

"Where have you been?" The chilling voice of the regent held Adora's heart in her throat. She stood at the second-top flooring: the one with the baths and dressing rooms. Appearance slightly more elegant with her high necked dress and adorned mask.

“Below, in the garden. Training.” Adora hoped her voice wasn’t as shaky as her heart. She hadn’t planned over sleeping in the garden. She hoped that wasn’t a sign of what the rest of her day would be like. She took her leave when the regent nodded and dashed to her chamber. Adora was thankful over her experience of armouring herself in seconds. She braided her hair high, adjusted her sword’s scabbard at her hip and returned back to the regent’s place.

The regent wasn’t all that interested in admonishing her disorder further, or if she was, she didn’t have that chance, because something much more interesting pulled her attention.

The dressing room doors opened and the princess walked.

She stood before them. Her retinue of servants and maids, bowing their heads behind her. They almost looked as if to form an arrow, with the point being the princess, aiming at the regent and Adora.

The princess was the most beautiful thing Adora had ever seen.

She wore a dress of brightest red, ruby-red, chrysanthemum-red, the same red as Adora's old cape. It was deeply cut, showing the freckles on her chest circling her heart like stars, exposing the peach-fuzz brown skin of her upper back and neck. The rest of her body was engulfed in red. Red sleeves falling from bony shoulders and pooling around elbows and hands, red skirts swishing with minute movements like butterfly wings, red bodice with paintings embodied into it.

So much red, with gold and turquoise. In fact, every jewellery she wore seemed to be made of gold with a turquoise gem at the centre. Her necklace, her bangles, her rings, her earrings, even the cuff at the tip of her tail.

Her hair was the color of oak tree, and looked just as rich and luscious. Half of it was free to curl downwards like thick vines, and the other half was braided and twisted and pinned with golden beads and gems around her head like a crown.

And atop it all, lay her crown.

The regent moved above the air slowly, even slower than what Adora managed to see so far, towards the princess.

Adora stood as still as a statue. She was in foreign terrain, standing between the two most important people in this entire queendom, she needed more information before thinking of engaging.

The regent circled the princess like a crow, deliberately and non-stopping, Tugging on fabric, adjusting gold. She then stood directly in front of her. The princess had her face bowed down all through the examination and before it. Not as deeply as maids did, but deep enough to raise alarms when considering the fact that she was the princess.

The regent placed a sharply-ended finger underneath the princess’s chin and slowly but surely tilted it up to face her. The difference in altitude was too high, Adora wondered if her neck ached from the uncomfortable posture, if it did, the princess didn’t show.

She couldn’t see her entire face from this angle, but she could catch a glance of shining face paint. Gold was scattered like powder over her freckles, her lips were painted as red as her dress, and from what she can see from eye, red as well with black swirls following her eyelid and circling the sides of her face like tendrils and palmettes.

The regent held the princess’s face in her grip for too long, searching for something in her eyes. When she found it, or gave up on it, she neared her and said in a cold voice, “behave.”

She nodded and the regent released the princess’s face. She turned back swiftly to Adora, “Your knighthood starts today. You mustn’t leave her side at all times. Do not disappoint me or yourself.” She vanished in a flare of black flames.

Immediately afterwards, Adora turned to face the princess. She froze.

The princess was already looking at her, expression blank due to the helmet’s anonymity. If she saw Adora's face she’d most certainly flinch at the utter shock plastered on it. The princess looked at her with eyes slightly narrowing, with eyes Adora had

seen before. Eyes she hadn’t forgotten. Eyes she never hoped to find again.

A shade of blue and yellow, of the sky and sun, of the sea and sand, of turquoise and gold.

Familiar eyes.

The princess squirmed a little at her faceless knight's stonish posture and silent, unapologetic gaping. Adora quickly fixed her stand when she noticed. She had so many thoughts and questions raging inside her, but this wasn’t the right time. In honesty, this was the worst possible time. So she pushed aside old fond memories and locked them in a box. Tonight she has a job to do, a task, a role to play. And she won’t fail.

—♕—

“Announcing: the arrival of the crown princess of the Queendom of Halfmoon. The heir apparent and first in order of succession to the throne. Last standing descendants of the lineage of the queens, and last survivor of the halfmoonian royal family. Future Queen. Her highness, princess c’yra the third!”

The announcer’s voice rang painfully loud even through the thick stone of the ballhall's doors, but it was no match to the receptive acclamation and applause of the awaiting guests. The princess’s birth-day was a nationwide day of celebration. All were invited to

the castle, not just the halfmoonian royal court and nobility, even those who had lived their whole lives behind the castle-city's walls were allowed entry. Of course many would lose their sanity over meeting or even seeing the true face of their princess.

The doors opened to reveal the princess, her royal knight, and her entourage behind her and the applause did the impossible and increased in volumes. Adora barely kept her posture firm, accompanying facial control wasn't needed due to her helmet so she was free to grimace and wince at the volume of the guests. She wondered how the princess kept her stillness, especially considering the enhanced auditory perception of her species.

And yet she was as still and kept together as a sculpture, even as the volume increased when she took a step towards her throne.

It only began to quiet down when she began ascending the steps and by the time she had finally sat on her throne. The hall was silent. Except for the sound of hundreds of knees falling to the decorative tiles.

The explicit display of love and respect compelled even Adora to kneel down to her princess. She didn't, though. Her place was half a step behind her throne and that's where Adora stood.

The familiar voice of the announcer bellowed down the hall, "let the celebrations begin!"

And so they did.

Almost immediately everyone in halfmoon of every profession came to bow down the princess's throne and do their deeds. Most were poets, coming from all over the world but also not far to boast their literary talents by boasting about the princess's gifts, most usually: her beauty. By the twentieth time, Adora had begun to grow bored, they weren't even original. They were repeating each other like parrots. More than half said the same thing: she was a flower in the garden, she was a star in the sky, her eyes were jewels whom her crown grew jealous of and her skin was molten gold. Adora curled her lip at the last poet who attempted to catch the princess's hands as he boasting about the sensuality of her body, luckily, for him not Adora, the guards at the bottoms of the steps stopped him before Adora had to intervene, she almost regretted it.

Aside from the poets, the wealthy came bearing gifts. Most were from halfmoon's aristocracy but also many were ambassadors and merchants of foreign lands bettering their relationship with halfmoon by bettering halfmoon's gold. Which was what most brought: gold. So much gold. The majority was in the form of jewellery, to adorn the princess's hands and feet and head, but some were as devices and trinkets, and few simply showed her wooden chests overflowing with golden coins. But gold wasn't their only gift, they brought fabrics, silk and velvet, spices and food, books and scrolls, inventions and puzzles. They seemed infinite and Adora thought they will never stop coming until an official guided them to another place for storing the gifts.

Adora thought about the starving and cold bodies she saw on her first day here and wondered if someone else in this room thought the same.

The hours passes like this. C'yra the princess sitting, Adora the knight standing and halfmoonians making excuses just to gaze upon the princess.

Scholars. Politicians. Noblewomen and noblemen. Jesters. Farmers. Merchants.

Until suddenly the unnoticed music of the background had changed into something more… conspicuous.

The sea of guests parted and were guided into the perimeters as the regent made her way towards the throne. With the same slowness she exercised with the princess hours before. She knelt down, albeit nowhere near as deeply as others did and outstretched her hand, black-clad palm upwards.

Adora wished to see the princess's face but that would require taking a step forward to do so, so she didn't. It would've been fruitless anyway, almost instantly the princess stood and took the regent's hand in hers.

Adora almost walked forward to join them but a sharp tilt of the regent's masked face commanded her to stand still, and begrudgingly, she did. She stood as still as a mountain with nothing of its might inside her heart. She watched them walk towards the center of the hall before standing directly before each other. The music ended sharply, and began anew.

They started dancing.

It was an eerie sight. Their hands were clasped together on their right and their left arms held each other's backs, it was supposed to be a dance of equal footings, but the way the regent towered over the princess resembled a snake. Their skirts were mixing together as they floated over the painted floor. Both fabrics of the color red, the color of blood, but while the regent's was dark and long-ago dried, the princess's belonged to a freshly drawn wound.

Everyone in halfmoon had their eyes trained as they watched the most powerful women in the queendom dance. Time had slowed down during their dance but also it had stopped as soon as it started, Adora blinked and princess C'yra was already making her way to the throne.

She looked as motionless as she was before, to anyone but Adora. The sleeves had ridden over her wrist when she put them on the throne arms and Adora could see the tips of her clawed hand trembling.

She couldn't talk, not without catching eyes so she made the next closest thing. She feigned inspection of her sword which allowed to take a half a step forward and with her armoured hand. she swiftly and gently pulled the sleeve down to cover the princess's shaking hand.

She heard a small gasp, but she didn’t turn around and Adora didn’t want her to in the first place.

It was pointless though, because immediately afterwards another knelt at the throne’ dais and extended his hand.

Adora knew him, just as she knew the six others standing behind him. Not directly of course, but she had to learn about the castle she’s to work in. The halfmoon’s council, the largest portion of halfmoon’s royal court. It was composed of seven seats, seven councillors. And apparently it was tradition that, after the regent, they were owed their time with the princess.

The councillor of war held his hand for princess c’yra to take, she took it, they danced, she sat back in her chair. The same cycle ran for seven times.

The council of education was immediately after, and then the councillor of health, then the councillor of indstruy, the councillor of finance, the councillor of lands, and finally was the councillor of culture.

Something about the display, about each councillor acting as if they were exceptional to be awarded this, about the way they moved their hands, about the way they’d tilt their heads close by and whisper, made Adora incredibly sick.

When the princess made her way to the throne for the final time, the cracks in her facade began to show, and Adora truly couldn't blame her.

How much time has passed, it felt too long and also too short. Adora waited patiently for the feast, not due to any hunger, she doubted she could eat anything tonight, but because she knew that would be the closing act of the ball.

The end can not come any faster.

—♕—

Adora hadn't slept a wink on the night after the princess's birthday ball. It wasn't unexpected but still frustrating, she wanted to sleep, her muscles arched from standing in metal armour for hours doing absolutely nothing.

She had been laying in her bed, eyes shut and body immobile, for hours now, and yet sleep evaded her. Her mind just kept rehearsing the events of the day in her mind. Too much had happened but also not enough, Adora felt as if she learned something but also as if she was knew less than before, it was so consuming, all of it. One thing was clear, though, she cannot let her guard down.

She was about to bolt upright in bed and scream into the night when she heard them. Footsteps. In retrospect, being awake

turned out to be a good thing.

Adora hadn’t closed her chamber door completely, the ajar part transported the sound perfectly to her ears. She stood to inspect it, and when she opened her door fully, she gasped.

The inky blackness in place of a door of the princesses bed-chamber was gone. Disappeared, with no trace at all. It left the princess’s chambers completely unguarded. Adora crept slowly with an unease brewing inside her and almost bolted inside when she saw no trace of her.

“Your highness?” She called from the threshold. The princess didn’t answer, no one did. Adora began panicking by the second. After checking every chamber in the wing and finding them empty she began to climb down the tower.

She went first to the kitchens, hoping that the princess must have just had the nightly desire for a snack. It was empty. Just as every other level of the tower until she finally reached the bottom.

Adora was entirely panicking now. Should she alert someone? The regent? Something about the ball dance made her reluctant to do so. She realised that no, she shouldn’t, this was a matter concerning the princess' safety and protecting, in other words, adora’s matter, adora’s responsibility.

She knew what to do.

After she sheathed her sword at her hip, she ran under the cover of the night across the garden, through the arche, and to the castle's stables. Swift-wind was asleep, as she suspected he would be, she almost felt guilty waking him up but she had to, more than a year on foot, taught her the importance of his superior olfactory capability. If she wanted to find the princess before anyone else knew of her disappearance, she'd need him.

If anyone was to walk inside the stables, he would find Adora silently staring at her horse, and the horse neighing randomly. But nothing about the interaction was random. Unbeknownst to any who'd walk in, an entire conversion was carried between her and him. One needless of words and syllables, she explained her urgency and he immediately stood and let her mount him. When he outstretched his wings and took off, Adora resisted the urge to look around wearily, unicorns were rare in etheria, alicorns even more so. She couldn't count on her fingers the amount of offers she was told in exchange of him.

She banished that thought for now, she needed all her attention focused on finding the princess at the moment. Swift-wind scored around the entirety of the castle-city with no avail, but before Adora would lose hope he stopped mid-air with an enthusiastic neigh.

Adora's smile fell to the abyss instantly when she realised what she was looking at. Unbeknownst to many, the castle-city walls were not perfectly circular, an entire portion of the circle had supplied the stone walls with mighty trees.

The trees of the whispering woods.

Adora knew of the whispering woods, everyone did. A forest line stretching in the middle of the etherian continent. It separated queendoms and lands. Whoever dared to travel inside never came back to tell the tale, it was said the laws of nature and creation were abandoned inside that forest. Suffice to say, Adora wasn't particularly ecstatic at the idea of entering it.

She checked twice with swift-wind to confirm this was the right place, he was sure. Adora sighed but made her way inside, she never disbelieved swift-wind and she wouldn't start now.

She left him behind, scouring the forest alone would be a difficult task, bringing a horse twice her size would just exacerbate that. She realised the stupidity of her act a minute into the forest and the realisation that she was lost now.

This has been a long day, with uncertainty and unexpectedness from start to finish. She was exhausted, and her body wouldn't sleep, and her princess wouldn't stay in one place for long. And now Adora is spending the first day of knighthood scouring a mythical forest with nothing but flimsy nightwear and a sword for a reckless princess.

All in all, she was content to just give up, resign, lay on the grass floor and let nature and fungi take over her body and use her for something that would actually better the world so much more than Adora ever did, but then she heard it.

A laugh, unsure and watery, as if its owner was surprised to laugh at something at all.

Adora followed that laugh like a song, like a guiding ballad, like a pirate to sea, she didn't know what she would find in its place but all options would be better than this colorless flavourless nothing.

She found the princess.

It was true, she was laughing. Her face was smeared with tears but she was laughing nonetheless. A… lion was nuzzling her face. Adora wasn't in any means an expert in animal life but she was sure she had never seen this creature ever, and neither did anyone else. It clearly resembled a feline creature, but there were too distinct features that distinguished it from all that Adora knew. Itts colourful complexion was too unnatural and its size too large. It was almost as big as the princess as it bounced on her, nuzzling and licking her face and making her laugh.

Faintly, Adora remembered the stories of the creatures inside the whispering woods being so different from anything from the outside, but she had abandoned that train thought at that point as she gazed at the princess.

She was wearing a simple nightgown with a silk robe for the cold, her face was bare and her hair unbound in wild curls, but she looked so much more beautiful than she did in the ball. There was happiness in her face, pure happiness and joy, her laugh was loud

and uncontrolled, too different from the practiced smiles she put on for hours ago. Adora could look and listen to her laugh for ages.

Like a woman bewitched she took a step forward.

Both woman and creature startled in fright, the princess's laugh was replaced with a sharp gasp and Adora's heart ached for the loss, before realising what she'd done.

The princess was looking at her with wide fearful eyes, body leaning away from her, and her companion growled in front of her at Adora. As soon as it did, the princess shooed it away and took off running deeper into the woods.

"Wait!" Adora called after her, confused by the reaction, before realising that the princess hadn't actually seen her face before. To her she was just an armoured stranger finding her in a secluded area of a forest no one would find her in.

Adora grimaced at how terrifying this whole situation must be to her, but even as she raced after her, she couldn't think of another alternative.

She was fast, so much faster than expected, Adora had fought battles and she struggled to keep up, she knew that if she kept one Adora would lose stamina and the princess would find herself lost inside the whispering woods deep ends. So she took initiative.

Digging her heels inside the soil, she jumped as high as she could and collided with the princess, dragging her down with her in a tangled mess of limbs.

They tackled and tumbled on the grass floor like children. Princess C'yra wasn't a fighter, that was clear from the start, but her claws were sharp and Adora preferred her eyeballs ungouged.

She tightened her grip on the princess's wrist and pinned them before her skull, and yet, she didn't stop fighting. Adora knew she wouldn't stop until she learned Adora wasn't a threat. She clearly didn't remember Adora from years ago.

"Look! Look!" It was a mighty feat for Adora to keep the princess' wrists in her grip with one hand and the other pulling her sword to show her the insignia and design. She must at least remember from before. She had to.

She did. As soon as the princess caught sight of the sword, she relaxed. Limbs stopped flaying, she met Adora's eyes and after seeing the recognition there, Adora undid her grip.

Princess C'yra's eyes narrowed immediately and with thunder-speed she jutted her knee between Adora's legs violently, as if this was a tavern fight.

She climbed to her feet quickly while Adora lay groaning in pain.

“Do not touch me!”

Adora wanted to reply, to say ‘yes’ and ‘of, course’ but even without her nursing her bruised crotch and bruised ego, she was in shock of hearing the princess’s voice and then in even more shock as she realised she hadn’t heard it not once during the entire ball. The princess had not talked during the entire night, ever, and Adora hadn’t noticed. She wondered if anyone else noticed.

With a scowl and glare, princess C’yra was content to leave Adora on the forest ground and made her way to the opening of the whispering woods.

“Wait! The whispering woods are dangerous.” Adora climbed groggily to her feet and followed her. She must protect her.

“Really?” Princess C’yra drawled. She had been walking ahead at that point but she turned around now to show Adora her sardonic smile. “And you’re here to protect me, I suppose? My hero.”

Adora twitched at the mocking tone, “Yes. If you haven’t noticed, I am your knight. You’re my responsibility.”

“You're right! Lead the way then, knight.” She then stepped aside and looked at Adora with clearly fake innocent expectation.

Adora spared her a glare and then stared ahead. She had no idea where they were, nevertheless how to get back. After a minute of Adora frowning silently into the distance, the princess cackled and began walking forward. Adora dejectedly followed.

"Even if you know the directions, you mustn't wander here, especially alone, especially at night."

"And why is that?" She clearly wasn't interested in the conversation, attention focused on getting back to the castle. But Adora still bristled at the clear carelessness.

"Because— you're the princess! You have a responsibility, and I do too, as your knight. You're my responsibility. I need to know your whereabouts, at all times."

The princess stopped walking, and then slowly she turned to face Adora with a stony face. She sneered at her, "Wow, you are clearly very dedicated."

Adora spluttered a reply, face surely red with agitation. But the princess interrupted her before she could even speak. "How did you find me anyway? I thought you were asleep, and even if not, you didn't follow me, I would have noticed otherwise."

As upset as she is by the clear topic change, she was glad over the possibility of them having a civil conversation. “My horse, he tracked you.”

“I’ve never met him, how could he even do that?”

“He’s… different.” She said and supplied no other explanation.

The princess looked at her blankly before she turned and continued walking.

Speaking of animal companions. “Where did your lion go?”

“Away.” And nothing else.

Alright. Adora then remembered the state she found the princess in, crying and then laughing. Surely not something needed to be done here of all places. She has an entire castle. “What were you doing here, anyway?”

She was silent.

“Was there something you wanted to find? Something you can only do here?”

More silence.

"How was the ball? Did you enjoy it?"

Even more silence.

"Listen!" Adora wasn't foolish enough to grab the princess after the previous altercation but she did stand before her and blocked her path. "I know you're the princess of this entire queendom and have the highest authority and can do whatever your heart desire. But I am your knight. I need to be by your side, no matter what."

"And what if I want to visit the whispering woods in the dead of the night?"

"Then, take me with you."

Princess c'yra's eyes, which where filled with venom when she uttered her question widened in surprise, the venom evaporating. She then narrowed them, not in anger like before. But in curiosity, in examination, she gazed at adore from head to toe and then back. Adora didn't know what she was searching for, or what she found. She hoped it was good.

Finally she said, “You are certainly different from the other knights.”

Adora looked at her expertly for an answer.

The princess rolled her eyes at the clear expectation but still said afterwards, “Alright.”

Adora smiled in relief on the outward, but beamed like a child inward. She didn’t why this felt like such an accomplishment, she simply succeeded in convincing the princess who she was the knight of to actually treat her like her knight.

Adora felt like she needed to say something. But she was reluctant to show her enthusiasm so early, instead she settled on a civil introduction.

“I’m Adora.”

The princess’s eyebrow rose at that, Adora felt a slight disappointment settle in her over the fact that not even her name would spark recognition but then it soared in happiness when the princess smiled at her, not like the rehearsed ones in the ball, not like the mocking ones of before, just a small genuine smile. “Of?”

“Of nobody and nowhere.”

Princess C'yra didn't react as Adora expected. Instead she said, "My name is Catra, also of nobody and nowhere."

There was no doubt inside Adora, she would know those eyes in every universe, but still hearing that name a second made her heart pulse. She didn't ask for more clarification, she knew she heard it right and if that's what the princess— Catra wanted to be called then her wish is Adora's command.

"Alright, Catra. Let's go home."

—♕—

Halfmoon was the first foreign land Adora had ever set foot in. She was a decade old, ecstatic by the promise of freedom and adventure, and of finding herself in a paradise.

Everything she had laid eyes on was colorful and bright and shiny. Everything was beautiful, and for the longest time she had thought the whole world was like this.

She was betwetched by the beauty of it all and suddenly found herself in the most beautiful forest in the world. Plants she had never seen before, animals she never knew existed. It was the best day of her life.

Day turned into night, and Adora realised she did not know the way back home.

She was brave, had always been told so, so she did the brave and mature thing. She held her tears back and called for names, called for help. She marked her trails and memorised her path. And yet she didn't get any closer to home.

She was crying by then, and due to the tear-induced blurriness she couldn't see ahead and bumped into someone. But instead of Adora falling to the ground, as most cases were, the someone in question had that fate.

"Watch your step!" She said. But Adora barely heard it. She was looking at the most beautiful girl in the world, and by ten Adora had seen many beautiful girls. She had stars on her face, multicolored suns in her eyes, her hair was a cloud around her head. She was the night sky in person. Adora couldn't stop staring, her mouth rendered useless.

The most beautiful girl in the world didn't have that problem. "Why are you crying?" She asked.

Adora's face had reddened with shame. She must have seemed like a crying baby who couldn't find her own way home. In a too low voice, she mumbled, "I'm lost."

The most beautiful girl in the world didn't laugh at her instead she beamed with pride and said, "I'm not! I can help you." And for once, Adora didn't feel ashamed for help, not when it made her this happy.

She gave her hand so they don't get separated and Adora clasped it instinctively.

With her, the night didn't seem as scary, the stars were twinkling like diamonds, the owl calls were melodic, the trees looked soft, the whole world revolved around Adora and her.

When they reached the end of the forest, the most beautiful girl in the world turned to Adora and said, "I'm Catra!"

What a beautiful name for a beautiful girl.

With a matching enthusiast tone, Adora had said, "I'm Adora."

She needed to go back now but she couldn't leave the most beautiful— Catra behind so she said, "can I see again?"

"If you want. I'm always in the whispering woods. You can find me here, if you want."

Adora pouted at that but then cheered herself up. "I'm leaving, but don't worry I'll come back! and I'll find you here!"

Catra smiled brightly and asked, "promise?"

"I promise."

Chapter 2: Alstromeria

Chapter Summary

> The flowering buds of friendship are blooming, but not flawlessly.

Chapter Notes

> Hello once again friends! I'm so happy to see you again. I thank you again from the bottom of my heart for sharing this story with me and I wish so deeply that you'd like this chapter.
>
> Onward!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora had needed only two days to fail.

After her, true, first acquaintance with princess c'yra and her second one with Catra, she found herself in an odd place. Pulled into two opposite paths, where at the end of each laid a mirror reflecting a different image of herself.

One mirror reflected Adora the knight. Armed and armoured. Embodying the knightly virtues to their fullest. Chivalrous. A shield and a weapon. She would shelter her princess from all the horrors of the world. Posture always rigid, eyes always attentive, sword always drawn, face always covered, mind always occupied with the mission to protect, protect, protect.

In the other mirror was Adora the friend. Sword sheathed and helmet deposited. She would sprawl instead of stand. Face and body as open as her soul. Her knighthood replaced by play and jest. Adventures to make the heart beat and eyes sparkle. Smiles and laughs and promises.

She knew which would make her the happiest, but Adora's desires have never been the first priority. While she’s distracted by the promise of friendship in paradise, she might lose her princess. No. Safety took precedence, the princess’s safety, catra’s safety.

So Adora chose the safe option.

She had only realised the error in her choice when she realised her princess’s misery. The realisation in question occurred due to the statement being explicitly said to her.

She had suspected something during their alicorn ride. When Adora suggested swift-wind as a method of visiting the whispering woods, Catra was convinced by the reasoning of the decreased time and effort spent. In the first time, she was terrified, as all would be. Her eyes tightly shut against the open sky and claws almost digging into the white coat. In the second time, relieved with the knowledge that they were safe from plummeting to their death from Adora’s steed’s back, she was ecstatic, her arms were lifted up to hug the clouds and her loud laughs were echoing across the clearance. Adora’s cheeks had hurt from smiling that morning.

In the third and current time, she was neither. She was clearly nowhere near as happy as before but fear must not be the cause of her distress. Adora had never been a master of solving the puzzle that was emotions and feelings, so she hoped Catra would simply just tell her what was wrong.

She did.

As soon as swift-wind’s hooves touched solid ground, she dismounted and whipped round to face adora. “Why are you being like this?!” She asked in demand.

Adora was at a loss for words. They had just woken up, the sun’s light had yet to illuminate the entire blue sky. She could not begin to remember the heinous crime she committed to render her princess this upset. “I’m afraid I don’t understand, your highness.”

“Stop calling me that!” She almost shouted. “I told you my name for a reason. And I know you do understand!”

Adora truly did not. So as an instinct, she apologised and bowed deeply. It did not have the desired effect; the princess groaned loudly and sank to the ground in defeat, curling into herself with her back against a tree bark and her tail around her ankles.

Adora winced at the clear portrayal of despondency before her eyes. It was the complete opposite of what the princess would embody inside the woods.

From what she had seen so far, Catra inside the castle was an entirely different person from the one inside in the whispering woods. She would transform from a swan to a hummingbird, from carved statue to a marble ball. For the one thing, she would never remain still inside the forest, the way she did inside the tower, she would run as fast as the wind that ruffled her hair until Adora would lose sight of her or she would climb the tree branches higher higher to reach the clouds with Adora beneath her readying her arm for rescue in the case of a fall.

Or, if she was too exhausted from the early morning, would simply lie down atop the grass floor. Her limbs free from strings and stretched out like a starfish. Her brown curls and the white lacy ruffles of her nightgown pooling around her like a lake. Face tired and sleepy but smiling.

No matter the activity her friend would always appear, to nuzzle her face and rub against her torso with loud purring and strong kneading, the affection dripping from his display. Evidently, he was named melog, by himself, and he was not a lion or a cat. He was like all the other creatures in the whispering woods, beyond imagination. Gazelles, squirrels, rabbits, ducks, frogs, butterflies, owls, all were too colourful and winged and many-eyed as if they were conjured from a dream.

And they all would be drawn to Catra like ants to sugar. In fact, even excluding Adora, Catra was never alone inside the

whispering woods. All the creatures of the sky and earth would circle her like loyal planets, finding warmth and life inside the curve of her palms and slope of her shoulders and the crown of curls atop her head, even the grass and small flowers would bloom faster around her figure, the entire woods seemed to shine with her as their star.

Nothing shined now. Catra hid her light and happiness and face in the crevices of her elbows, her sadness tainting her surroundings, no animal appeared or sounded and petals fell to the ground dry.

It was Adora's fault so she had to fix it.

She made her way to Catra rubbing her wrists, unsure. It hadn't been a full week and Adora was failing on every aspect of her mission. Both, she was disobeying the regent, and upsetting the princes. She didn't know what to do. She needed someone to tell her, so she asked.

"Your highness," she called as soon as she sat down.

Catra remained silent and unmoving, so Adora changed tactics.

"Catra."

An amber eye appeared between skin and hair.

"I'm sure this must be not what you would want to hear, but I truly don't know what I did wrong, can you tell me?" Adora's voice was as bare and shaky as her body. She left the tower with nothing but her nightgown and her sword, she didn't even braid her hair, the air flowed against her bare arms and inside the hollowness of her chest and made her shiver.

Catra's eyes were widened with incredulousness, then narrowed in suspicion, then softened in understanding, than narrowed again but in determination. "Alright." She began her explanation. "I have kept my word. You, on the other hand, didn't allow me the same courtesy."

Adora’s face must have shown how confused she still was, because Catra rolled her eyes before continuing talking.

“I allowed you to accompany everywhere and have not run off outside of her sight, I obliged. But you did the opposite. I have given you my true name, and yet you refuse to use it. I have said that you're different from the other knights and yet you seem fixated on proving me wrong.” She added with sincerity. “You’ve been cold, and hard. Rock-like.”

A puzzle was having its pieces fitting into place inside adora’s mind, but one piece remained unknown. “So… I suppose you do want me to be different?”

“Yes! Well, no. I want you as what you’ve been before. When we met. Not this act that I know you’ve been performing.”

“But— I shouldn’t be different. I’m your knight!” This was just like their first argument and Adora had no clue on how to teach her or make her understand.

“You can still be that, just” her tone was firm at the start but grew softer at the end until she whispered. “…more.”

More. Adora’s heart began racing. She knew this feeling: wishfulness, hope. It was dangerous. But so very tempting, like the yellow pitcher, the venus flytrap. She shouldn’t, goddess knows she shouldn’t. But she couldn’t not ask. So she took a deep breath and willed her voice to be as straight and detached as possible.

“Like,” she took a second and deeper breath and finally asked, “a friend?”

Catra managed to pull her open eyes enough to meet adora’s and with cheeks reddened like cherries, nodded.

Adora gasped. Too loudly, one would say. But who could blame her. The wish she’s been drowning, the wish that’s been stubbornly resurfacing, was shared. In the nights where Adora

would dream of being catra's friend, Catra was dreaming the same thing. It felt too good to be true or real. But it was!

Adora spent too much time inside her head that Catra registered her gasp and her followed silence as rejection. She stood up to leave.

"No! Wait!" She copied her and rose to her feet to stand before her, "I— I want that too. I do want to be your friend." She said with all the longing in her heart.

Catra's eyes gleamed and her smile grew, but her happiness was halted by Adora's interruption.

"But," she held a finger. "We must consider all aspects of this, clarify details. Determine exactly what each party means."

To adora's relief, Catra chuckled at her sternness. "Party. 'this' meaning our friendship. You make it sound like some official agreement."

Catra's smile was contagious. "I would love for it to be an official agreement." Adora realised the scary forcefulness in her words and quickly added. "If you would too, of course."

"Don't worry." Catra was smiling, and shining. Which made the whole forest shine. They were standing directly in front of each other, brown and blonde strands hair swinging from the wind and curling against each other to blend, they were so close, close enough to touch, close enough to breathe in each other's aroma, close enough to… "I do."

Adora beamed.

—♕—

They have spent little time in the whispering woods afterwards. Whatever Catra would seek inside it every dawn must have been found quickly this time. She was much warmer during the alicorn ride home. That is, until her feet touched the decorative tiles and

her eyes gazed at the door leading to the outside of her chambers.

It was like a drop of ink slowly staining a fabric, Adora could see it in her eyes, in the droppings of eyelids and tightness of lips, the resignation. The bone-deep knowledge of your hatred of something and of your inability to step away from it combined.

Every day would start the same. Catra would wake up to find Adora already awake, they'd ride swift-wind to the whispering woods, Catra would find joy there and Adora would look at her as she does and then they'd get back to the tower of princess c'yra. Where Catra would spend hours becoming a princess and Adora would spend minutes becoming a knight.

The flooring directly underneath the princess's was reserved only for washing and dressing, cleansing and beautifying. Body purified in the cinder-hot baths every morning, hot enough to vaporise any remnant of the outside world from skin and filled with rose water until its aroma was burrowed deep inside every crevice of the princess's body until she smelled more flower than human. Hair oiled by olives and brushed by delicate hands into perfect brown ringlets. Silk and satin and velvet, golden rings and turquoise jewels, paint and powder and wax, body and face rejecting flesh and meat and contorted into embellished ceramic and porcelain.

Every morning.

It did not surprise Adora to see Catra glaring at the door in contempt, or walking towards it anyway. She wished to cheer her, but she had no inclination of how.

Fortunately, Catra did. A hand away from the door, she turned to face Adora with the bright gleam of a new idea in her eyes. "If you still want to, we could write it all down during my lessons. Our official arrangement, as you said. There may not be any power in it, but I'd say written words are powerful enough."

Adora was blown away by her princess. "That's a wonderful idea!"

With a smile as a reply, Catra took her leave.

During her first day, Adora had followed her. She sat inside the steaming rooms with fragrant scents in silence, Catra took pity on her reddened head and consistent sneezes and ordered her to stay outside the door, and adora of course obeyed, she would don herself in the meantime.

The thin and fine armour was still foreign to her. The gossamer silk in the sleeves and legs underneath it all. The feather-light and intricately carved gilded steel of her cuirass, pauldrons, vambraces, gauntlets, poleyns, greaves, sabatons. Her chain-mail skirt. Her, of course, helmet. Like everything in halfmoon, her armour was made to be seen more than used.

Adora was, after quickly braiding her hair, finished, using a sixth of the time Catra would need. So she bruised herself, on the balcony at the top of the tower, she duelled the morning air. She can always depend on this, her sword and her fists, to silence her head and make the time fly. In the blink of eye, Catra emerged.

She was beautiful. That was not compliment, but an accurate observation. A goal achieved from the hours and the servant's hands and the wealth. The princess would differ slightly in appearance from a day to another, but some things did not. The uppermost of her back and chest was always bare, contrasted sharply with the rest, with her hands and wrists concealed underneath the billowing sleeves and her legs underneath the even more billowed skirts. Her jewellery was always of gold chains and torquise beads, fashioned into circles and half circles of the moon overlapping. Her hair was always halved. Her crown was always atop her head. And, the most surprisingly, she always wore red. No matter the shade, light or dark, it will always be red.

Halfmoonians embodied their connection to the moon in their houses and their papers and their bodies, they colored their clothes in its light and dark. Most of the royal court wore white or silver or blue or, rarely, black. And yet, Catra was always seen in red.

Red was beautiful on her, anyway.

“You look beautiful.” Adora’s mouth said while her head whispered, Friends must compliment one another, right?

Catra gave a tart smile at that and said, “I sure hope so.” before leaving her chambers for the day.

An enveloped letter on a platter would find them. The detailed itinerary of the princess for the day. Adora had gathered enough information to realise that catra’s royal duties consisted of only two, equally cut, chores. Studies, and socials.

Socials took precedence, and Catra’s mastery over them took Adora's breath away.

Adora was never a friend of words, of using her voice to defeat her enemies, she wasn’t even an acquaintance. She preferred the sword over the pen, the fist over the rhetoric. She had always thought it a lesser form of victory, but seeing Catra wielding her tongue so elegantly and triumphantly, she had no choice but to question.

Halfmoon’s royal court was Catra’s battlefield, and from what Adora had yet to seen, she always arose victorious.

All battles will be held in her own territory, her own tower. Whether in the many halls and rooms inside or in the refreshing breeze of her great gardens. Her opponents would the ones come to visit her.

The easiest opponents to defeat were the courtiers, the nobel-women, duchesses and countesses and baronesses and marchionesses, or as Adora saw them, leech worms in wealthy fabric and gleaming gems, hiding sharp teeth in smiles and poison in honeyed words. Sadly for them, Catra did the exact same. Adora saw it with her own eyes, the way she will rope their desire to get closer and closer to the crown and dangle them over their heads like bait, the guaranteed power of being the future queen’s entrusted luring them like honey does to the bear, just to pull it

back swiftly and harshly, with a sharp smile and heavy eyes to show them who actually stood higher. It was easy, she had fun during it.

Difficulty increased in level slightly but clearly when the nobility were exchanged by the highest authority outside the throne: the halfmoon royal council.

Catra would have to adapt instead of using the same war tactic as before. Councillors were ruthless, and prideful, and worst of all, powerful.

The councillor of education would drink tea with Catra inside the library she bought for her, preening her own feathers as she boasted about her generosity in providing Catra with the best of books and scrolls and the best of teachers. She was old, in her prime, mind as sharp as her ringed claws. Catra would thank her and simultaneously deem her gift useless by saying how no one in all of the land, even after reading all the books and hearing all the teachers, would begin to compare to you and your wit, dear councillor.

The councillor of war was volatile and eager to please, he was the only man with a seat, a fact echoed alongside the rumors of his position being acquired due to his familial link to the previous councillor of war. Catra would be colder with him, feigning indifference no matter the militaristic feats his armies would achieve defending their borders. It kept him meek and humble.

The councillor of culture was a geriatric woman rumoured to have grown up alongside Catra’s grand-mother. If one as to ask Adora she would say that she was the nicest. Excluding how she would look at princess c’yra the third and only see the late queen c’yra the second. She would praise the deceased queen’s wisdom and beauty, while simultaneously denouncing her martial choice being a knight instead of another royal. She would finish her monologue with reminding and encouraging Catra to be just like her mother. Catra hardly spoke during.

And that’s how she operated. Switching masks and acts, a masquerade were she was the actor and the creator and the viewer. The diplomacy, the finesse and charm, the guile and deceit and cunning, that was catra’s arsenal, and by wielding it, Catra will always win.

Adora did not doubt her at all, on the opposite she was mesmerised, in complete awe. But her doubts and unease were concentrated in the other half of the circle, the half Catra seemed to abandon. Her studies.

They were making their way towards the fourth flooring of the tower, the library. It was where Catra would have her lessons and studies. with her many teachers and scholars. Or rather, what she was supposed to do, adora had yet to see that.

Every time a lesson was held and a teacher arrived, Catra would find a way to evade both. Tricking the scholars into spewing lengthy speeches, stalling for thr time to fly by, or, most urgently, not showing up at all. Before this morning, Adora hadn’t thought of it as her place to speak. But now they were declared friends, so it was different.

Catra’s third evading method would not work since they were already headed towards the library anyway, which made Adora relieved. A lesson was sealed today after all.

Adora pushed the great doors wide open, taking the time to savour the interior not for the first time and most likely not the last. The library was enormous. The base a perfect circle, the tiles arranged to showcase the wheel of the moon, its many phases and orbits and ellipses in the sky. The book shelves were built like a snail’s shell, spiraling upwards and upwards with a closeby stairway. Many seats and tables were lettered around in a seemingly random manner but upon closer inspection, not at all. The windows at the highest of the room painted the room in bright sunlight, no shadow or dust lived here, but Adora knew an untouched thing when she saw it.

As adora was admiring the intricate design of it all, catra had dashed to the full bottles of ink and empty sheets of paper. She had one object in each hand and gave them to adora when they both sat down on a wide sofa, it was adora's idea after all.

She took of her right gauntlet to hold the feather pen, her mind recalling the many contracts and papers she had to write before realising that this was no digijtty or ambassador, this was catra and this about their friendship so there was no methodology to follow, they could do their own thing.

She settled on writing their names and their orgins (the way they introduced themselves) and leaving a space for the list of conditions, the termination, and the signature.

Catra spoke and adora wrote, "my conditions are," she began reciting while holding a finger for each point she made, "to be called not by my title but by my real name, to be spoken to directly and freely, to be free to decide what I want, to be, well…" she looked at her suspended fourth finger and hesitated before saying. "Just be my friend I suppose."

Adora was writing all which was said, but catra must have been ruminating about her list because she said to the sound of scribbling. "I know the list is small and simple. I don't have much of an experience in friendship."

Adora titled her head upwards to meet catra's eyes, they were wide and vulnerable. Adora didn't know what to say but she knew what to do. After she finished catra's list she began hers and finished in the same breath, she only wrote on thing: catra's last point, 'to be my friend.'

"I don't have much of an experience in friendship either." Catra's eyebrows had risen at that, adora's too; she was surprised at herself for both the statement and how sure of it. She tried to disprove it, but even when she didn't like it, she knew the answer. She had evaded Catra's after the confession. For fear of seeing

contempt at having whatever illusion she had of Adora ruined. But the silence suffocated her, so she stole a glance.

Catra was smiling at her, warmly, toothless and small, open and honest. “It’s alright, “ she said, voice as soft as the hand she cradled adora’s with. “We can learn together.”

Adora’s chest lit up like a candle. They can learn together, there was no shame in starting anew, was there?

They had gone back to completing their agreement. Both agreed to set termination to a decision explicitly made by either party, instead of limited by time. Both wrote their names and signed the agreement and were done.

It was a game. Their first play. It was all a pretend and make-belief and had no actual power in binding, but it was done, written down, their friendship and the promise of it written on paper. Undeniable. No matter what the future would hold.

—♕—

As they were lounging in the many cushions surrounded with many silk and feathers in one of catra’s many gardens. Adora’s intoxication as a result of her becoming catra’s official friend had disappeared in a flash as she remembered catra’s scheduled studies for the day. She immediately reminded catra of it and catra said, ‘oh, yes!’ but did not move a muscle from her relaxed posture.

She was lounging on her side, supporting her face on the palm of her arched hand, and throwing pomegranates into the air and landing them into her mouth with the other. Crown askew, feet bare. Humming noisily a tune Adora did not recognise. Adora was sitting on the opposite side, not as ramrod straight as how a knight should be, but nowhere near Catra’s relaxedness.

Adora knew Catra was trying to recreate the ambience of freedom from duty and title that she found in the whispering woods here in

the gardens of her own tower. They were far from sight, Catra excused the servants that brought her fruits and tried to fan her with hug feathers. The bushes and shrubs carefully groomed around them concealed them from the outside. Even though it was still inside her tower's borders, this place was only for Catra and Adora.

Adora wished for it to be true, but it was snot. And no matter how hard she wanted to convince herself, she couldn't.

Catra groaned loudly at adora's consistance quiet muttering and sighing and said, "what are you on about? You look like you're about to explode."

Adora exploded, "I don't think you should abandon your lessons!"

Catra's mouth gaped open, but Adora didn't back down. Before today, she knew it wasn't her place to talk and that fact gave her an excuse to not do anything, but now they were friends and one of catra's conditions was to be spoken to freely so adora must do just that, but most importantly, she still remembered the sick and improvished halfmoonians behind the walls. She wondered if Catra knew about them. If she cared. Because it did not look like she did. She had the power to change things in the future, as queen. Ultimate power.

But power without preparation was fickle and dangerous. And catra did not care about her studies, she didn't attend her listens, she didn't want to learn and study, she didn't hold value in her preparation to queenhood and what that would entail, all the responsibility and duties and so many lives affected by her decisions, it looked like it didn't matter to her. Adora could change that, if she could just wake Catra up that life was more than just quiet woods and alicorn rides and pomegranates, maybe she could make a difference, she could help Catra help all those people.

She wished that she had organised her thoughts into words during her silent fuming, because catra's shock had bled into

annoyance and she regarded Adora with narrowed eyes, urging her to continue on.

Adora spilled her thoughts all over herself. "You shouldn't abandon your lessons. It's disrespectful, to yourself and your teachers and — and the people you're going to rule in the future. And you need them. You are going to be queen! You need to learn how, and your lessons teach that. If you don't do that then you're not just hurting yourself but all of halfmoon too."

Adora had thought she made a pretty good job of explaining her point, but when she beheld catra's face she choked on her breath. It had just occurred to her that she had not seen Catra angry. Annoyed, yes, as the most common negative emotion. Also fear sometimes on swift-winds back, she did see her happy sometimes this day and the one before and years ago, but mostly she was just sardonic and mocking. She didn't see her anger, she wished she hadn't. Catra's eyes were wide, unblinking, mouth shut but the muscles clenching her jaw were visible as she fought to keep control of her heaving chest and clenching fists.

'This,' in a dangerously quiet voice she hissed. 'doesn't concern you."

Adora felt the feeling to back down but she trudged forward, "but we're friends, before a knight and a princess. our lives concern each other, no?"

"Not on this!" Catra was losing the battle of controlling her volume. "I told you I'm free to decide what I want, you can't tell me what to do!"

"I'm not telling you what to do! I'm just saying that your studies are important."

"You don't know that! You don't know anything!"

Adora was feeling insulted, so instinctively she rose to the same level. "I definitely know more than you since I actually attended my lessons!"

“Shut up!” Catra yelled, before face and voice slacking. Adora had just noticed the tears in her eyes and something other than anger, something deeper and well hidden, something worse, sadness. Catra quickly covered it when she noticed Adora noticing, and stood quickly, ignoring Adora existence as she walked away. Adora quickly followed her.

The remnants of their conversation, their fight, hung like a rotten fruit near them, making the air around them reek. Adora was beginning to feel guilty, not at what she did, but how she did it. Yes, she should’ve been nicer, but she was right. She had spent so long standing at the sideline, watching events unfold around without a say, she always closed her mouth, and armies bore the wounds of that mistake. She won’t close it again.

“I’m sorry.” She still said, because all those facts and the fact that catra was upset and the fact that adora would do anything so she won’t stay upset can all coexist. She didn’t receive a reply.

After an hour of silently walking around the gardens, concluded by the low hanging of the sun, Adora began to amend. “Can I help?” She asked.

She was met with silence. A realisation based on memory hit her and she knew that unless she uttered the magical word like before, Catra wouldn’t speak to her. She was lucky before, she doubted she would be as lucky again. So she began to spout whatever came to mind.

“I may not know exactly what fields you’re focusing on, but I can say that I’m well-educated on plenty and enough. I can speak and read more than a language, I can explain it to you, if your teachers are inadequate.”

Still silence, Adora changed direction.

“Or we could speak to someone else, the councillor of education perhaps, she did gift you that library after all, I’m sure she would

be open to changing whatever you would like about it. Or maybe you could speak to the regent."

Catra stopped suddenly, and then continued walking hurriedly afterwards. Adora was making this worse.

In a desperate attempt she just laid it all bare. "I truly only care about you and your future Catra, I'm sorry if I came across as imposing or authoritative or anything like that, I'm not. I just want you to be happy."

Still silent. Almost eerily so, there were no birds tweeting above, no insects buzzing around. Everything here was carefully groomed and decorated. Adora began to drown in the silence.

"I don't need those lessons."

Catra's voice was quiet but sure, like a secret she was afraid of saying but not of knowing. She didn't look at Adora, it seemed as if she was speaking to herself. But she did answer, she cut the silence clean, and for that Adora was grateful.

Adora pondered catra's answer. She did not doubt its truthfulness but she did want to examine its extent.

"Can you prove that?"

The incredulous question had Catra whip her face to look at her, bewildered. Adora began to explain her standing with her hands outstretched. "I swear to goddess, I'm not doubting you or calling you a liar. I just thought you might want to test that knowledge, and it'd bring me ease. Also we could still make use of your library."

Catra was silent, not in anger but in contemplation. Adora had already said her piece. Whatever decision Catra would make here would be all hers.

The sun was beginning to set. The sky darkening around them and the moon waking up, only then did Catra answer.

“Alright,” she said. “But not today, and not every day.”

Adora was feeling something, something she had not felt in a very long time, in a year: pride, accomplishment, triumph.

It was not today, but it was the day after.

After they entered the library, catra had reclined on her seat and didn’t say or do anything. She was waiting for Adora to make her move.

Adora focused on the books and their contents this time instead of the library’s grandeur. There were books of everything and everywhere. Sciences and arts, of peoples and their history, of the sky and the earth and the ocean, of mathematics and numbers and angles, of words and stories and poetry, of logic and reason. And they sat there, untouched and unopened.

Not anymore, if Adora's plan was to work.

“What subject are you most interested in?” Adora asked her, a question disguising another question; which subject are you most knowledgeable and comfortable in. She was trying her hardest to make this as the least tedious as it could be.

“None. What are you most interested in?” Catra replied. Adora knew that if she redirected the question toward Catra for the second time, then Catra would do the same, and then they would get stuck in an infinite circle until the sun would set and they would have to leave, so she thought of an answer.

There were many things Adora liked to learn and many things she disliked, a less amount that she hated and only one she truly loved.

“I’ve always loved astronomy.” She said, so that’s what they started with.

The library was big, huge, the organisation of the bookshelves was confusing to a person who did not grow up with it, and Catra

wasn’t ecstatic to help Adora find the correct section. Adora wasn’t put off by that, though, Catra was already doing more than she had expected by being here.

After finding it at last, she began to skim over the titles. She did not know Catra’s exact level and her agreement was a hesitant structure that Adora wasn’t keen on testing, so she picked a starter.

Catra ahead already made herself comfortable. Her shoes were kicked off and her bare feet were crossed at the ankle and supported on one armchair while her neck was on the other, her arms around her chest in a languid fashion. She looked as disinterested as an owl, but also just as keen eyed as one. She did not take her eyes off Adora as she chose the seat directly before her.

They had not agreed on the exact details and technicality of proof, and there are infinite ways of measuring and testing so Adora picked the easiest one, she would flip through the pages randomly and ask a question concerning the first statement on the page.

She opened the book on a random page. “What is a barycenter?” She asked.

Catra answered. She answered wrong, or rather that’s what Adora thought with a frown before realising Catra was explaining the concept in her own words rather than parroting what was written in the page. Adora understood her, but she was surprised at her understanding. It was… unique to say the least.

She moved to the second question.

Catra had answered with the same level of disinterest as the first, and as Adora progressed with the questions, not much changed. But she didn’t sit as far away as before, and her voice was less monotone, and her eyes more animated.

Adora would read the written text after Catra's answers even when she knows it already, many things are lost and found in translation and sometimes she would lose her focus on them. She had read an entire page and flipped over before realising she had been silent this whole time and Catra was patient and silent during it.

Adora began to apologize before moving on to the next question, but Catra stopped her. "Did I still not prove myself enough?" Her tone was not accusatory but her words most certainly were.

Adora stammered before saying, "yes." She really did, they had only moved through twenty questions but Catra's unique and extensive explanations coupled with the fact they were all being correct has proved herself enough. And if she was correct in this randomly assigned book and subject, there was no doubt in the others.

Catra stood, Adora had thought she would leave and begrudgingly left her book aside but Catra stopped her.

"We'll leave when you finish that book." She said, a favour disguised as a command.

Like a good knight, and a grateful friend, Adora obeyed.

As Adora read, Catra had waited in her seat, staring into nothing and losing herself in daydreams, but she had soon grew bored and began climbing the stairway upwards, then she started going through the books and scrolling for no reason, and then she stopped before a marked section in the library. The art section.

Adora stole a glance at her after every page she finished. She saw Catra standing still before the section. A page later, she was searching through the nooks and crannies. A page later, she had taken out papers and colors. A page later, she had begun painting.

Adora loved reading, but she loved having read so much more. It was like an accomplishment, a reward. And seeing what Catra was

painting was its own reward. So she averted her gaze and kept them on the pages of stars and galaxies.

The pinkish orange hue had begun to spill in the room to signal the sun’s descent when Adora finished her book. She quickly stood and made her way to Catra and her painting. The suspension ebbing away.

It was a tree. A specific tree Adora remembered from the whispering woods. It was far from a realistic depiction, there were too many colors and angular lines to suggest this was simply of memory instead of having been affected by imagination.

She wanted to ask Catra if that tree had any significant meaning, but she had already pushed her enough today so she simply said, “it’s beautiful.”

Catra had been looking at her attentively when she arrived and was hunting for her reaction like a hawk, at Adora's comment, she blushed and looked away. Badly hiding a small smile, her first smile inside the tower, her second of the day. Adora had only just realised she had been counting catra’s smiles.

So that is what they exchanged with abandoned lessons and absent teachers. Leisure reading and art and playful questions and answers. Things would escalate into debates that would let adora’s blood on fire but catra’s smile count would increase by the day so she loved it. The library had become their haven for intellectual pleasure, the way the whispering woods. But as opposed to catra’s, this was Adora’s doing.

—♕—

Adora had always prided herself in many things, in her strength, her knowledge, her swordsmanship. Things others prided her over and so she followed suit. They were always things that distinguished her as if not the best than as better, things that helped win, whether in the battlefield or outside of it. In

halfmoon, although, she prided herself in her closeness with Catra.

Mainly in the state of being the one Catra would abandon all masks and acts around, the one she displayed the true authentic self to, the one who truly knew her.

That pride was tainted slightly by the knowing that another in the castle knew Catra, if not more then, just as much as her.

The regent.

Catra did not visit the regent everyday of the week, but the days she did outnumbered the one she didn't. The regent was the only one the princess would leave her tower for, a carriage was supplied as one must expect but Catra had refused them for swift-wind instead. The trip wasn't far, but it wasn't the journey duration that made Adora frown, it was many other things.

Everytime time they would arrive at the regent's gardens (so different from the princesses, they were wild and weedy and full of thorns), Catra would enter the glasshouse alone, Adora would stay outside, and then some time later Catra would emerge and they would leave.

Due to either the glasshouse's material or the regent's sorcery, Adora could not hear a whisper from her place outside of it. She could see their lips moving, Catra's expressions and both their postures changing, but she would not know a word of what they were conversing about.

The only thing they did other than talking was play the game of queens. It was a modified version of what Adora were familiar of back home, but it was similar enough across the lands, halfmoon's board was circular, with all the movements modified to fit that, their king was exchanged of a queen, and their queen exchanged for a consort, their pawns and castles and horses and elephants were the same. Catra lost every time, from what Adora could see. But Adora could not see all the time, because sometimes the glass

windows would be tainted in spotless black, so she didn't know much of what happened during their visits.

Adora did not know many things, she came to realise.

She tried to deduce as much as she could from catra's state afterwards. Some times, she would appear unchanged. Many times, she would appear upset. Few times, she would appear hurt, but if asked would refuse it.

This information, coupled with the questions they produced when examined kept Adora awake during the night. Laying motionless in bed and pondering answers she had no access to. She spent her many nights like this, and Catra only needed two to figure that out.

"Did you not sleep well?" She asked, half of her attention focused on the conversation and the other half on making a flower crown of daisies for melog.

Adora had been sprawling on the grassfloor and yawning and being generally so unlike herself that Catra asked and Adora could not answer untruthfully. "No."

"… so you slept well?"

"No."

Catra was confused, "But you don't look like you slept well."

"That is not what I said." Adora's voice took a theatrical tone that was similar to a riddler. "Your question is based on the fact that I slept the night and the options if that I either slept well or unwell. The answer is I didn't sleep at all."

Catra threw a chunk of petals at her, giggling, but unfortunately to Adora's goal she did not drop the subject and continued to ask why Adora hadn't slept at all.

“The only way I could describe it is,” Adora started, borrowing an explanation from long ago. “My mind is too loud sometimes, louder than the quiet my body needs to sleep, and so it doesn’t.”

Catra frowned at that, saddened.

“But it’s alright, I have had years to deal with it. I’m accustomed I’d say, it just becomes worse sometimes.”

Adora really hoped Catra would not ask what made it worse. She didn’t. She went back to her flowercrown-making with a thoughtful face, the gears inside her skull running like clockwork, and Adora closed her eyes against the early morning sunlight.

She opened them again when she heard Catra’s saying in a quick voice. “I think it’s bad to be accustomed to it, I think you should find help for that, and I think that help can be found by using one of the many medicinal herbs cultivated here in halfmoon.”

Adora tilted her face towards Catra’s and found it red and tight with the eyes stubbornly averted, as if she was regretting her saying already.

“That’s a very good idea, Catra.” Some of the tension dissipated from her comforting words. “But I can’t leave you, I’m your knight.”

Catra rolled her eyes, her sardonic demonour returned, “you would barely spend an hour.”

“I cannot be away for a second, Catra.” She bit her lip in thought. “Unless… you would come with me.”

“What?!” Catra was startled enough to let the daisies slip from her fingers.

“Everything is sold in the castle-city market, right? We could visit it together!” Adora was beginning to become giddy at the idea, at the prospect of finding Catra another place to be happy, comfortable, free, another whispering woods, another library.

Catra hadn’t left her castle ever since Adora arrived, she barely left her tower. This would most certainly be an adventure for her.

But instead of the enthusiasm Adora suspected, Catra face only displayed fear and worry,

“I can’t leave the castle, Adora.”

“According to who? You’re the crown princess. You have the utmost authority. And if it’s a matter concerning safety then fear not! Your knight won’t be further than a hand, I promise.”

Catra’s hesitation was beginning to dissipate, she looked at Adora for a long minute, looked at the forest around them, and then at the almost finished flower crown in her hand. In a second, her countenance, like her resolution, hardened.

“Alright. But!” She interrupted Adora's glee. “Only to find you the herbs. I won’t have my knight half-awake, and I won’t have my friend tired. This journey would only be for you.”

Hearing the opposite of what adora wanted from this adventure was weird, but she shrugged it off. They could both benefit, but of course, catra remained the priority.

Adora was about to recline back to the grass, before Catra drew nearer and with a smile, and deposited the flower crown of daisies she’d been making since they arrived atop Adora's honey colored head.

Adora blushed, maybe at the close contact, maybe at the loving gesture, maybe at Catra’s radiant smile, she did not know. She wanted to thank her, truly. But all that left her foolish mouth was, “I thought that was for melog.”

Catra laughed loudly at that, her head pulled backwards to reveal her sun kissed neck with the sound echoing around them. She playfully swatted Adora's shoulder and said, “you really need that sleep, Adora.”

—♕—

The following noon and afternoon had been blissfully free of duties. Adora wasn't one that sought messages in random events, but if she was, she would have thought this was a sign she had made the correct decision.

Catra had told the servants to braid the entirety of her hair around her skull for the day, a requested a dark plain cloak that and took off her crown. But other than that she was unchanged.

Adora tugged swift-wind through their mental bond, he stood upon the balcony in a minute, they mounted him, and the two women atop the alicorn finally took off.

Like everything in her life, Adora came prepared, she learned all there is to know about the castle-city market. And from atop the skies, she could see it. The market was a line stretching at the castle-city's perimeter, a permanent fixed point of commerce between all of Etheria and beyond and halfmoon's highest nobility and royalty. Swift-wind had descended on a little far away point to adora's command, so Adora and Catra had to continue the rest of the trek on their feet.

Both seemed mesmerised, their necks and eyes swirling around them. Yes, it was beautiful and polished as all of halfmoon was, but it was the most disorganised and lively and true place she had ever seen in this queendom thus far.

It was crowded, the designated space was large, but the amount of people was larger, foreigners like Adora in a strange paradise land, of all and every profession, merchants and traders, fishers and farmers, blacksmiths and carpenters, weavers and fabricators, and more than what Adora could see. Selling everything from necessities to luxuries. Spices and vegetables and fruits, cloth and fabric, metal and ceramic, inventions and discoveries, everything the eye can behold and the hand can touch.

She grew dizzy from the thought of every person here having a story of their own, of having a family that they left behind or took with them, of the labour they went through to acquire their goods, the adventures they endured during their travels to arrive here, the life lessons they learned on their own. That thought coupled with the plethora of colors and shapes and sounds and scents made her very excited to stick around longer and examine every and all things, but they had one objective to meet her and according to Catra's orders it was only that and nothing else.

Speaking of Catra, her reaction upon their arrival mirrored adora's like a jagged surface. Amongst the excitement and wonder and awe, she could detect a flicker of fear in her eyes before they she tugged the hood of her cloak further downwards, her ears were twitching and her hand tightly clutching adora's vambraced wrist. Adora remembered how all of this must be as foreign to Catra as it was to Adora.

That won't do. As much as Catra argued otherwise, this journey was for her and her only, Adora would ensure this to be an enjoyable day for her. She palmed Catra's hand and tilted her head downward and crouched slightly, when their eyes met, adora smiled at her in which she hoped to be a comforting gesture of understanding, she didn't straighten her back until Catra gave her another smile in return.

Onward.

The herbalist was an elderly and warm woman. She greeted them with such friendliness, and quickly began presenting them an abundance of herbs after Adora told her of their predicament, from barks and seeds to flowers and roots. Each herb was accompanied with a tale of how the herbalist was able to acquire them, adventures of climbing high mountains, of diving deeping into the sea or travelling where no one ever traveled. Her tales most certainly had a bit of imagination going into the making of them, but Adora didn't mind. She liked a good story. It also reminded of her days on the road, of the excitement of a new life

and new adventures. But she was stable now, happy even, in halfmoon, with Catra, and she wouldn’t trade it all.

With her right hand she gave gold coins to the haberlist and with the left one she took the bundle of herbs.

She turned to look at Catra, she couldn’t do so when herbalist became a storyteller but she did hear some gasps of wonder behind her from time to time, she was too focused but now they goal was met and Catra most certainly had loved the experience it was time to go home.

Adora’s heart stopped beating.

Catra was nowhere in sight.

—♕—

Catra had known it was a bad idea from the start.

From when Adora had taken her idea into consideration instead of dismissing it, when she convinced her to come. From when she opened her mouth to help Adora once the way she helped her. From when they agreed to become friends. From when she saw her in the whispering woods and struck her and Adora retaliated in understanding instead of violence. From when the regent had told her of a new knight to guard her.

Catra had known it was a bad idea all along. But according to all whom she had met in her life and more, she was an expert in bad ideas.

Her heart had started beating frantically when she agreed to Adora's offer and they went home to prepare for the journey, thinking about how there were too many variables to account for, too many bad things that could happen, but Catra wanted it, the excitement, the adventure. She didn’t have much time after all, so she agreed.

The market, with all its loud crowds and dizzying atmosphere had mesmerised her, excited her, and that made her afraid. She learnt a long time ago that she can't trust herself when she feels this much, she'd overflow like a fountain. So she clasped her knight and friend's wrist like a chained cuff and didn't let go and hoped that Adora would understand the message she sent through the gesture.

She did. And they went onward.

The herbalist stories were awe inspiring, Catra had stood before her with an agape mouth, but after understanding began to trickle down her like rain she withdrew herself. The awe was exchanged with envy and anger at the herbalist, at her stories and adventures, at the truth that Catra would never be able to experience any of what she told.

Listening anymore was too painful, a mockery of Catra's suffering, so she left.

She didn't go that far, she only unclasped her grip on Adora and took three steps back. But she underestimated the water-like current of the crowd and overestimated her stature, a second went by and Catra was swept alongside the abundance of sellers and buyers.

She managed to steady herself quickly, but she couldn't see much from atop the many heads, she tried to trust her intuition and walked straight in a specific direction. She stopped, looked around and realised she had arrived at places they've already walked through. She changed to the opposite direction and trudged on and stopped as soon as she realised she had arrived at spot they didn't walk through yet.

Panic was beginning to knock on her heart, but with all her might, she steadied herself and her thoughts and tried to think. She tried, but she failed. The crowd was all around her, a sea of reeking meaty bodies that made her body scream the mantra of get out get out get out! So she did. She pushed bodies and

quickly weaved through like a needle in a fabric until she finally came on the other side.

She did not recognise this place, there were no trading posts around her and very few people that were. She was all alone.

Panic had taken home inside her heart. She was the crown princess in an unknown territory, unprotected and unaccompanied, around strangers who were eyeing her from head to toe and making notice of her gold and her cloth and her beauty. if someone noticed, if someone doubted, she would be worse than dead, she would wish to be dead. She was a lamb surrounded by wolves, a bird around snakes, and she had known by herself to blame.

Her lungs hurt, her heart pounding, she was gasping for breath as her mind conjured pictures of the worst that could happen over and over until she couldn't see clearly what was in front of her. A foreign smell reeked, a stranger was close, a hand grabbed her elbow and said in a leering tone that was too too close, "hello, pretty thing."

She freaked. She threw herself backwards and her arm forwards, something warm and wet coated her claws, an anguished scream hurt hear ears, and a step was taken towards her.

Catra ran. She ran as hard and as fast as she could, she didn't stop, not when her legs straining, not when her lungs were bruning, not even when all the colors around disappeared and were replaced by green. She only stopped when a rock had jutted her step and she fell to her face with a thump. Raising herself from the earth by her hands and knees, she began to eye her surroundings. She had no inkling where she was, no one was around, no buildings or paths were seen, she had ran faraway from everything. Only trees and bushes and the grassfloor surrounded her, and this forest, which was clearly not the whispering woods, gave her a sense of familiarity that gave a sense of safety to finally crumble.

She burst into tears.

Yes, they were of fear and sadness, but most of all, they were of anger. In rage.

She had known it was a bad idea from the start, she should've told Adora so. Adora was too nice and saw Catra and her world through too pink of lenses. She should have told her 'no' and then told her why, that she was too weak, too fragile, too stupid to make her way in her own castle, nevertheless the city. There was a reason she was confined in her tower, she had proven time and time again that she can't be trusted. It was for her own good.

But she didn't, and now she sat here. Knees and the hem of her cloak stained with mud and dead dead grass, crying and sobbing like an infant, instead of standing up and making her way back, too afraid and frozen to do nothing but stay put. She was beyond pathetic. The realisation made Catra throw her head back and scream in anguish, with nothing but herself to hate she attacked the trees around her, clawing the brown bark with her blood stained hands. Even that was too much of an effort for her, and after too little time she slumped against the poor tree and cried harder.

She was such a disappointment, just like the regent always said.

She had no way to know how much time had passed, except for the burning in her eyes and fraying in her throat, but suddenly a strong gust of wind struck her and a mighty flap of wings sounded to her. She tilted her head upwards, and saw Adora atop swift-wind before her.

She was her saviour sent from the sky, her protector, her champion, her knight. Only Catra's. Her helmeted head reflected the sunlight around her like an angelic halo and her white steed was as glorious as her image. She was her salvation and she had come at last.

The all encompassing despair that filled her body to the brim was purged out quickly by her seeing Adora that it left Catra exhausted and worn. With her eyes gazing reverently and her low laugh escaping her dry mouth, Catra slumped forward and fell unconscious against a firm chest.

—♕—

One of Adora's worst sins was the flightiness of her mind. She was too easily distracted, her eye too easily pulled, and her attention with it. Zeroing on one singular thing as the world disappeared around her. It had brought her many problems growing up, from her parents to her twin to her mentor. She never believed their worry, what she would focus on would always happen to be the most important, so why pay attention to other than that?

The world had finally answered years later.

Was is the herbalist stories, or perhaps the herbs themselves and the mission of choosing, or maybe it's nothing as specific as these options but rather the broad goal ringing in her mind of making Catra enjoy this journey, where she ended up achieving the opposite.

It didn't matter why, what mattered was that she was distracted. And it almost cost Catra. Her princess, her responsibility and duty. Her mission in this new and paradise-like world.

As soon as she noticed her disappearance, she didn't wait a waste a single second, she bolted. She raced through the crowds, the solidness of her build and her armour cutting a path across the bodies easily, until she reached swift-wind. Catra was fast, Adora would need just as fast of a friend to help her find her.

Reliving on swift-wind's nose and her own keen eyed, she searched for her from the sky. Enough time had passed to tell her that Catra wasn't in the market. Her throat had run dry but she didn't give up, didn't stop for a blink. She had to find her, no matter what.

And she finally did! She found her crouching amongst the green and wood. Alone. Shaking. Adora had the flair to throw herself to the grass and weep and beg forgiveness, but just like when she first noticed her princess' inexistence, she gathered her sea of emotion and built a dam around it and focused.

Catra had fainted as soon as she saw Adora, a quick scan assured her that no injury was the cause of it, but Adora was older than the version of herself who she believed injuries could only show on skin and flesh.

She caressed Catra tear painted face and as she gazed at it she allowed herself one sob, one sniffle and two tears. Before she gently settled her palms under catra’s back and knees and carried her while mounting swift-wind, only her mental bond to him assured their safety atop his as she used all her limbs to hold Catra close to her heart.

Catra had woken up a second before swift-wind’s perching on the balcony, but she remained just as silent and motionless as before. She left Adora's embrace as soon as her feet touched marble and immediately made her way to her dressing chamber, the servant summoning bell was sounded behind the door, Catra was done for the day.

As soon as she realised she was alone and unseen, she broke down into pieces. Silent sobs racking her chest and tears clouding her vision. This was all her fault.

She always did this, overestimate and overexcite herself to the point of recklessness and calling it bravery. She never cared if it got her hurt, she didn’t have to, but now she had Catra, she almost had her hurt. She ruined everything.

She needed to talk to Catra.

For an hour, she stood. She didn’t undress herself, didn’t lay on her mattress, she did nothing as she waited for Catra to emerge.

When she finally did, she lifted an eyebrow for a second at seeing Adora but settled her face into passivity fast enough as she made her way to her inner chambers. Adora could see her from the entry getting into her bed, the sun had not even started to set yet.

Adora took a deep breath and armoured with the thought of this being her only chance, entered the crown princess's inner chambers for the first time.

Catra sat up in surprise, "what are you doing?!" She asked in exclamation. "The barrier will appear at any minute now. Leave."

"I need to tell you something." Adora breathed desperately.

A darkness shadowed catra's face. She scowled. "No, you don't. I know exactly what you're about to say."

Adora took a step forward and said, "I still need to."

"I know, alright? I know I was stupid and cowardly and— and weak. You don't have to tell it to me. I know!"

"That's not true! It was I who was foolish I shouldn't have—"

"Trusted me? Thought I was strong enough? Capable enough?"

"No!"

"Oh, please." Catra spat. "You won't even let me look at you and you want me to believe you?"

She was right, Adora had not taken her helmet off during the entire day, and she now wished against doing so even more; the evidence of her weakness in the tears and redness was visible on her face. But it was catra's wish, and her wish was always adora's command.

She took her helmet. Her face must have been as red and soaked as she felt it judging by Catra's widened eyes.

After a moment of silence, Catra pouted and said quietly, "you shouldn't cry over it, over me. It wasn't your fault."

"Yes, Catra. It was." Her tone left no space for debate.

Catra opened her mouth for a retort but Adora interrupted by speeding towards her and standing face to face and saying, 'can I ask you a question?"

Catra pulled back at that and nodded instead.

"I've been thinking about a lot. What happened today at the market, your… panic. But also everything else." She felt her eloquence leaving, her way of words betraying her as she tried to ask such a deep and personal question and burrow herself even deeper inside catra's mind and life. "Was it because of the regent?"

Catra froze, like a frost. like a glacier. Her face was frozen in obsolete shock, her wide eyes were unblinking and her chest did not rise or fall. She looked like an ice sculpture and paled white just like one. After an age passed, she gathered enough strength to pull air to her chest and move her mouth and say, "what?"

Adora tripped over herself to explain, to draw her the puzzle that had been forming inside her mind for weeks, how the pieces were coming into place to show a picture Adora was pained to see, how she tried to avert her eyes from. She had seen and been in a lot of high places, of courts and princesses and people with otherworldly power. From the moment she saw her, Adora knew something was different here, out of place. She had attributed at first to the queens' demise, to catra's being an orphan, a queenless princess, a motherless daughter.

But the behaviour of the royal court, of the council around her, told her differently. They hated her. Which didn't make sense when considering she had the most power due to her status. So the only way to fit the logic was to change one of the statements, the first was true enough, Adora saw it with her own eyes, the

contempt and greed and jealousy, which left the second one to be disproved. Catra did not have all or the most power, which meant someone else did.

Only one person fit the criteria, and it was diamond clear who from the first day.

“Well, I was wondering how you haven't left the castle ever in your whole life, even due to your status. At first I thought you simply didn’t want to but your reaction to the market said otherwise which means that someone else must have forbidden you, and only one person could do that. But more importantly than all that, you always acted… differently near her. Adora had said all that in one breath and speed that stopped her from overthinking her choice of words and patiently waited for a reply.

The frost covering Catra was slowly beginning to thaw. Shock was exchanged for understanding, horror for realisation, and then…

Adora had not seen Catra cry. She did find remnants of her face earlier today (was it today? it felt like ages) but she had not seen the full sight. It was a horrible sight. At first she was stony, unmoving, as two tears streamed down her cheek like rivers, and then more and then more until she was gushing, heaves punching their away out of her rib cage as her trembling body shocked from the force of it all. She was sobbing, loud and watery and painful to hear.

Adora wanted to get far away, to close her eyes and open them and find Catra smirking and lounging and happy before her. But she wasn’t, she was sad and hurt and she was baring all her naked vulnerability before Adora. Her mind didn’t know what to do, but her heart did so she followed it command.

What could Adora do other than hold her close?

She climbed into the bed and gathered Catra in her arms, into her lap, as she shook and wept. Hands slowly caressing her back and arms and cheek squished atop her head.

After another age passed, Catra had calmed down enough to ask, “how did you know?”

Adora had no clear answer for that, there wasn’t a specific interaction or piece of information that told her, she just connected the dots laid before her for days and nights. “I just… noticed.”

Catra was silent, until she wasn’t. “No one else did.” Her voice was quiet and small, from sadness, from betrayal, and also from a bit of anger. “No one else noticed for twenty years.”

Gently, Adora said, “I think they did. I think they just did not care.”

Adora mentally slapped her mouth at her coarseness, but Catra surpised her when she said after a deep exhale, “I think so too.”

They lay entangled together at the edge of the bed, until Catra untangled her and lay down on her back, she wasn’t looking at Adora, she was looking straight ahead at the sky shown from the glass window at the centre of the dome. But she spoke to her, “I envied the herbalist stories, that is why I left. I barely got to leave the tower, while she traveled the whole world. The world reminded me why soon enough, I got lost immediately after and then led myself directly to the lion’s den. I put myself in danger, I could’ve been killed or worse. But it’s alright, I know now, it’s best that I just stay here. I’m not enough for the real world. I’m sorry I dragged you along with me to the bottom.”

Her voice was heartbreaking to hear, cracking and resigned and so unlike anything Adora saw of her, she could hardly believe this was Catra before her speaking, and about herself nonetheless! “No.” Adora said it in a rush, shocked that even have to do so, her voice echoing around the chamber. “You are so much more than enough, catra. And you shouldn’t resign yourself to something you don’t want, and most of all, you should never apologise.”

Catra's eyes watered. "I'm weak," she said. "I don't know what to do with myself. I want too much and too deeply to think clearly. I'm a danger to myself."

"No, you're not!" She fought back but Catra had already turned around and gave adora her back. Reaching desperately for a solution Adora said, "I could teach you! Combat, swordsmanship, whatever you want. You're not weak, Catra. You saved yourself today. You're strong, very strong. and I want to help you understand that."

Catra was silent, Adora found herself staring at the slope of her back before Catra said in a small timid voice, "really?"

Adora laughed heartily, "yes, really. Whatever you wish, I'll do it for you."

Catra turned slowly around and looked at her like the sun, her eyes wide to take in all the light Adora provided, 'do you promise?"

A strong sense of memories and a past she can never reach trickled her, but Adora ignored it, she had the future to look forward to now, and the Catra of today was with her. "I promise."

Both smiled, both gazed at each other warmly and both bolted upright in fright when the sharp sound of the dark barrier covering the chamber's door and windows sounded. The sun had set.

Catra was worried, Adora was not. "You're stuck here now!" The former said.

Adora wasn't worried, she could conclude enough that the barrier rise at sunset and would set at sunrise, so she was only stuck here for one night.

With Catra, for sleep, undressed, in the same bed. Alright, she was starting to worry.

“I could sleep on the floor.” She supplied quickly. “I’ve slept worse than polished tiles.”

Catra glared at her, “Don’t be a fool. The bed is big enough for a village to sleep in.” She then stood and pulled a wooden chest from underneath her bed. She opened it and unfurled a white nightgown and gave it to Adora, “This is the largest one I own.”

Adora was frozen.

“You can’t expect to sleep in your armour, do you?”

Adora, wisely, held back the confirmation that yes actually she was expecting to do just that. Instead she stood silently and took the nightgown from catra’s hands and went to the corner of the chambers to undress, a facade of modesty, there was no place to hide in the perfectly circular room.

Adora finished undressing and dressing quickly and turned to find Catra already laying on her bed. The bed Adora was supposed to get in to, now. She wiped her sweaty palm on the white fabric and took deep breaths as she made her way towards it. She hoped her face wasn’t as red as she felt it would be.

It was. The first thing Catra said when she turned to face her was, “Your face is very flushed.” And to make matters worse, she palmed her forehead. “And you’re very hot too.”

Adora was being cooked inside her own skin like meat atop a fire, she closed her eyes, the first step towards sleep after all.

“Are you going to sleep with your hair braided?” Catra asked again, her voice clear against the quietness of her chambers and the dark night.

Adora sat up and unbraided her hair before settling back down.

Catra was looking at her strangely and said after a moment of quiet, “You’re very beautiful.”

Thankfully, no reply was demanded of Adora because Catra's face grew saddened again and she said, "I forgot your herbs, did you buy them at least?"

"Yes, I did. It's alright, I can use them tomorrow." And then with a softer voice she said, "it was a very good idea, Catra. Thank you."

Catra smiled at her warmly, Adora would never find something as beautiful as her smile.

As sleep was calling for her, Adora has one second to realise that atop the smooth and soft fabric of pillows and quilts, with their eyes closed and their breathing is quiet, their hands were holding one another.

She didn't know who reached out at first, and after more thought she found it didn't matter, because at the end Adora's pale and big hands, calloused and slightly scared, was holding catra's darker and smaller one, the sharp tips of claws slightly touching her knuckles. Their fingers were interlaced, their palms touching, Adora had never used her hands to do a better thing than holding Catra's.

A deep, kind sleep greeted her.

Chapter End Notes

> Each chapter is named after a flower that is symbolically associated with the theme of the chapter, daffodils of the first one were for new beginnings, and Alstromeria of this one is for friendship.
>
> I'm using two different chess queen piece symbols for the pov, the white queen is for Adora and the black queen is for Catra. (A little hint for future events, the white pieces are always moved first in every game)
>
> And we're at the end! Thank you so much for reading and I appreciate it so very much! I can't wait to hear your thoughts

and opinions and anything really, just remember to be kind and respectful.

See you later.

Chapter 3: Intermission one: belladonna

Chapter Summary

> A glance at the childhood of princess c'yra, where the beauty of the queendom and castle hides the tragedy and misery and unjust pain.

Chapter Notes

> Hello again! first I want to apologise about the time, I try to write as fast as I can but I have so many other responsibilities to take care of and I'm a still a beginner writer I would say, so thank you so much for being so patient and I hope you'd enjoy this chapter.
>
> We're taking a break now from the present to take a look at the past, and it's not very pretty. Please make sure to check the tags above and the trigger warnings below at the end notes.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Once upon a time, there was a witch.

She was a witch among witches, among those who loved the magic too much to let it be, dedicating the entirety of their lives into mastering it. But different from her fellow witches, she was always hungry, ravenous, never satiated, always hungering for something more. Always wanting to be more.

Until one day, her wish came true, her spell succeeded. She died, and was rebirthed as the most powerful witch in all of the lands.

All the magic in the world was hers to consume, to devour, the magic in the living, in the flower petal and trea bark, in the bird feather and beast claw, and most abundantly, in the people.

Afterwards, she journeyed to the etherian continent, for the queendoms that ruled it were the richest of magic in all of the known world. After years of mindless travels and lowly hunts and silence, the witch had had enough. She knew she was worthy of something better, higher, greater. She deserved a crown and a throne, and a nation to call hers.

The universe heard her wishes and, as answer, gifted her halfmoon.

A queendom which just suffered a great loss, regicide, with people who were too deep in the waters of their mourning and grief to look upwards into the sky of tomorrow, a tomorrow she would reign over.

It had been too easy, the sole barrier standing between her and the crown was a small and weak royal court, one she bested with ease, by the power of shadows and whispers and people easily believing what they see or hear.

It had all been too easy, except for one. One thing she could not account for, one broken cog in her clockwork, one wildflower in her carefully grown garden, one anomaly.

The princess.

Like her court, too small and weak. Too young, an infant of a royal. Too alone, an orphan of a princess. And as long as she lived, as she breathed, the throne would never belong to anyone but her.

It would be too easy to kill her, but the witch was a creature of chance, of finding opportunity in the wild, she could make use of the princess, control her like a pawn on the board, squeeze her dry like a fruit, have her warm her throne for her.

And when the perfect day would come, the witch would strike, and she would win. She would be the queen.

For now, she would only be the regent.

—♛—

Princess c'yra's sin was committed before the could talk, before she could walk, someone would even say, before she took her first breath.

In some other world, her birth would have been a moment of celebration, a gift to the overflowing queendom, a new good thing

to behold and cherish, a princess to treasure, a daughter for her mothers to love and raise and guide.

But that was another world, where those horrendous turn of events had not existed, where the emperor had not stricken, where the queens had not perished, where the princess did not embody the tragedy that struck halfmoon so very suddenly.

For all who looked at her though the same, they did not see her as the small babe with dusted freckles and eyes painted in the colors of each mother's eyes, they saw her as their perpetual reminder of their false sense of peace, that their paradise was not as untouched as they believed, where springtime was not the norm outside halfmoon's trees. She was their reminder of bloodshed, massacre, death, and grief. Tragedy.

All who held or looked at her could only feel melancholy, a deep seated sadness of what could have been, and no matter how their heads told them it was not her fault, their hearts would not be settled. She was a plague, a disease. And so the orphan princess grew up alone.

No face stuck around in her infant memory, the servants ever changing, the guards faceless, the courtiers few and far between. No face struck around, except for one.

It was a face like no other, instead of soft flesh, it was made of hard porcelain. Instead of earthy tones, it was colored like dry blood. Instead of expressive crevices, it was as smooth as a river stone, with only two symmetrical holes at the upper half of it.

The face had made c’yra cry the first time she saw it, it had her confused, she couldn’t understand the wearer’s intentions when she held her. But as that face appeared over and over, year after year, she grew attached to it, she sought it, she wanted it.

Princess c’yra was six years of age when she truly understood how that face was no face at all.

She had lived her whole life inside a tower, one that looked as if it sprouted from the soil like its surrounding gardens and trees, spiralling and round and multicolored. She had lived there alone, safe for faceless and voiceless servants and guards. Except for the regent, the porcelain faced.

She would visit her sometimes, in her inner chambers, in her eating hall, in her library, in her gardens. Everytime she did, c’yra would be the happy.

But not happier than when the regent would invite her, have her visit, in her glasshouse.

It was so very different from c’yra’s tower, it was angular with sharp edges, black stoned with foggy glass, with light dimmed no matter how brightly the sun would shine. The surrounding gardens were overgrown and weedy and full of trailing, climbing vines.

It was scary, but c'yra loved it. For that was the place where she would not be alone, where someone would look at her, where she could speak and be heard, where she could matter.

C'yra loved the regent.

That was why, during that fated night, she did not hesistate to answer the her call. Their visits were weekly, the regent had told her as much once, and c'yra had not missed a day since. She was always too excited to, bouncing on her small feet the way her curls bounced against her cheeks, dragging the hand of her assigned knight as they walked their way.

The glasshouse had been darker during that day, foggier, the weed and vines around it tightly winded. C'yra had noticed once, but not twice, she did not think much of it. The regent told her to visit, so she would visit.

When she was near enough to enter the light dimmed around her so much as if it was night, but c'yra had not let that deter her, she had left her knight at the foot of the steps and began walking through.

"My regent?" She called hesitantly into the glasshouse. After she closed the door behind her, everything became very dark, like a world of shadows. Even with c'yra's royal eyes she could not see much ahead.

She stepped through, it was very silent too, she could hear nothing but her clank of her shoes' soles and her confused accelerating breathing.

As soon as the possibility of the regent's not being there and c'yra's subsequent need to leave were thought of in her mind, she noticed a figure in the distance.

"Oh, regent!" She hurried forward. "I was afraid you would not—"

The regent turned to face her.

C'yra froze, and then screamed.

The face that looked back at her was not the regent's face.

It was not made of porcelain, but of lacerated flesh. It was not smooth, but was crisscrossed by scars. And it was not rich red, but a deep gray, a dead color, a face of corpse.

And the face was angry as it looked at c'yra.

C'yra did not hold her screaming as she ran to escape, pure memory carrying her through the darkness, a darkness that did

not allow her to see what made her fall with her face to the earth.

With a bleeding nose, she pushed her small body upwards and looked backwards, a chain of blackness and shadow was tightening around her ankle, pulling her back no matter how much c'yra clawed at the ground. More chains were born of the darkness, contorting her until she was forced on her knees with her wrists pulls painfully downwards.

Footsteps sounded and the him of dark skirts came into view. "Look at me." The regent's voice was the most terrifying thing c'yra had ever heard in her life, and yet she shook her head, eyes tightly shut as she tried to will the nightmare out of view.

Fingers like dead tree spindles closed against her mouth, pulling her face upwards, yet her eyes remained shut.

"This," the regent pulled back her lips to hiss. "is the price of power. This is what people who are not born with it have to suffer through."

C'yra opened her eyes in instinct as the nails digging into her cheeks broke skin, whimpering as she faced the horrifyingly monstrous face before her.

"Are you willing to pay that price?" C'yra tried to pull her face back, to get away. "Are you?!" Nails were digging deeper, a warm

something prickled from her cheeks.

"Answer me!" The regent bellowed. C'yra shook her head, she did not exactly what she refusing, for she refusing it all, everything, she refused to be here from the start.

The regent chuckled at her answer. "Of course, you won't. You do not have it. You're too foolish, too weak, too broken. "

A moment of silent and then, "am I beautiful, c'yra?"

C'yra nodded enthusiastically, yes to anything, everything, whatever to make her regent happy, to make her love her again.

C'yra had though the regent was pleased with her answer, for she had withdrawn her hold, but after a moment, she slapped her on her right bleeding cheek.

"Lies will only get you so far." She told the whimpering form of a child. Who wanted to curl around herself and hide until the world was right again, but who was not. The child who was cupping her bleeding, pulsing cheek as she stared with wide eyes at what the closest thing she had for a mother denounced her, forsaken her, rejected her.

The regent opened her mouth again and c'yra tried covering her furred ears, hiding from the ugly words, she could not bear it

anymore. But neither woman nor girl got to do so because shattering glass sounded from the entrance.

The knight! He had come to save his princess.

C’yra saw it all, heard it all. A moment forever imprinted in her mind. The knight had only taken a step forward, before the shadow chains around C’yra pulled back from her and made their way to him, climbing him like snakes, tightening like steel, until they disapproved underneath.

The knight c’yra did not remember the name of exploded into a shower of viscera and blood and bone, and then that horrendous display too disappeared as the shadows gulped it all. In one second, a knight was standing, in another, he wasn’t. Like he never existed.

The regent moaned behind c’yra’s back, like one does after a eating a full meal.

C’yra looked at her mother, her regent, for one blink, and then ran.

Despite the pain, in her ankles and wrists and cheeks, she did not stop running. Not until she reached her tower, not until she was safe.

For years to come, c’yra would remind herself of this when the nights of self blame and condemnation were too thick. She would remind herself that she was not silent, she did not keep it a secret. She would remind herself over and over until she believed even for a second, that during the knight, she had told the first person she saw, and the second and the third. From servant to guard to courtier to councillor. That the regent killed her knight, that she hurt her and made her bleed, that she did not love her, for even the orphan princess knew that was not love.

She would remind herself that it was not her fault no one had believed her, that they called her a liar, whether to her face or behind her back, that she was not heard.

When the day of her next glasshouse visit drew nearer, c’yra did something she had never though possible. She left the castle.

She had never left her tower before hand, but as her mind remembered the last visit’s events, and as her body remembered the pain, and as her heart remembered the hatred she was met with, her entire being walked through the arches around her garden and then further.

Towards the whispering woods.

C’yra did not feel scared, not with the faint trees that blocked the paths, not with many noisy insects and birds in the skies, not with the weird looking animals circling her legs, and not when the night sky shone its stars on her.

“I am never going back.” She told her new friend, a lion that was no lion, a fearsome yet gentle thing. He was curling around her, giving her something soft to rest her back on, as he rested his head on her belly.

The not-lion simply grunted with closed eyes, but c’yra understood it, somehow. Just like how she understood his name as melog. He wanted to smooth her, but c’yra was too angry to be soothed. She had done it all right, done exactly what she’d been told to,and yet she was punished. How can she trust it would not happen again. She did not know it at the time, but that anger would be her salvation later.

“I’m not!” She defended herself to none. “I don’t care about food or clothes or beds. I’d live with the flowers and birds and you, if I have too. At least you like me, no one likes me there.”

C’yra’s eyes misted as she looked downward, melog opened his eyes and rubbed their faces together, pulling c’yra momentarily out of her misery. “But… leaving so soon means I let them win, didn’t I?”

Melog did not reply, it only continued rubbing her affectionately, but c’yra had already come into her decision with no help. “They will not win! None of them, I’ll make sure of it. I’ll be big and strong and queen someday, and then I will make them lose.”

And with this new-found sense of mission arming her heart, if not her body, she went back to her castle.

The punishment for her disobeying the regent had been severe, making her bedridden and barely able to move from the pain, and yet the castle believed what it wanted to believe, that she was simply sickly, a frail flower, a delicate doll. Not that there was a monster hunting her.

But c'yra did not let that stop her, to force her to abandon the woods. She would visit whenever she wanted, she had friends there after all, and adventures happened there, even the little ones, just like the ones in her story books and so unlike what happened inside the castle.

For if she stayed forever in the castle, she would never have got to meet a honey-haired girl, one who was crying and scared, and one who became the first person c'yra had ever helped.

And with the beautiful girl had asked for her name, c'yra the third did not say it, for that name, that title, had only brought her pain. Instead she told her a common halfmoonian name, the name of the heroes in her story books, the names of the servant and guard's daughters, the name c'yra might have had if she was born to be happy.

She told her first friend that her name was Catra.

—♕—

Change knocked on Catra's life and body loudly, suddenly and very rudely.

Her life, so far, was governed by monotony. Days and nights spent identical, sleeping and awaking at the exact same time for years, staring into the clouds outside the windows as the servants dressed her, eating alone in the eating hall, attending her lessons in the library, and, hebdomadally, visiting the regent's glasshouse.

But that was the life of Catra the girl. Catra the woman on the other hand lived a new life. Few things stayed the same, many things changed.

Catra had begun to notice many old things when the new arrived. Like how instead of moonly whites and silvers, the royal colors, she had always been dressed instead in shades of red, like no halfmoonian did, but like the regent did. The red did not change, but everything did, the fabrics became tighter, laced exactly how her body curved and swelled, making her notice for the first time how much it changed as she grew, and the cuts were uneven, too short on her chest and back, baring her naked brown skin to the air, but too long on her arms and legs, restricting her mobility. Everything else increased with her age, the face paint, the jewellery, all but for her crown, it became smaller, a dainty thing constantly askew on her head.

Like how she had not been seen by many people, never met her royal subjects, never conversed with her courtiers and councillors,

she had grown up hidden, invisible, existing solely inside the tower or the glasshouse. That also did not change, she had not yet left the castle, but she was, not only allowed but, wanted in other places, halls, throne rooms, ballrooms.

Like in her coming of age ball.

She was taught exactly what she must do during the night, but, like all she learns, she did not expect to see its need in the real world, around thousands of people, with higher than mountain stakes.

In theory, she knew exactly how this night would go, but in practice, she was in a foreign land.

The regent came to meet her, before her arrival was announced and the doors were opened and halfmoon got to laid its eyes on its princess for the first time, no longer an orphan babe, but a woman. Her mask and dress was charmingly yet subtly polished, she was the regent after all.

She did not acknowledge the servants and guards around them in the hallway, she never did, as she spoke to Catra directly. "Do you know what happens to birds who can't fly?"

"They die in their nests?" Catra answered curtly. The regent's fabled questions were rarely about actual knowledge but mostly a

drawn-out way of threatening or reprimanding Catra of things she had not done.

"Not quietly. Their parents push them off the nest, but not before they teach them how to flap their wings and balance their weight, but if the bird refuses to listen, to obey, then it has nothing but itself to blame as it shatters its skull on earth's rocks."

Catra stared at her blankly, using this as an opportunity to practice keeping her anger, her emotions, invisible from her face for the night.

"I have already taught you, c'yra. You will have none but yourself to blame when you fall."

"If I fall." Catra retorted instinctively.

The regent's fingers traced the swirling paint on her cheekbones, before grabbing her chin and bringing her closer. "Need I remind you that the entire queendom is behind these doors?" She hissed.

Through gritted teeth, Catra said. "No."

The regent snorted but let go, "let us see how you will disappoint us tonight, your highness." and stepped aside.

The doors opened.

Nothing would have prepared her ears for the deafening sounds, her eyes from the flashing colors and shapes and crystal lights and oh-so-much movement, her mind from the enormous amount of faces and bodies and people. She had never met so many people.

She was frozen in place, frozen in the shadows. The regent pushed roughly like a ragdoll and Catra stepped into the light and, for the first time, stood before her royal subjects.

Hers.

She was the princess, the future queen. There was her throne, right there. Her power, her authority, her reign. As Catra sat on it, she beheld the entirety of halfmoon kneeling and bowing for her, and for what felt like such a long time, she smiled.

That smile was allowed to live for a moment and two before it shrivelled and died as the regent stood before her, her hand outstretched. She was the only one who was not bowing.

Catra stared at the hand, and then, bravely, at the mask. Knowing what she must do, thinking instead of all of what wanted to do, and the consequences.

What would happen if she refused, if she rejected her, if she slapped her hand and screamed at her royal subjects about what kind of a parasite wormed her way in the royal castle for years, if she finally acted like a princess who would one day be a queen.

But the question was fruitless; she already knew what would happen. Death, it was. Maybe at the same moment or maybe years after, but she would meet death for her insolence, and Catra wanted to live, for now.

And so instead, she ignored every alarm in every cell of her body and let her hand rest atop the regent's and let her body be pulled upwards, away from her throne.

A circle of halfmoonians and more formed around them, so many eyes gazing at the embodiment of halfmoonian power and royalty, princess and regent, before them, together.

The music crescendoed, they began to move. Soon enough, Catra was gasping weakly, not at the physical exertion or anxiousness, but at where she was, and with whom.

She was being held by the regent, with the hands that slapped and chained her, the embrace she was denied for so long, at the scent that used to bring her comfort in infancy and grew to do the opposite when she did, the mask that plagued her nightmares for so long finding its place near her neck.

She was close, too close, it was all too close, too frightening, like a fly trapped in a silk web as it watched the spider make its way. But Catra was even weaker than the fly, the insect would wiggle and try to escape, Catra could not even do that. She had to stay in her trap, feign content, act as if the hands on her wrist and waist did not make bile rise in her oesophagus.

And while her body can not escape, at least her mind could, so she let it loose, free, disconnected. Looking at the mosaic on the tile or pillars or ceiling as the world became erased and she imagined all sorts of things that were not there to be. It's how she always survived.

She could've been dancing with the regent for minutes or for days, the regent could've been hurling a rib cage-piercing insult after another, the queendom could've been sat on fire, and Catra would not know, would not care, would not be hurt because of it.

And when it was finally done and Catra could finally sit down back on her throne, she did not stop, she was half awake and aware of the ball. Half looking and thanking the gifts of ores and fabric and spices from inside and outside the queendom, half listening to the poets and bards and songwriters boast about her beauty and nothing else, half tasting the feast laid before her, half acknowledging the people ogling her with hungry eyes as if she was a treasure, or a meal, or a gemstone.

When courtiers and ambassadors and many more began to interrupt each other as they asked for a dance, or a talk, or a second, Catra was reminded of what the secondary function of this ball was.

The first was to show the world who the princess was, the second to show what the princess can be or do.

She was the perfect fruit, young, ripe, untouched. Unprotected, orphaned by war and in need of allies. And, as the entire queendom used to tell her while growing up, and as the rest of the world echoed when it saw her, she was beautiful, just like halfmoon, dark, soft, rich, round, and multicoloured, from her hair to her freckles to her eyes. All would want to have her, own her.

Catra thought about what her first dance with the regent might say to them. How even if one here and today managed to capture her eye or her heart, if politics aligned like stars and agreements flourished like flowers, she would always be owned by one, belong to one, for only she in the world had her, her mother, her jailer, her cager, her torturer, the first person her heart sang for and broke because of.

“May I, your beautiful highness?”

For the entire night, she had not entertained any of the noblewomen, the men in halfmoon were never that bold, but yet many persisted. None like the eternian duchess though, shoulders armed and smile permanently painted over her pale face. The only reason Catra stood again from her throne and accepted her hand was, to put it in simple language that would never describe the hunger and thirst that plagued Catra’s days, boredom. Even when she knew what the duchess wanted, what they all wanted.

Marriage. It was too early, too soon, the thought of another shackle weighing on her made Catra want to close her eyes and disappear, there was still so much she had not done yet, had not seen or felt, had not experienced, she had not lived yet.

But she was not afraid, and so was not careful. It really was too early, her mind reasoned, not even the regent could bleed of her use so quickly. This was her first ball after all, she did not worry.

She learned afterwards that she should've worried, took precaution.

No one was ever allowed near Catra's tower, nevertheless inside it, which, yes included her gardens. For years, she walked like a ghost in the night, nightgowned with bare feet, quiet and slow, watching the stars of the night sky and caressing the green leaves of the high pushes, only her and the silence. But that silence was preached, and she was not alone anymore.

"How did you get in?" She did not know how the eternian duchess made her way inside, if by blade or by coin or by some other power catra was too young to know, and she did not care. Only that she followed that path to the outside too.

"I needed to see you, princess." She answered Catra a question she had not asked, the regent did that too, before Catra grew enough to notice it.

“Guards!” Catra had only called once before continuing her nightly stroll, confident in her being untouched.

She shouldn’t have been.

The duchess pushed her side ways, climbed on top of her, and pinned her wrists to the grass.

“I needed to see you. The stories did not lie, you are the most beautiful thing the eye can see.” Her voice was ragged, dripping with appetite, her eyes lecherous Catra’s trembling body underneath her. “Such face. Such eyes. Such body. So untouched by the war, soft, supple, scarless. Please, allow me to have you, to hold you, to—“

Catra was panting, gulping for air, her heart escaping the enclosure of her being and making her entire body shake, tremble, quiver like a leaf as it tried. The ball had ended, her act was done, she was supposed to be safe and alone. She had done good, so why was she not treated good, why was the world so unfair. A sense of bitter nostalgia washed over her about that night of her childhood, where the silky blindfold was ripped from her eyes and she was forced to face the horrors of the world in that glasshouse.

The glasshouse.

“Wait!” She breathed, noticing she was crying hysterically simply because of her voice cracking. She did not stay stop, because she knew the monster atop of her would not stop, but she would make it wait, buy a little time, survive for a while. Enough to breathe and think. The monster only stilled when Catra said in a tone that masked her entire terror by slightly seductive indifference. “I know of a better place.”

Her left wrist was cuffed as she walked and walked silently, a shadow she tried to ignore being too close to her, leering and sniffing behind her. Catra was thinking and rethinking what she was about to do and coming to the same conclusion every time.

She climbed the steps leading to the glasshouse door by muscle memory. The duchess is still close, still holding her by the wrist. Catra had being hiding her face and tears and terror behind her curls and mask of indifference, but as soon as she tugged and the duchess complied and moved to step right in front of her, she raised her head high and made her eyes drip with all that was boiling inside her heart.

The hatred, the anger, the resentment, both towards her and all those so alike her, who only saw Catra as a piece of meat to enjoy and discard, at the nobility, at the royal court, at the regent. Everyone who had hurt Catra in her life, everyone in her life.

The duchess gasped before Catra pushed her, too surprised with the glare of absolute human hate instead of the compliance she had expected, and that surprise preoccupied her enough that she did not notice the predator behind her.

Blood sprayed on Catra's face, momentarily making her close her eyes, not seeing the gory scene in front of her, but hearing all so clearly. The anguished screams, the cracks of bone, the tearing of tissue and flesh, the dripping of blood and guts on the floor. And finally the strange breeze-like sound of all of that disappearing into nothingness.

The regent swayed slightly, from the euphoria, from her satiety, from her appetite quelled. She had been so very hungry, and now she was not.

Catra had done that. She knew the regent would be spent after the night, that she would be hiding in her glasshouse, like a hungry animal in her lair, keeping the thirst at bay by a few sips, and instead Catra had delivered to her a full meal.

Catra had killed someone, using the regent, and only because she wanted to.

She was busy realising what she had just done and did not notice the regent walking with sluggish steps toward her until her hand met her cheek. She wiped the blood off the bridge of her nose and the high of her cheekbones before holding her left cheek. So gently, so tenderly, so unlike how she always touched Catra.

She pulled her hand back only to slip it under her mask and lick the blood off of it, continuing to stare at Catra, and when she finally finished, she said in a voice Catra would never forget. "You are so much like me."

Catra did not run from the glasshouse during the night, she simply walked. She was not a girl anymore, she was a woman, and she was not the prey anymore but the predator, not the victim but the villain. For the first time she was not the one who was hurt but who hurt others. Not feeling sick because of it made her feel so.

Even if she had not said it, Catra disagreed with the regent's statement. She didn't have to explain it, no one explains why the sun rises from the east or why the plant grows upwards or why rain falls from clouds,, it simply doss, and Catra simply was nothing like her.

But after she continued doing it, she started to believe it.

It was her revenge. The eternian duchess was not the first one, and after years Catra doubted there would be a last one. A brightmoonian lady, a salinean baroness, so many more, all the same, all with eyes and tongues and hands that were never punished, and so Catra punished them. Lured them when she was angered, gave them a sense of victory and safety before she finally let it all go, her glares were exchanged for words, yelling what she always whispered to herself and longed to scream at the world, memorising their shocked faces before pushing them into their bloody doom.

She grew to leave as soon as she heard the screaming, not entertained enough to stay and see her final work. See the proof that maybe the regent was right, the entire royal court was right.

That she was not a daughter of the queens, not cyra the second or her wife, not halfmoonian, not a princess, not a royal, not a result of love between women. After all, she had only shared her surface and name with them. While with the regent it was much deeper, from her words to beliefs to foreign accent, imitating her mannerism and behaviours, inheriting her cruelty, her ruthlessness, her inhumanity.

Ah, she was like her. She was her produce, her spawn, her creation.

She was her daughter.

—♛—

Catra was two decades of age when she made her second friend.

Her friend was pale haired and broad shouldered, with gentle eyes and words, she was also her teacher.

Catra's education had always seemed like an afterthought. Her teachers and tutors in a constant state of exchange, she barely remembered half of their names. Her lessons were enough so she won't wound up an invalid, but not enough to teach her anything worthwhile of the world. During infancy, it consisted mostly of her expertise in the basic foundation of literacy and mathematics and logic. And after her coming of age, all revolving around etiquette

and decorum, not about the politics or the world's geography or anything that would serve her as a princess or a queen.

Nothing about the national world, all its living beings, the history of it. Nothing for her to truly learn. And like all the things in Catra's life, save for the whispering woods, it was beyond her control.

Her teacher wanted her to believe the opposite. During her first lessons, she would constantly try to engage Catra in the conversation, asking for her own thoughts and never interrupting during the rare times Catra actually would answer, and always giving Catra the option.

It was foreign, new, dangerous. Catra had not budged during the first days, paranoid about this trap or new cruel punishment. But with every time she would put her step forward, she would slip over and over. Indulging in this new luxury. Knowledge. Intellectual pleasure.

Until came the day where the teacher asked what she wanted to learn, resigning utmost control to Catra solely, whatever she wanted and how and why.

"I've always wanted to learn about the sky." She had always wanted to learn about the whole world, in all honesty. But the few things she already saw from the earth, the pain and punishment and cruelty, made it undesirable, and the ocean was too far away and unimaginable. And so the sky seemed like a new safe point to start.

And so she had learned marvelous things, how day and night came, the formation of clouds, the reason behind the rain and storm and snow, and so much beyond too. Stars and planets and galaxies. All too cosmically big and wide and vast and so very beautiful.

And like all good things in Catra's life, except for the whispering woods, it came to a fast abrupt end.

One regular day, she had walked into the library that always seemed like a dusty gift from a councillor she barely met, but after the emergence of the teacher, became her second haven inside the tower. Only to find a strange face in the seat where her teacher must be.

She had not uttered a word to the stranger, had not spent a second in that library. She instead walked straight towards the puppeteer who has always pulled the strings in the theatre stage of her life.

For the first time in her life, Catra entered the regent's glasshouse out of her own volition.

The regent was sitting in her armchair, tables and desks surrounding her, scrolls and letters and papers on it, her doing the onerous job of maintaining control of halfmoon. And yet her attention was pulled towards queen's game, the checkered board and small pieces a hideous display for Catra, she was forced to

play from time to time, she never won and never wanted to. She knew what that board meant to the regent, what joke it was. And that fuelled her anger further.

"Bold, are we?" The regent crooned at her incorrigible burst of doors. If Catra had any sense of sanity, she would die before doing that. But the regent seemed slightly entertained, she might have been sated recently, her mood bright, bemused instead of furious.

"What did you do?" Catra hissed through clenched teeth. Her head was swimming with the horrible possibilities, of all the things done to her friend, to how much can the regent's cruelty involve, making her dizzy and disoriented and oh-so-angry.

"Who?"

"My teacher!" Red painted Catra's cheeks in embarrassment at not even knowing her friend's name, never asking for it. "The woman who has been teaching me for a year!"

The regent tilted her head slightly, letting the silence grow thick and heavy, and then, in a mocking and amused tone said, "You do always succeed in surprising me, c'yra. I would've assumed someone as foolish as you would have notice how your teachers are assigned for one year only, and yet. I shouldn't have, did I?"

She finished her talk with a chuckle and Catra got lost inside her mind.

"But—"

She stopped her mouth. She couldn't continue that statement, that line of thought. But what? She thought because she wanted it then it would happen? That the turn of events in this world would change its axis because she commanded too? That she had the choice or option?

But she was her friend.

Even when she had tried her hardest not to speak any of what she was thinking, it seemed as if the regent could hear it clearly, as clearly as Catra could, even behind the mask, hear her smile.

Rage.

Catra could feel the waves and rushes of a sea of uncontrollable and devastating rage, one with a dam she had spent twenty years building, all of it breaking into nothing, as that sea flooded her entire world.

She wished she could say she wasn't in control when she stepped forward, when she hurriedly made her way to the regent, when she unsheathed her claws, and she desperately above all wishes

she could say she wasn't in control when she slashed the regent's mask in half.

But that would be untrue, she had been in control of it all, she was conscious of it, she wanted it.

Catra ran away from her crime before hearing the regent's scream of rage, one rivalling her own, but she had been too slow, too weak. It was too late.

The so familiar feel of the chains made of absolute shadow and darkness wrapped around her, halting her escape and pulling her down and down, no matter how hard she fought against it, fuelled by a well of strength unknown to her.

When she couldn't fight the chains, she lunged to claw at the regent, a madwoman's ordeal. But it was all futile in the end, soon enough, she was pinned to the glasshouse blank tiles, chains crossing over her chest and legs and face as she was pinned in place like a butterfly on a board. And despite all, Catra was still thrashing minutely, unintelligent growls and grunts making their way out of a mouth she had trained for so wrong.

"Look at you!" The regent screamed from some place higher than her, Catra couldn't turn her face from how tightly the chain dug into her left cheek. It seemed that the regent had recovered from the shock of seeing her whipping girl take hold of the whip for the first time. "A madwoman, all because you could not have what you wanted! You have been too coddled, spoiled to the core, you

haven’t seen the horrors of the world and now you go and seek them. What kind of broken creature are you?!”

Catra tightly closed her eyes, lowering her ears as low as possible since she couldn’t block them with her hands, the sea that fuelled her act had all but dried up, and Catra reverted back to the small cowering girl who had nightmares of this glasshouse more than all.

The regent knelt beside her on one knee, threaded her fingers through Catra’s curls and pulled her upwards to face her, the friction of the chain made cuts appear and bleed of Catra’s face and upper body, Catra did not scream or sob or whimper. She growled even when pain overwhelmed and she glared back at the regent’s bare corpse-like face.

“I’ve been too lenient, clearly. You will learn what it is like to suffer.” She whispered into Catra’s ears, before thrusting her head against the ground and knocking her out.

When Catra opened her eyes some time after. She found herself in her tower, her inner chambers.

And the realisation of it all, her teacher’s absence, her mad act, the regent’s cruel words, the shallow cuts all over her, the pain on the back of her head, the reminder that she will never gain control of her own life, made her tip back her head like a wild animal and scream as high as she can.

When her voice ran out and she lay gasping on the ground, she was not yet satisfied. So she stood up, and destroyed everything in her path. Throwing and tearing and breaking all she can lay her hand inside her chamber, until she stood atop a puddle of scattering feathers and wood and ceramic and fabric and so many other things she can not name because she never learned what they were, and she never will now.

She wanted to scream again but her voice was too hoarse, she wanted to cry, she wanted to destroy more things, she simply wanted to stop feeling like that.

She needed to go to the whispering woods, she needed to see melog and lay on the grass floor. That always helped her, her whispering woods visits were what must have kept her sane and resilient throughout the years living inside this horror house of a castle.

But a strange thing blocked her entrance where the beautifully engraved doors were. Like a blanket made of shadow and darkness, of blackness, of nothing. She tried to touch it, but as soon as she did, it began pulling her inside like a deep lake. She pulled it back, she threw a table leg at it and it broke into a shower of wooden splinters. Catra realised what that was, a barrier.

She began laughing, slowly at first, few and far between chuckles, and then hysterically. It was not funny, the furthest thing from it, but the absurdity of it all, at the limitless extent of how nightmarish Catra’s pitiful life was, made her laugh. If she didn’t she would start crying.

Which was exactly what happened as soon as her laughs died down. She climbed down onto her bed as uncontrollable tears of anger and anguish rained down on the blankets and cushions.

"I hate you." Catra said, not screamed, not whispered, simply said into no one, and kept saying it repeatedly like a mantra. Even as her eyes fluttered into slumber, her lips kept mouthing the words. Her own proof of her pain, the only evidence she had in a trail that would never come.

Days passed.

When the regent finally came to visit catra, she found a nonmoving tightly wounded ball in the centre of the room. She had forsaken the feel of her bed after the third night.

The accumulative effect of being imprisoned inside her own room, the thirst and the hunger, the pain and fever from the untreated wounds, the heavy agony inside her heart, all left her in a half dead catatonic state.

The regent smiled at the display, she looked so pitiful, night gown failing to conceal her shivering bony frame, hair unbraided and messy and pooling around her ankles, face hidden behind elbows and knees. And so, so gently, she knelt down beside her. So tenderly, she stroked her head. So motherly, she comforted her.

“Look at how much you made me hurt you, and for what? To indulge in more luxuries, learn what you will never use, befriend people who will always leave you. Why do you do this to yourself, c’yra?” She tucked a loose curl behind her bare ear and whispered. “You know you will never live long enough to be queen anyway, don’t you?”

With her face hidden, her body limp, Catra did not give in an indication that she knew, but she did. She did even before she realised that she did, she didn’t hen she was young, she might have had dreams and hopes but as she got older, she knew. She knew so instinctively that she would never sit on that throne, never wear that crown, never have that power. It will never happen. It’s something she had a lifetime to understand and she did. But hearing it so clearly, so proudly, so triumphantly in the regent’s voice, made her unable to accept it.

She stood, very slowly and dizzily due to the pain and fatigue, but she did, and only after she stood high and mighty over the regent’s surprised kneeling form, she finally spoke, her voice hoarse from the thirst and disuse and weeping. “And who shall stop me?”

She had surprised the regent, after these three hard days, that was all the victory she needed. The regent stood quickly to fix the posture and towered over Catra, in a barely controlled tone, she said, “are you really his moronic, are you simply acting? I refuse to believe creatures so broken would exist in the world with us, and yet if they did. I wouldn’t be surprised for it met you.”

“I’m not moronic,” Catra replied, with a voice so weak but a soul so strong. “Or foolish, or weak, or as broken as you think I am.

You tried for so long to teach me that, convince me. But I don’t believe you, and I never will.”

The regent was angry, the shadows in the room trembling at the same frequency as her fists, she would snap in anyway moment. But Catra would speak her piece before that happens.

“I know that was your plan all along, I knew when I was child. But I will tell you this: you will not kill me, no matter how much you try, somehow, someday, I will survive you, and I will escape. I promise it”

Catra gasped at the tightness wrapping her chest, cutting her air and voice, making her skin dig into her bones and her bones dig into lungs, the pain almost made her see black but she had to stay upright, just for a little while, just so the regent will not leave this room victorious.

With false calmness, the regent crooned, “care to repeat that?”

Catra took a deep breath, even as she felt her chest constricting like wood and paper, she licked her lips and with hard eyes and a harder mouth she said, “You—” the chain grew tighter.

“—will never—“ tighter.

“—win!”

Catra heard the cracking sound of broken bone before her eyes and her ears succumbed to nothing.

—♛—

Catra had lost touch of time.

The days following the night where the regent very closely came to kill her become a passing blur. An untanglibke feeling just like the pain that turned into dull sense in the background, the shapes of physicians that came to treat her and disappear afterwards, the feeling of the blankets fabric and the cushions and pillows surrounding her on her bed.

It could've been days, years, eons. Catra would not know, would not care.

Just like how she didn’t care when the regent appeared near her left one day, loosening the front lace of her nightgown and inspecting the green and purple bruises painting her chest, tracing them. Catra had not acknowledged her existence, laying like stone as she turned her head to the right and stared at the fluttering curtains before her balcony.

The regent had not spoken to her, and soon enough left, Catra would’ve hoped that was her form of guilt or apology, but she was

too old to hope for something so foolish.

She was too old for so many things.

Her time had run out, her sand clock turned silent.

As slow as a growing seed of a plant, Catra extracted herself from her bed, staggering and swaying towards the curtains, and soon enough, met the night cold air with her tired-to-the-bone face.

Her hands were trembling slightly from the exertion as she clasped the wood of the railing and began to push herself atop it, pain and exhaustion ignored, as she finally stood with her two bare feet on the narrow wood.

Her body was fluttering as her nightgown and curls were with the gentle breeze, it would be so gentle and tender, the wind, hugging her as she met them.

She didn’t want to think about it, wanted to wish that if she was close enough to the sky she would forget the earth, but she couldn’t. Her mind stubbornly supplied her with images of what will happen afterwards, how the queendom would treat her death.

Would they mourn like they mourned her mothers, their queens, most likely not since Catra was never truly their princess, only a pretender of one.

And despite Catra's heart, her head made her imagine would the regent would do when word of Catra's fallen and dead body reach her, would she be pleased, that she was finally free of her, or would she be angry, resenting Catra did taking this thing out if her control, would she desecrate Catra's body in rage when she'll become dead the way she did when she was alive.

Catra did not have an answer, and would not need to search for one. For soon enough, she will be dead.

But before Catra could finally do the kindest thing for self, before she could step off the wood, a stronger gust of breeze made her lose her balance, and trip over her feet.

Catra screamed as she was pulled down by the ever strong gravity, arms flaying madly, until her fist was clasped the bottom of the railings. She whimpered at the pain rushing through, reopening her wounds and making them bleed and taint the white sleeves.

"Help! Catra screamed desperately, maybe the regent hadn't left yet, maybe if the servants or guards could hear her. Someone to save her, anyone. "Help, please!"

And as the silence replied back, she finally understood. No one would save her, no one did in her two decades of life, and no one would do it now. She had no one to ask for help, now to scream for, no one to beg.

Catra sobbed as she felt the strength in her grip begin to weaken, she would fall, she would die, and even that would not be her own choice or option, her own control. It would be the wind and her own clumsy feet and the too long dress.

And that realisation, filled her with a stronger will. Grunting and cleanching her teeth she pulled her other arm and clasp the other side of the railing, and with painful force began to heave herself, upwards, upwards, upwards…

Until she finally climbed over and fell on the balcony floor.

During her days or weeks or months of recovery she had not cried, not from the fear or the anger or the pain, she had used all of her strength not to shed any more tears over her morbid joke of a life.

But now, after escaping death so closely, and all by herself, after saving herself all by herself, she cried.

Fat tears were streaming down her cheek like powerful waterfalls, making the brown of her hair and the white of her collar stuck to her head and neck. Loud sobs and wailing were echoing into the silence of the night only for her to hear and no one else. There, atop a tower no one else lived in, for no one to see and no one to hear, the princess of halfmoon was weeping as if she was only made out of misery and agony and tragedy.

She wished she could cry for eternity, until this sadness could escape her and leave her alone and free, but she wasn't a child anymore, she was old enough to know what she wanted and to know that she could not have it.

But what if she could?

The conflicting, contrasting, entirely opposing idea of how she managed to survive for so long burned alight inside her mind and refused to be put out. She had promised the regent, she had promised herself above all, that she won't let her win, let her determine her death the way she did with her life.

But what if she could defeat her not by dying, but by living. What if should escape her, truly escape her, and win.

The idea was mad, and hysterical and foolish and moronic, all the things she'd been called, and it was near impossible.

But it made her smile.

And as she stood up and wiped her face and made her way back inside the coverage of her inner chambers, Catra promised herself and the world and all who could hear it, that she would escape, survive, win.

She would live.

Chapter End Notes

Trigger warnings:
Descriptions of blood and gore
Descriptions of emotional/psychological abuse
Descriptions of physical abuse and violence
Mentions of forced marriage
Mentions of suicide

Belladonna is an extremely toxic herbaceous plant, that when taken orally can cause severe poisoning even at low doses, but due to its pretty appearance and some of its medicinal properties it symbolised things like duality and the beauty/danger dichotomy, which I think is perfect to describe Catra's childhood under her care and inside the castle, and is why it's the title of this chapter.

For your information, the regent/shadow weaver is lying, birds rarely push their babies out of the nest, they usually encourage them by restricting food and make sure their wings are developed enough, and even if they don't fly they don't die in the nest like catra concluded, some can adapt to their environment on the ground enough to survive. This is a clear indication of sw restricting and weaponing information and catra having a pessimistic view of the world.

And I just wanna say for every woman or person living in a household or at a place where they can't or are actively prohibited from having control of their own lives and the freedom to do with it what they want, never give up hope, it's the strongest thing you can have. And you're not alone, many also struggled like you did, and they managed to get their happy ending. It's never impossible.

Thank you so much for reading! I would love to know your thoughts on the chapter!

Chapter 4: Lotus

Chapter Summary

Is life in paradise permanent or not?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

For many months, Adora and Catra had shared the same life.

They shared their mornings and nights. The same bed, waking up and falling asleep with each other's faces as their last sight.

They had started doing so directly after their first night together. Adora had always been a light sleeper so she easily noticed how many times Catra’s sleep would be interrupted, nightmares plaguing her mind, snores exchanged for whimpers and unintelligent please.

“No. Regent, please.” She had heard her mumble with an asleep yet in-pain face.

So Adora could not convince herself to go back to her lonely bed and leave Catra to battle the enemies her mind conjured alone. Catra had agreed only at the account of Adora’s own sleeping difficulty, noticing how the herbs didn’t help nearly as much as a her own warmth and closeness did.

It was not a lie, but a half truth, each agreeing for the same thing for vastly different reasons and knowing the other didn't know. Adora did not feel guilty for she had noticed how easily Catra would agree to things for Adora's sake instead of her own.

With their arrangement made, each had never had slumber nearly as well. Falling into their places so easily and comfortably, was no emptiness between them, no barrier between their differently colored skins except for the identical white lace of the night gowns they both wear to bed. Catra would drape her body across Adora's like a falling leaf and Adora would wrap sure arms around her waist and back, and their content snores would fill the room until the morning would shine on them.

And it would not be different then. They'd share early warmth and breath no one else did, blankets and legs tangled like vines, each smell burrowing inside the other's. The vulnerability that came with the early hours of dawn where there was no walls and no masks, the whispers and confessions, reserved only for each other as witness.

That closeness was proceed afterwards and outwards.

They shared their meals. The quiet and silence of the dining hall became a long forgotten memory, usurped by their loud laughs and talks between bites. Adora began sitting at Catra's right and with a served plate per Catra's orders, and as much as Adora loved food, especial now halfomoonian cuisine, it did not rival how much she loved seeing Catra brighten in every act whenever she was close, including eating. Seeing how the angularity of her bony shoulders cheeks began to fill and soften so beautifully over the days.

They shared their socials. Adora stopped standing like a statue half a step behind her princess, yes she was her knight but most importantly she her friend, and she acted so during the many courtiers and councillors' visits Catra had all alone and friendless. She began interjecting into the conversation, supporting Catra's every argument, and in less dire and more boring times, would happily supply the service of making Catra laugh with comical faces or whispered jokes, smiling widely as Catra's unashamed laugh rang around the gardens.

They shared their studies. The dust Adora and Catra had cleared when they entered the library together for the first time did not have the opportunity to settle in again. It had become their safe haven, rivalling the whispering woods. And like they did among the tress, the did all sorts of things among the shelves. Reading together and alone, loudly storytelling and playing like a theatre actors or quietly humming the words and sentences with Catra's bare foot over adores lap and with Adora's gauntlets on one of the many of the many tables.

Catra did not stop drawing after her first time, she had started with simple items of the world around her, adding her own abstract and conceptual twists, but as the days passed it seemed that her favourite muse was Adora, as if those paintings had only been practice so she can finally focus on her. Most of the time Adora wouldn't even be disturb, Catra would draw her from memory or as she sat reading on one of the library's many armchairs, but somewhere along the line she had gained the courage enough to ask her for poses, from simples facial expressions to more challenging stances, with her armour or without it, sitting or standing, face placid or expressed richly, until the yellow and white paint became ready resupplied.

Adora of course had said yes for the first request. She had smiled so widely and felt a bloom inside her heart when Catra had showed her her first painting of her, seeing herself through Catra's eyes, she felt immense gratitude at the thought of being immortalised by the hand of her beloved friend. But she had also felt something else, something identified only in the context of being so unlike her other feelings, something faint-as-cemetery familiar. But she did not feel it for long so she did not think of it for long.

They shared their thoughts. The most intimated act of all, and it was the only one where they did not find complete enjoyment in. Adora and Catra agreed on many things, but by their conversations grew deeper, they began to realise that they also disagreed on an equal amount of things. Their worst conversation, one that had to be cut short when Adora's fists began to shake and Catra's claws began to protrude, were about a topic of something that dictated both lives so irrevocably: war. Adora's jaw was dropped to the tilework and her mind went quiet when Catra told her how she thought war was useless, immature, childish. It was a wrong statement in every sense of the word And Adora tried to make Catra see that, bringing up economical profit and geographical expansion und personal glory and so much more. But Catra had disagreed and offered a solution for every point until they reached a tense statement and there was no further action to be taken but to change course.

But that had been a rare occurrence. Most of their conversations were beyond amiable, with trust and agreeability as its centre. They confided in each other mortifying secrets, philosophical beliefs, pointless chats, and even childhood stories, enthusiasm the least found ingredient in the latter.

They had shared so much of time, of self, of soul, of mind and body and heart. Then poured into each other the essence of their own personhoods, until each began to fill and overflow, intermixing with the other, affecting and influencing and changing.

It was inevitable.

Adora began changing Catra to a knight. A fighter, a warrior. Catra did not forget Adora’s offer and Adora held true to her words.

It had been difficult. At the start, they had prepared everything, designated a clear area in the Whispering Woods, filled a bag with all sorts of weapons from Adora’s to the guards’, it was not stealing Catra convinced her, those weapons belonged to the castle and so belonged to the princess, but the rest wasn't as easy or clear.

Adora had grown up and was raised among punches and weapons, knew the language of the blade as good as her mother tongue, was taught to fight as soon as she could walk. It was her second nature, her first instinct. How can she even begin to explain it to someone. How does someone answer the question of how how to breath, how to blink. Adora didn’t know, but since Catra was the one asking, she would try to.

They had moved clumsily against each other at first, Adora hesitant and scared, Catra over enthusiastic and reckless, but soon enough they had began to match each other’s rhythms.

Catra had mastered bodily combat it easily and quickly. She had perfect control of her limbs and organs. She was agile and nimble, fast and swift. Inherently knew where to strike to exert the most force with the necessary strength. And to Adora's horror, she had quiet the pain tolerance.

But they didn't stop there, it wasn't just about self protection, Catra wanted to have the power to inflict harm, and the choice to do so or not, and Adora had found out that she can never tell Catra no.

Catra wanted to move to the next thing immediately, eyeing the collection of weapons Adora refused to touch and kept a safe distant a way, so they did. Starting with the staff.

Days were spent teaching and training, adjusting holds and postures, repeating strikes and dodges and trick, until the day of their sparring finally arrived.

They had switched clothes. None of what resided in Catra's wardrobes sufficed for spars so Adora had lent her the knightly silks unearth her armour. The ends of her trousers were rolled back and cuffed at her bare ankles and the collar of her shirt stubbornly sliding over one shoulder, with her hair tied high with a ribbon. Adora contented in wearing Catra's a little short long sleeved nightgown and braided hair.

They stood like mirrors against each other, each grasping her staff with two hands and perpendicular to her body, pose the same, countenance the same. Adora began counting downwards, and soon as she the number escaped her lips, Catra lunged.

Adora held the urge to back away and allow her the space, she did so many times before and each time made Catra angrier and angrier until Adora rewired her muscle memory to fight Catra like an equal many times until she did. Every strike budged, every dodge interrupted. Catra was a fast-learner and an apt pupil, but Adora was born to fight.

They had reached an centre, staffs against each other, each grunting with the force of it. But Adora pushed further until Catra dropped to one knee, she was holding her staff perfectly straight as she pushed back against Adora's but Adora could see her arms straining against the force, she knew she would back down any second down.

She was wrong.

Catra surprised her, she had had the same realisation as Adora's, that she couldn't battle her on brute strength so she changed tactic. She let go, relented her grip on her staff and turned her body on the opposite direction, allowing for Adora's to hit her on the back. Adora was shocked and disoriented by the turn of events, and Catra took that to the her advantage. She anchored the end of her staff on the grass flower, and with all her strength pulled it upwards, striking Adora straight on the jaw with the opposite end.

The startling pain of the blow made Adora unseeing and unstanding, her grip on her weapon waning, Catra hurried for her victory, kicking Adora on her torso and landing her on her back, before straddling atop of her with the staff's wood against vulnerable neck. It was done.

For a moment no one said anything, both facing each other with wide eyes and gulping mouths until Catra narrowed her eyes and pulled her staff back, before thrusting the end before Adora's face.

With a hoarse voice she said, "Proomise me you weren't holding back."

Adora was too dizzy to even come up with a lie or a tease, she was completely truthful when stammered, "I- I wasn't."

Catra looked her at the eye, searching, finding finally. And then her face broke into a huge smile, unbidden happiness and pride and joy. She threw herself atop Adora once again, hugging her tightly. Her gratitude was undeniably clear.

Adora groaned though, Catra's head on her shoulder knocked on her jaw and lit the pain anew. When Catra pulled back, she gasped, finger tentatively touching the gash on the side of Adora's face, her own doing.

Her eyes were sad and guilty as she helped Adora upwards and told her, 'that needs to be cleaned, there's a river nearby."

Hand in hand, Catra led Adora.

As Adora kneeled by the river's side and cleaned the blood and dirt off the wound, Catra was rummaging through the weapon's on the grassfloor.

"Woah," she said from behind.

When Adora turned to see what Catra picked, she scowled.

She never liked whips, they were too fluid and unsure, slippery in the hand. They made the body move for it not the other way around, weapon commanding the hand instead of the opposite. They were very rarely useful, also.

She told Catra all that, in a, in her opinion, a very unbiased and objective manner. But Catra only laughed and said, "That only means you just don't like them."

Adora groaned loudly, getting to her feet, "They're barely a weapon. Here, there are much better options, here."

As she rummaged between the blades and wood, she could see from the corner of her eye Catra hiding the whip inside one of her

pockets, but pretended like she didn’t. What she didn’t actually do was see Catra’s other hand reach for the scabbard on her hip.

“What about a sword then?”

Catra flinched when Adora’s fist encircled her wrist harshly, and Adora let go immediately, apologies already slipping from her mouth, trying to erase Catra’s scared stare. “I’m so sorry.”

She knew before now Catra never liked being touched suddenly, and she had never forgotten since, except this once.

“It's okay.” Catra sighed as Adora kept offering apologies but no explanation.

“Here!” Adora thrust a bow and arrow in Catra’s direction, enthusiastically redirecting the conversion.

Catra looked at them with small disdain, fingers limply holding both items. “I don’t want to be an archer. It seems too distant and faraway.”

“Well, being far from the danger can help sometimes. Come on, at least try it.”

“I’ve never been far from the danger,” Catra whispered under her breath but obliged as Adora gestured for her.

They stood exactly against each other. Adora’s front to Catra’s back, too close. Adora’s face reddened even as she refocused her mind on adjusting Catra’s grip on the bow and the arrow.

Adora’s mouth was rattling off technical details and information, but her mind and her ears did not listen, occupied with other things.

And it seemed like Catra’s was too.

The no desire and enthusiasm she had for archery gave space for other things to focus on, and soon enough Catra’s eyes weren’t on the tree target, but on Adora’s face, Adora’s eyes, Adora’s lips—

“Alright!” Adora snatched herself away from Catra’s near embrace, quickly enough to almost trip backwards. “You don’t have to if you don’t want to. And you’re right, archery doesn’t suit you anyway. What about daggers?”

That actually did pull her attention and Adora sighed in relief when Catra stopped looking like at her with a face too precious and red. She has taken the dagger from Adora’s hand and put it nearby her own claws, comparing the edge and length of each.

“I already have daggers and knives on my hand.” She said.

“But that is the difference.” Adora defended, genuine and truthful. “You do not need to use your body like a weapon, you can have something else to bear the brunt and the blow.”

Catra was looking at her contemplatively and then back at the weapon and hand, after a moment, she nodded, “alright.”

Adora smiled, and they restarted the same journey they did with staff with the new weapon.

And, in turn, Catra started changing Adora to a princess. The only image of one she knew, at least.

First time they arrived to the tower after they're first combat, Adora went to her own room to wash, Catra refused. She urged Adora to join her in her bathing chambers, Adora had been understandably very hesitant, but at catra's pleads and the argument of that being her return of favour and her urging Adora to allow her to at least do this for her made her relent.

It had been easy. After the first time, adorn enthusiastically joined, it had been such along time since water that hot massaged her tense muscles and made her body as putty as clay, the mere memory made her sigh. The baths were also big enough that both to sit vertically opposite from one another but it seemed that Catra’s affection translated fluently to inside baths too.

Both were flushing red from the heat, damp hair sticking to foreheads and neck, the steam barely enough to hide each other’s nudity. Adora willed her eyes to wonder anywhere except for Catra’s direction, the latter did not share the sentiment.

She was so very close. Face propped atop her interlinked arms on the baths rim, watching her with an expression Adora knew she would be able to decipher if the fog-like steam wasn't so thick, and it scared her.

Catra then moved. Raised her hand which was dripping with rosewater towards Adora’s direction, and brushed her blonde hair behind her right ear.

“I like your hair free like this.” Catra said, and then asked. “Why do you always braid it so tightly?”

"I did not always do that," Adora could only say.

"Why did you start then?" Asked Catra, and Adora knew she would, and yet she couldn’t answer, barely mumbling. “Maybe in another time, it's along story"

"I have time," said Catra, but Adora only hummed at that.

Silence joined them, but Catra wasn’t perturbed by adora’s tone, and so shooed it away.

Inn a deep and sultry voice, Adora had not had it directed to her not even once, Catra said, "you're very beautiful, Adora.” and Adora forgot how to breath.

As soon as she remember to inhale before exhaling, she gave an answer hoping it was equally in tone and honesty, "Not anywhere as beautiful as you!"

Catra chuckled. But it wasn't entirely joyous. She held up the same hand she had touched Adora with so gently with and said daringly, "are you sure?"

Adora did not know what Catra was showing her at first, and when she did, she gasped. At catra's wrist and then at what further inspection showed her, at her shoulders, chest, neck, back. The only pieces she could see above the water.

Scars littered her body, deep lacerated ugly ones. Ones done purposefully and intentionally, out of hate and anger and resentment, they looked like they hurt even when they were healed, but definitely not as much as when they were given to her.

Adora knew who did it but she couldn't speak about it, instead she asked in dry voice, "How have I never saw them before?" Catra’s

dresses and night gowns and entire wardrobe definitely showed that amount of skin and yet this was the first anyone had ever beheld them.

Catra turned away from her as she spoke, "She has the servants cover them, paint, fabric, whatever that could hide her mistaken." She chuckled mirthlessly when she said. "Can't let anyone see how ruined her doll is."

Adora was quick to speak the truth, "I don't think you're ruined, Catra." She said, insistently, urgently, "I think you're still very beautiful."

That did not please Catra not as much us Adora thought it would, but she still made her smile. Before Adora could open her mouth and speak more, to face the topics they so strongly avoid, more rose water was damped over them by the servants. The meoment was interrupted, but Catra giggled at it so Adora couldn't find it inside of her to be that displeased.

The servant began and did not stop beatifying Adora as much as they did Catra. Her braid became much more intricate than she could ever manage to do, little braids starting from her temples until they were pulled enough into tho long plait cascading down her back, curled blonde strands trickled her cheek, pearls were tucked in. It was too beautiful work to be hidden underneath her metallic helmet.

The helmet which had a lavish feather sprouting suddenly from behind, complimenting the other changes on her armour, frills

underneath metal, ornate cravings found every day. Softer and more embroiled silks underneath. It was all so very unknightlike, but Adora did not care as long as Catra liked it.

They had truly shared everything. Except for one.

The regent.

Her power eclipsed Catra’s desire to have Adora attend her visits alongside her the way she did with the other courtiers. So little was changed from Adora’s perspective.

Only difference was how Catra would share with her more than she did before, even if not completely. Even after Adora had uncovered the truth, Catra was resistant to speaking about the regent. And with every new information rarely extracted, Adora could understand why.

Thankfully, she had been busy of late, which made her and Catra’s visits shorter, and Catra’s wellness longer.

"It’s because of the halfyear’s halfmoon." Catra had answered when adora commented.

Adora remembered reading about it, in one of the many halfmoonian cultural books she read to try und know catra more.

So she knew enough to ask, "Have you ever attend the capital-city’s festival for it?"

Catra looked at her with tired eyes- she wasn't always against Adora’s seditionist ideas, as rare as they come, but she was always skeptical and calculating of each know, she said, "No. And before you say I should do it, I wont. I don't see the appeal, especially considering the last time I left.” she had a resentful gaze that was directed only at herself. She shooed the idea away with her hand and her mouth. "It is just not worth the risk"

That was not what Adora wanted to hear. She has stopped walking through the garden walkways, causing Catra to stop too. She knelt down in front of her, a gesture she learned recently that showed how much more comfortable and receptive Catra became when she had to look down instead of up at someone.

"Catra," Adora started, taking her bejewelled and manicured hands into her gantleted ones. "Believe me, it is entirely worth the risk. And it would not be like the last time, you had come so far and changed so much. Don’t you want to start again?”

Catra looked downwards when she whispered "I'm afraid"

"That doesn't have to mean anything if you don’t want it to," Adora whispered back. Insisting and insisting and insisting.

Until Catra said yes.

—♕—

They had dressed like no other for the night, like no princess, and no knight.

Adora had left her armour and helmet behind, opting for red breeches with halfmoonian style gold embroidery on the sides, coupled with a loose white blouse with ruffles on the hem and sleeves making her feel like a dove, and when she threaded her fingers through her blonde hair to braid she stopped herself and changed her mind, opting to tie her hair high on her head with a white ribbon, the way she did before.

She didn't have to wait long for Catra like she used to, she exited the dressing rooms in relatively the same time. Catra had also left her dress and crown behind. She instead wore short bloomers coupled with a commoner’s corset and sleeves, all barely visible under her thick dark cloak, and her hair was entirely free like it never was, no braids or twists or jewellery, wild curls cascading over her hood, with only a crown of flowers adorning it, some Adora recognised from the gardens and some from the whispering woods, different colors and shapes of petals and stems surrounding Catra’s head like a halo.

Catra twilled and Adora realised that she had never seen her move as freely, she asked, "How do I look?"

And Adora said because she knew it would make Catra smile, "Unlike a princess."

Tonight was apparently, a night of surprises, for from the start it was changed and unfamiliar, Catra had stopped Adora from mounting swift wind and asked “can I ride him for this once? Take the lead?”

And Adora couldn't think of a reason against it so she relented and sat at the rear of her own alicorn for the first time. She had reluctantly circled Catra’s waist for safety but as Catra laughed harder and charged at the sky faster, she found herself holding both to and for dear life. Until all her senses were erased by the altitude they were on and replaced with of Catra’s closeness. Catra’s smell filling her nose, Catra’s hair tickling her cheeks, Catra’s warmth against the cold night, Catra’s everything satiating her like no other. Catra’s face red and gleaming of sweat and joy after successfully descending an alicorn for the first time.

Adorns attention was concentrated on Catra, and Catra Adora, but as the sounds and movements began to fill the blank paper of their surroundings, they were both pulled to different directions.

The festival of the half years half moon was a magnificence to behold, it seemed no matter how many days she would spend in, halfmoon would not stop mesmerising Adora with its beauty.

And Catra too. It was an entirely new world to her too, and underneath the awe Adora could detect a sheen of familiar fear in her eyes. As a solution, Adora took Catra’s hand in hers like she

did before, Catra smiled at the gesture and the memory before leading Adora by their interlocked hands deeper into the festival.

"Let's start there!"

They started with learning the idea and concept behind the day's celebration. They had both read about it, side by side, but Catra wanted to see how people tell stories and how similar or different they are from books.

They had met every storyteller. Orators, puppeteers, bards, all saying the same thing in different ways.

"The halfyear’s halfmoon is not for celebrating the beginning or end, it’s for the in between, for the middle. For acknowledging the steps you have already taken and for the steps you have yet to take, to rest from walking the path and see how far you've come before continuing on. We don't celebrate the past or the future but the present, the now, the today." Said the last storyteller they visited.

Adora could not take her eyes off Catra, the words urged her too. She was so very proud of her, of what she had done, of where she came from, more proud than Adora every felt about herself. It had hurt, her eyes were overfilling with tears the way her heart was overfilling with pride and gratitude and… love.

Catra turned to face her, Adora hurriedly rubbed her tears and thoughts off before Catra would notice and she thought she succeeded when Catra only said,"All this listening and watching and standing made me hungry. Let’s go find food.”

Adora followed Catra’s hurried lead, thinking she must be even more hungry than she said, but when they finally reached a table filled from all kinds of food and desserts, Catra took one treat in hand and brought it into Adora’s lips instead of her own.

Adora flustered and said in stutters, "I'm not hungry. "

Catra did not relent, "You haven’t eaten since the morning."

“Neither have you, you deserve it more."

"Why?" Catra challenged, "I'm not a princess, not tonight."

Adora had no retort to that, but she still didn’t accept it.

Catra groaned. "Fine. You clearly can’t leave your silly chivalry behind with that armour so how about this,” she stopped nearer, the crumbs getting on adores pink lips."You will eat this but only because I want to and you have to check your princess's food for poison, isn’t that so?"

Adora did not say yes, but she immediately opened her mouth auld allowed Catra to feed her the treat.

As soon as she swallowed it and registered the deliciousness and clear non poison filling her tongue she took a identical one and brought over Catra’s lips.

Catra was much better recipient than her, opening her mouth and easily accepting and humming in delight while eating.

Adora thought that every positive word must belong to Catra, and even though she will never eat her, she thought Catra would definitely be delicious.

Their enjoyment of the food had to be interrupted sadly, because a group of people collected all the trays while hurriedly offering explanations such as contestants.

Catra's eyes sparkled at the idea, contests, the concept of game and challenge and competition, of winning.

After a quick scan, She quickly grabbed adora's arm and pulled her into the general direction of the contests and games, and sat on the first empty slot she found.

Catra had every won single game, from puzzles and riddles to optical tricks, she wasn't deceived by sleight of hand or confusing

terminology, or queen’s game. One by one, the contesters grew wary of her and her large sack of coins that she kept inside her cloak’s pocket like spoils of war.

Adora felt embarrassed, she loved winning almost us equally Catra, both meaning true, but from the first game she joined she failed miserably.

"Perhaps you should something more suited to your talents." Catra offered when she noticed how strongly Adora took losing, “Like that." she said, gesturing to a ring circling two arm wrestlers.

Adora hesitated, it's been so long since she fought someone amiably, not wasn't Catra, not someone she trusted with her life and doesn't remember she started to. Also, the participant were very clearly more suited to winning. Her soon-to-be opponent had shoulders double the size of hers, and Adora was not a frail woman.

Catra saw adores hesitancy and mistook it for fear,"Come here." she demanded and pulled her closed, standing on her toes she whispered in Adora’s ear. “If you win, I will give you a kiss as a prize.”

Adora’s face remained flaming hot ever after Catra stole back her warmth by stopping back and out of the way for the ring.

The man was condescendingly eyeing Adora, which was unfamiliar in halfmoon and all of Etheria but oh so familiar where Adora came from.

She knew what to do. Adora squared her shoulders and tensed her muscles and was prepared when her opponents hand clasped hers. With a grant, he smashed her hand against the wood, or, that what he wanted and what was supposed to happen but Adora held on and soon enough they were stuck in a stalemate that Adora knew she would lose if she didn't end this soon.

She hoped the half moons light wasn't bright enough, she hoped none was looking at her directly, she hoped Catra was looking at her arm instead of face.

While unlocking something deep deep inside for something as childish as this Adora noticed of a faint glow from the corners of her eyes and with a yell smashed her opponents arm on the table’s wood and won.

The crowd around her screamed in a delight, what an unexpected twist, the people are entertained. Adora didn't care what the people wanted, only one, and she found her befor she did.

Catra was giving Adora a kiss on the cheek, and as soon as Adora realised what happened, it had stopped

She wanted to rewind time.

"You're so strong." Catra breathed to the side of her face.

Adora giggled uncontrollably and thanked her.

Their sentimentality was interrupted because of an emasculated man, Adora was offered her prize in coins and her opponent tried to steal it which resulted in an uproar. Adora and Catra left the scene together, hand in hand, laughing uncontrollably like children.

They fond a sanctuary in a quiet and dark place, to collect their breath, step away from the extremes of the crowd, find comfort in each other’s solitude.

It had taken them a lot of time to finally quiet down and stop laughing, but as soon as the did they realised they were on a behind a performance stage, the music and song of the performers filling their space.

Adora’s inhibitions and walls had disappeared for the night and for the first time since she stepped foot inside this queendom Adora spoke about something of her past unprompted.

"I used to sing when I was young.” Adora told Catra, solely because she wanted to.

And maybe it was for additional proof, or maybe Adora just missed it, or maybe Adora just wanted to mesmerise Catra the way she did so much her, but then she started singing.

Sound vibrating through her throat, breathing leaving her lungs, voice carrying so much that Adora kept hidden, singing a sleep lullaby that was a crucial part of her childhood. It was too precious, she was showing centra something so deeply her and wishing for nothing but for her to accept it.

And she did.

Catra looked at her exactly what the eyes wanted.

Adora was giddy and flustered, rubbing of her neck.

"Wow." Catra finals said after recovering by from her awe, "I wish I could do that."

"You already have such a beautiful voice.” Adora said truly, and triumphed at Catra blushing at the compliment. "I could teach you how to use it."

It was a repeated memory, combat exchanged for songs.

And just like before, Catra was a quick study. Standing before each other, two hands clasped two hands, the two of them shared the melody, the tune, two voices becoming one as it filled the space around then and existed only in their world.

It see,we like forever, until it was not.

Their world was breached, Catra yelped and Adora could barely see a small shadow escaping before Catra followed after it swiftly.

“Catra, wait!" Adora called, a sense of familiarity telling her what it could be.

Catra was fast, so by the time Adora caught up to her, she had the culprit cornered.

It was a child, just like Adora suspected, clutching in his small bony hands Catra’s tail ring.

Catra was standing stone-still, face wide with incomprehension. So Adora explained with a hand on her shoulder, “He must be hungry, he just wanted to got some money." She said hurriedly, worrying about this igniting Catra sense of indignity.

Catra was looking to her with a strange face, and then she turned to the small trembling child.

Adora was tense, not knowing if she should intervene as Catra drew closer. She knelt to the ground close to the child and outstretched her hand, it wasn’t empty, she wasn't asking for the jewellery back, she was offering in her hand the sack of coins she won.

No words were exchanged, the child couldn't believe his luck and so took the gift und ran away.

Catra was quit for some time then she turned to Adora and said," I never knew— the regent always boasted about how rich halfmoon is.”

"Not everywhere." Adora answered her unasked question. "They're forced out of the castle-city, it’s a different world outside of riches.”

Catra was looking downwards, deep in thought, face so heartbreakingly sad for the first time in the night, "I wasn’t the only one halfmoon hurt," she said in a small tone of realisation. “there's so many others.”

That was exactly the reality Adora wanted Catra to acknowledge at their earlier days, but she was only understand half of it, too focused on the tragedy.

"Yes, "Adora took her shoulders in hand, wanting her to understand,"but it doesn’t have to be like that forever. You could do them what you did to yourself, you can save them, you can be their queen. You can fix it all.”

Catra’s eyes was alarmingly wide and unbelieving, so Adora offered with a smile, “I know you can.”

Care sprung, pushing Adora step back with the force of her hug, arms so tightly around waist. Adora quickly reciprocated, wrapped her arms around catra’s back.

Into the fabric and meat of Adora’s chest Catra whispered, "Thank you."

They stayed like that a long long time, and it was still not enough, they only separated out of surprise when light shined on their faces.

Sunrise.

Catra turned to face Adora with a face of urgency. "There's some place we here to be in. Hurry!” She said before taking Adora’s in hand in hers and almost running out of the quiet and into the waking day.

They found themselves atop a small hill at the outskirts of the castle-city. "I wish I could say I used to sit on this hill as a child, that it was somehow an important part of my home which I discovered all on my own," Catra said neutrally while hiding a hint of sadness."but I didn't, I founded it in a map, and wanted to watch the sunrise with you atop it. l hope that's enough."

Adora sat beside Catra and mirrored her posture, legs tucked underneath with her face and torso angled to the side to face her, and said in all truthfulness, "It's more than enough."

Catra did not seem sure, "You do so much for me, you spoil me, you care for me, I can only hope to pay back the price."

"There is no price, Catra" Adora said. "I only did it for you"

"But why? I don't understand, there has to he a reason."

"If there was, then you have to tell, because I do not know it"

They sat in silence afterwards, watching the beauty of the sun's birth.

Only after the sun had risen above the horizon, did Adora whispered "It's very beautiful."

Catra turned to face her, and asked, "the most beautiful thing you've ever been?”

They were so close, their face a finger away, nose almost touching and when when she spoke, Adora could taste Catra’s breath.

"No.” She whispered, the most honest she had ever been. “You?”

"Me neither." Catra said.

They didn't speak further their eyes were enough, writing the answers that only they can read, screaming something that only they can hear.

Centra had leaned like a flower, like the moon, like the most beautiful thing in the world, and kissed Adora’s lips with her own.

Adora was frozen, as one does when having their heart‘s desire, she only moved to ask, "are you sure?"

“Most sure I've ever been in my life.” Said Catra.

And only then Adora kissed her back.

That's how they spend the start of the new day, a top a hill only they knew of, the sun’s light shining in them and making their bodies glimmer like gold, fingers interlocked with each other, Catra’s sitting atop Adora’s lap, eyes closed, chests meeting, lips smiling as they kissed each other.

—♕—

Catra didn't insist on riding swift wind on the way back, Adora was surprised until she wasn’t, until she couldn't control her alicorn’s balance from how much Catra tortured her. Catra with hands that wandered through backs and thighs and hips, with breath that warmed adores neck, with chest pushed against Adora’s back.

Catra who had Adora hurriedly dismounting her alicorn only so she can pull her close and kissing her so passionately.

They were beyond distracted, the world didn't register to them any more, the only reality they acknowledged was the space between them. Adora cupping Catra’s face, Catra’s hand circling adora’s wrists.

The only reality that existed for the, where the back of Adora’s knees hit the bed’s edge and made her fall on her back, while pulling Catra a top of her by her hips, where Catra’s dark curls and cloak fell and shielded them in their own space.

It didn't shield them forever.

Claps were sounded near them. They sprung into action, Catra faster than Adora, more experienced with the intruder, by the time Adora realised who has interrupted them, Catra and already placed herself before Adora, protecting her.

"What are you doing here?" Catra spat the regent.

The regent stood from the corner's shadows, nearing the new lovers. Her voice was thick with mocking, "Seeing now my princess was celebrating the halfyear’s half moon of course. "

"Don't kid yourself, you never cared before.” Catra said taking a step back, maintaining the distance between them, her left arm outstretched to shield Adora."and I'm not yours."

The regent threw her head backwards and cackled, "oh, C’yra. You’re nothing but mine.”

The chase was over, the regent had caught up to then, a chain of darkness encircled Catra’s chest and dragged her near the regent like leash."I had though someone as simple-minded as you might understand that. Did for really think you could be free? did you really think you can leave this Castle with out my knowing? I will always find, your highness."

"Catra!" Adora exclaimed in panic, unsheathing her sword.

"But I'm not here for you tonight," the regent said before throwing Catra behind her like waste.

"Adora." the regent drawled her name and turned to face her, but Adora was already sprinting and kneeling at Catra’s side, saving her.

“Are okay?" Adora asked as she struggled with the shadowy chains. But Catra did it answer and only told her to "Run! Leave! Get away!"

"I know how much of a temptress she can be, Adora, believe me, I do. I have seen it for years "The regent bellowed behind them. “but you can leave her now, it's alright, I'll allow it, I will give you some thing better."

"You don't anything about me!" the overfamiliarity in her voice enraged Adora.

"Oh, but but I do. Who invited you into the castle? Who gave you the princess as a gift? I know you, Adora. I know the power you hold, I know of your past, and I can shape your future. You only have to join me."

Adora froze. Understanding finally downed on her, finally seeing what her plan was all along, but it didn't matter her, nothing

mattered but Catra.

Adora drew her sword and pointed at the regent, same way she did the first time they met, but with new anger and vitriol. "No." she said, with finality.

All was still.

But then the resent whispered, "I see."

Adora's sword was wrenched from her hands and the same chains that wrapped Catra for a lifetime brought her to her knees.

'See, child.” The regent spoke while caressing the sword with spindle like fingers, fingers that made so much hurt and bleed, now addressing Catra," you have managed to corrupt another. Ruined another good thing in this world. And for what? A half love? She did not tell you her story, her history, for if she did you would have come running and crying to me like the child you will always be."

Adora’s eyes filled with tears, hearing her crime testified. They knew she wasn’t truthful, and she knew that Catra knew that. She knew so much of Catra while Catra knew so little of her, only secrets and lies and half truths.

But there came Catra’s firm voice, cutting through her guilt. "I don't care, I never did. I know who she is now and that it is all that mutters to me."

The regent cackled again in a room of chained girls, then she moved into Adora’s vision to show her what she was going to do even as she spoke to Catra. "Perhaps be this will change your mind."

The chains digging into Catra’s and Adora’s bodies left them, made their way across the tiles and bound them selves around the sword.

Adora realised what was going to happen too late.

"No!" she screamed.

The sword broke under the pressure of the chains into a hundred pieces.

And in the same exact moment, stars exploded behind adorns eyes, and screams were torn out of her chest.

The same room that was once filled with light and love and kisses, were now drowned in shadows and pain and hurt.

The last thing Adora heard was Catra's panicked calls, the last she saw was her tear stained face, the last thing she felt was her arms around her.

The last thing she thought of was how she had hurt Catra.

Chapter End Notes

The lotus flower is a symbol of life and rebirth, exactly what Adora and Catra have been going through since they met each other.

I hope you all enjoyed the happy(/ier) parts of this chapter because everything from now on is much more intense and complicated.

Next chapter we have: Adora's backstory!

Of course, thanks again for continuing with this story! I'm beyond grateful!

Chapter 5: Intermission two: Camellia

Chapter Summary

The untold story of the knight, or is she?

Chapter Notes

Hello again! Today we're going to do something different and take a different route in a different place and a different time, I hope you'll enjoy it either way!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Once upon a time, there was a perfect empire.

One which shared its glory everywhere, until its reign encompassed all the lands of the continent and stopped only at the shores. One which produced intelligent people who produced intelligent tools and sciences. One where order and stability ruled supreme. One where everyone knew and taught and believed in destiny above all.

An empire which was eternal forever in history and land and minds. Eternia.

A baby was born to rule Eternia.

She was born the perfect daughter. Her body embodied Eternia. The clear cloudless sky was found in her blue eyes, the rich gold of their earths was found in her blonde hair, the solid marble of their castles was found in her pale skin, the strong mountains and rocks of the land was found in her bones and flesh.

And by the time she spoke, it was clear her mind repeated the sentiment. She embodied Eternia’s philosophy and teachings, dedicating her entire being into her destiny and the future role she would play, parroting all she's told, being obedient to her superiors, being dutiful to her empire.

She was named Adora, for she was eternia's beloved, adored. And she always will be.

Until change knocked on the door of her life when she aged six.

"Come, Adora." Told her parents she barely recognised the faces of, for they were forever protecting and defending their empire in battles. "Come and meet your younger brother.”

To some that had been a day of celebration, but to Adora it was only the day when she realised her destiny might not be secured, that it was threatened, competed for. There was a new contender in the meritocratic race, a new royal child in the palace. Adora realised if she wanted that throne and crown, if she wanted to become empress, if she wanted her destiny to come true, then she needed to make it happen.

She need to be perfect, and that is what she became.

The perfect scholar. An enthusiastic student, reading and memorising every book and scroll and stone piece of writing of anything concerning her empire, from the political and regnant affairs, to the languages and cultures of other nations, to the world she lived in and its sciences and its explanations and even further to the sky and its gifts. She mesmerised all her teachers and more, boasted her intelligence to every royal and noble ear.

The perfect fighter. She was fuelled only by the imaginary picture of herself leading armies before two decades of life. She adored weapons, swords most of all, she used to sleep clutching wooden ones as child. But she knew strength didn't come from the blade, but from the hand that wielded it. She honed her hands as well as every part of her body. Carried boulders until her arms became just as firm, challenged every fighter in the empire to a duel or a spar or an arm wrestle and bested every single one of them.

But she was also lace over steel, the perfect courtier. She charmed as well as she fought. Quiet the gentlewoman, so chivalrous and beautiful as she romanced her empire’s women and further, she knew how to whisper and caress, how to negotiate and conform, convincing and diplomatic und charming.

She had fully became the perfect princess. Golden hair tied high with a white ribbon and with an equally golden crown atop it, blue gowns and jackets seeping authority and power from every thread, walked through her palace and empire and beyond like she owned it. For soon enough, she would.

But first she had to prove her worth, follow in her ancestor's footsteps.

There was a battle, against a new foreign rising emperor. His soldiers like pale identical worms in ugly green armour. He was greedy and stupid, daring to set foot on Eternia’s shores.

Adora was meant to lead her first army into that battle and finish in, teach the new emperor what is done to the enemies of Eternia.

She had miscalculated. The emperor's soldiers hardly rivalled the prestige and power of her and her warriors and knights turned soldiers, but they were relentless, non-stopping, like moving skeletons, refusing to die despite how many arms and legs and heads they lost.

The battle raged for days, and Adora was beyond exhausted, became unsure and unsteady. Maybe that is why.

She had been in the thick of the battlefield when it happened, each fist clutching her sword and shield tightly, body beyond tense, she could not see anymore, could not think through the thick fog of the war, though the smell of the blood and the clank of blades and the pain in her body.

Adora struck, but the enemy that was before her moved swiftly and placed his enemy in front of her. And only after blinking twice, Adora realised what had happened.

A comrade, a peer, her own soldier stood before her, with Adora’s sword protruding from his spine.

Adora had froze. Unblinking and uncomprehending, and the more she stood motionless, the more eyes were pulled towards her, the more soldiers realised what their princess had done.

She had killed one of her own soldiers. The truth sank slowly, and more followed, how her other soldiers were horrified and scared of her, how they backed away and left her vulnerable, how their distraction caused them their lives as more enemies descended upon them.

They were losing the bottle, and it was all Adora’s fault, her fault, her mistake, her imperfection.

She wasn't perfect anymore, she will never become empress now, she will never have her destiny.

Adora snapped.

Adora did not remember what happened afterwards. She didn't remember how loudly she screamed, how it echoed across the battlefield. She didn't remember how she glowed, shined, exploded, light and heat erupting from her like a volcano. She didn't remember how the force of it all destroyed everything

around her like the birth of a star. She did not remember anything about how she fell unconscious in the middle of a decimated crate full of burnt corpses, friend and foe alike.

She didn't remember any of it so she had be told.

When Adora opened her eyes from oblivion, she saw herself lying on her bedroom’s bed and a stranger standing on her bedroom’s tiles.

"I am the priestess." Said the stranger.

Adora was disoriented and confused, so she replied back with what she always said when following that script. "Hello, priestess. I am the princess."

But the priestess did not follow the script and instead said. "You are not a princess anymore."

The shock that filled Adora’s ears from those words almost made her deaf to the next ones.

"You are She-Ra." said the priestess." A goddess, of the sun, of power, of light, of magic."

The priestess did not stop talking after that, but Adora had stopped listening.

Understanding slowly settling and filling her with sickness. Not only did she lose her destiny, but her title too, her entire personhood, her entire being. Adora was nothing now.

"You are crying, hysterically too." Adora had not realised she was until the priestess told her. "Being She-Ra is an honour, a gift, you were chosen by things higher than many can comprehend.”

Hope begin to bloom slowly inside her heart, maybe she would not need to be nothing, she could become something.

"Being She-Ra is your new destiny, will you to fight for it?" asked the priestess.

Adora had already made her mind. If she would not become empress, she would be content with becoming goddess.

"I will." Said Adora with a new-found passion.

—♕—

Adora was no more, there was only She-Ra now.

She wasn't a princess anymore, they did not refer to her by her highness or future imperial majesty. No, the shaken and eye-averting servants, the only people she had got to meet after the battle, called her by her holiness. For she was holy now, sacred, divine. Something higher than a princess, even an empress.

Her possessions had been ready and packed even before she awoke, she had spent no more than one night in the palace, it was not her home anymore. Today, she was to leave for the temples.

She remembered faintly studying about those temples, historical sites reserved for more than centuries and surprisingly, inhabited by the few and the distant.

She was supposed to meet with the priestess first thing when reaching the temple, but she had only stepped foot inside those marble floors when she was found. "You must be She-Ra in every way." the priestess told her inside her new chambers. "In body, and mind, and soul. Perfectly."

The priestess had left after leaving Adora with her new chamber and possessions. The room was much smaller than her previous one in the palace, bare too. But the floors and walls were made from an iridescent material she couldn't even name, making the space look otherworldly, divine, ethereal.

Just like how she was supposed to be now.

She was dressed so unlike the way she used to in the palace. Her body was draped in a pure white silk, long fabric crisscrossing over her body like a porcelain statue, less like a dress and more like a tattered robe, but the material of the fabric betrayed its opulence. It was both longer and shorter than what she accustomed to wear, covering her from the neck to drape past her feet, while leaving her arms and back and glimpses of her chest and legs bare.

The only addition to the silk was the gold. So much gold, solid and molten and more, circlets of gold surrounding her arms and wrists and ankles, studs of god piercing her ears and nose, powder of gold dusting over her lips and eyelids and shoulders, and atop her head, lay a halo of gold crowing her head.

Her hair was simply brushed and left free and untied, her feet were only protected by a pair of soles underneath, Adora felt unsure, and when she looked in the mirror, she did not recognise the woman staring back at her.

She also had not noticed how much her body had changed after the battle, except only faintly. She was taller, extremely so, not enough to be unusual for a person but unusual for her, in one night she had grown an additional half of her height. Her free hair was also longer, reaching the back of her knees. Her skin was different too, she smiled slowly at the bigger musculature of her arms and thighs but her smile faded when she noticed now spotless her skin was, scarless, all the reminders of her hard won duels and spars and battles were erased.

This was not her body.

Adora had noticed how heavily she was breathing from the fog appearing on the mirror, she slapped her face as an instinct, and roughly wiped the moisture from her eyes. There was no time, and there was no reason too. She would not break just because of a different body, millions would die to be reborn in the body of a goddess, the body of a beauty.

She should feel honoured at between chosen and gifted this. By the time, she was summoned by the priestess, Adora had fully believed that.

The priestess had told her very little, she did not know what she was supposed to do as a goddess. Her only guide was understanding what she would not do, since she was no princess: she would not fight or study or charm and since she would not become an empress: she would not rule.

Her first task was to sit and sitting she did perfectly. Ascending for the elevated marble dais, tucking her legs underneath her, keeping her back straight as a sword, her chin high as a cloud, her face smiling and open and collected.

A blink and a nod, and the doors were opened and people were poured in like a chaotic river. All as soon as they beheld her dropped to their knees and feet, showing their devotion in their bodily sublimation. They were not silent, many were loudly wailing and crying, muttering prayers and thanks to She-Ra for finally returning.

"I never doubted it, not once" said an elderly devoted who had reached the bottom of her dais.

Adora was absolutely flabbergasted, She-Ra was known to her in her whole life, but apparently to some she was coming, returning, they held to belief and their belief was rewarded.

"Fix your countenance." said the priestess, and Adora gathered her wide mouth and eyes.

More were waking from their delirium and beginning to realise that their goddess was truly there, just in of reach. Adora were distracted by the wailing mob and the acolytes trying to placate them, that she did not notice one of devotee climbing for the dais and reaching for her hand.

"Wait!" Adora exclaimed in horror, memories of fire and blinding light and corpses flashed to her mind. But the acolyte did not wait or stop, she simply put Adora’s hand atop her head and sighed at the contact.

And she did not burst into fire.

Adora gasped at her hand peacefully glowing stop the devotee’s head, no one was hurt. they were all happy. The devotee and mob were boasting shout She-Ra’s hand and and touch and

blessing, they all wanted her, they weren't scared of her, they loved her.

Adora would train her self to earn that love.

When Adora retreated to her chambers, the apprentice had told her. "Those people are yours. Your duty as She-Ra is to protect them, help them, save them.”

"Does that mean I will learn how to control my powers?" Adora has asked first thing.

"Yes" said the priestess solemnly. "So you would hurt none."

Adora smiled afterwards. She did have a destiny, a title, she could still help people, she could still be something.

She just had to put in effort and do her best and try to be as perfect as possible. She would be the best She-Ra in history, she vowed it.

Her days after that followed a rhythm. In the day, where the sun was highest and strongest, she would meet and serve her people. And in the night, where the sun was weaker and safer, she would train and master her powers.

Firstly, heat.

During the night of her first stay there, she couldn't sleep, wasn't allowed to. She first had to master the sun underneath her skin, that fire, that flame.

The priestess said more people would want her hand and touch, her blessing, so she must shine and not burn, become a tender dawn instead of a scorching flame.

She had stood for hours, holding in each hand a piece of clay. She was told to heat one to liquid while keeping the other frozen solid. Again and again.

She had failed, the first and fifth and tenth time. It was humiliating, she stopped searching for the priestess's eyes after the third time, knew she'd only find disappointment and faint ire.

It was also exhausting. Her legs were beginning to cramp from standing for hours, her body was slouching from longing to sleep. And, as an unpleasant surprise to her, she was not resistant to her heat as she thought she was. Every time she managed to melt the clay it scalded the inner skin of her palm and made her hiss in pain. "You will learn how to heal, yourself and others." the priestess had only said as a reaction, to placate her. And then added immediately. "Again."

It was much further in the night now, Adora had though the priestess would give up with a sigh and leave, letting Adora train in secret until the time of her next evaluation arrived and she could mesmerise her then, the way she had always done.

But she didn't leave, she didn't seem to mind the late time, didn't seem tired either. And then after two additional failed attempts, she had told her. "You will not be meeting your devotees until you take control."

And, finally, that thought was enough. It had scared her, the idea of losing her devotees, her people, her destiny scared her. She took a deep breath and tried for the fifteenth time.

She succeeded.

Adora gasped in mirth and turned to face the priestess, she simply nodded in approval. As opposed to the day before, Adora had slept with a smile.

The next day proved her training necessary. Word of her arrival had spread quickly, the temples grew fruitful of people of all and every. Parents with varying children in age, hurried and curious travellers, disciplined scholars and believers, new and old lovers, everyone. And as suspected they all wanted her blessing, her warm touch.

She had been handed more infants than she had ever seen, carrying and rocking them gently as their mothers and fathers urged her to make their child's life happy and easy. Elderly and sick who brought her hand to their heads or chests to ensure a comfortable passage through death. New lovers who wanted their love to last forever. Travellers who sought a save journey.

And then devotees who wanted more than her touch. They wanted a piece of her, one they can carry in their person and place in their homes, a strand of hair, a chip of a nail, a drop of a tear, a drop of blood, a tear of skin.

Adora could not always indulge them, she knew if she did then more would ask too, and she was only finite. There was not enough of her for the whole world, not yet at least. But she couldn't of course refuse her people.

"How about a song?" she supplied instead. She had noticed how many had fawned and sighed at hearing her speaks, so maybe instead of blessing their skin she could bless their ears. Maybe her voice would as enough as her touch.

It was in all the ways that mattered. Her melodies and royally trained vocalisation echoed around the hollow temple columns and domes. And they were all absolute enchanted, many were weeping, and she had tended to them with divine care and gentleness, guiding more than one head atop her lap and whispering comforts until they calmed down and fell silent with a smile.

Secondly, healing.

The sun heals, brings the crops to life, heal the mind and body. The priestess told her she was destined to do it, so she did.

The priestess had also told her the easiest form of healing would be towards herself, so she slid a knife across the marble table and said. “Stab your hand so you can heal it.”

Adora obeyed.

Her grip was firm and sure as she pushed the edge of the blade through the center of her palm, never faltering even as she cut into flesh and veins and bone, until the steel shined from the other side. Adora pulled the knife away from the depth of her own hand and tried.

As opposed to her first training, she was given more than one night to master it. It was needed, for she had needed three nights to even begin healing her own hand.

There was no instructions, no methodology to get this, the priestess told her it was all already within her, she just had told her to let it go. And after nights of burning pain seeping through thin bandages, fever and infection, and tears of pain and exhaustion and criticism, Adora finally managed to stitch her flesh back to itself through her own magic.

Next was s bird, then a cat, then a gazelle. All with bent bones and stabbed meat that only Adora managed to heal back into perfection by simply being herself.

After her first demonstration of a child's broken arm, more people began to pour in for She-Ra, their healer, their midwife, their reviver, their miracle worker.

Adora had thought she had an impenetrable thick skin from her past life. She had been in battlefields, she saw the wounded and worse, she had been close to gore and pain and death her entire life. She though she was untouchable, unaffected.

The first time she could not heal someone was the worst day in her new life.

It was a woman, prime of her life, a hunter or fisher or traveller judging from her firmness, it should've been very easy and simple. The woman was stabbed, by a thief she said who stole her coins, straight in the chest, through the heart.

"I walked so long for you, She-Ra." she said. " l knew only you can heal me."

But she didn't. Adora was useless as the woman slumped her heavy half-dead body on her lap. She tried to place her hand on

the gushing wound and work her magic but she couldn't. Adora didn't knew why she couldn’t. The woman underneath her was breathing haggardly, and the blood was flowing like waterfalls through her fingers and straining her pale skin, her white silks, her gold.

Adora became as frozen as the woman's cold corpse in her lap soon enough.

But that had only been a learning opportunity. Adora had gotten much better ever since, she had not failed a single person ever since. Every disease, every injury, ever birth, Every near death. She had thwarted them all.

Thirdly, light.

It was her easiest, simplest and happiest for Adora. There was no pain, no exertion, no failure, it was simply good, during both times.

The priestess had her summoning suns and stars and particles of light, all from her own skin and veins, and finally Adora could do it easily and perfectly.

Like something inside her was longing for this, and she had finally freed it.

The people loved it, the children laughed, the elders were in awe. Adora stood before them like a shining beacon, pulling the sunlight streaming in the halls like threads and knitting a tapestry out of it. Ferocious animals and adorable pets, tall mountains, mighty trees, her old palace. Painting it all around her with the light that was her paintbrush.

And during it, she could finally see it, how they loved her, how they adored her. How she was their sun, their goddess, their she-ra, how perfect she was.

The priestess had praised her for the first during that night and told her to rest, And Adora’s love towards overflowed in her heart until it seeped from her mouth saying. "I love you, priestess."

The priestess did not parrot the sentiment, but she nodded surely and clearly in approval and for Adora that was enough.

All about her new life was enough.

Surely she was enough too.

—♕—

Adora had lived an entire year as She-Ra before she had finally realised.

After many months, the awe and wonder of her new role and its magic and its power had all been used up, and monotony and boredom began to occupy its place. Not only in Adora’s mind, but in her devotees’ too, and so they grew bolder with their players, always wanting more. But She-Ra always delivered.

Until...

"Kiss?" Adora parroted buck in near horrifically, surely she must have misheard, but the man before her did not look confused or alarmed, instead he looked hopeful and hungry.

"I beg of you, she-ra." Said the man with his too wide and salivating mouth. “Just one kiss. I need your blessing."

Adora was frozen. Alarm rinsing in her head when she realised she didn't want to answer this man. She had refused her devotees’ requests before, but always only because she didn't have the capability, not because she didn’t have the desire.

She had to finish this situation quickly, she didn't know what she was supposed to do, and something inside her deterring her from asking the priestess.

"How about a touch?" she supplied instead, hoping that was enough to satiate the man as she placed her hand stop his head.

It was not. The man seized her hand and brought it close to his face, warmth and saliva coating his mouth as he started kissing all over the skin he could find.

Adora panicked and pulled her hand back with a barely controlled screech. All eyes of the temple were drawn to her now as she stood without thinking. She tried to calm herself by justifying it that it was because the surprise, but she couldn’t, and something inside of her could not endure staying in that hall any longer. And so for the first time She-Ra left her people.

By the time the priestess caught up with her in her chambers. Adores’s panick had been exchanged with anger she didn't know who caused it, so when the priestess expressionless face appeared before her, she decided to redirect it at her.

"That an extreme poor of judgement, She-Ra." The priestess said in the same tone she used for praise, teachings and apparently how, reprimands.

"What else was I supposed to do?!" Adora has yelled, and surprised herself by doing so. She had never raised her voice before inside this temple, nevertheless on another person.

But the priestess was not surprised, she continued with the same exact tone and countenance. "You are She-Ra." she said. "You are supposed to answer your people’s wishes and grant them always and forever."

"So it doesn't matter what I think?” Words she had never given the permission to exist were escaping her mouth, and Adora couldn’t stop them. “I can't choose?”

“No.” Said the priestess. “You were chosen. It’s an honour to a She-Ra."

Adora's chest was heaving and she couldn’t think, couldn’t answer. She knew, she knew it all but something deep inside her refused so passionately. And Adora didn’t know what it was or what it was refusing.

She couldn’t bare this conversation any longer, so she changed course.

"They are only like this because they're bored." Adora replied back with a vitriol. “I'm sure there's more powers I can master. There must be more things I can do"

"You are only supposed to do what you are asked,"

“But—“

The priestess was done with her. She said with finality "You are She-Ra. You must do your duty. Go and meet with your devotees.”

She curtly turned and left.

Adora stood lightly panting in her chambers. She didn’t like any of what just happened, her interaction with the man, the conversation, how she acted. She felt like a child, like worse. She had to fix it. So she went to do so.

She did not meet with her people again. She tried but she couldn't, every step she took closer made her chest tighten and her feet heavy with lead, but she felt too undeserving of rest and so did not return to her chambers. So for the first time, she wondered the temple.

It was purely accidental, Adora decided she would tell whoever would ask, readying the excuse beforehand, and it was the truth. Adora had been palming the marble crystal walls as she walked, feeling too unsteady and lost. When suddenly her hand did not touch a wall but a secret entrance that made her fall and turn on her head.

She was a mess of limbs and silk and gold when she tried to untangle herself to see what dark hole she had fallen into. When she finally looked up she gasped, her voice echoing around her.

A face stared back at her. Rich brown skin, large eyes, a strong nose, full lips. Long brown hair that cascaded in a braid down and down and pulled Adora’S eyes to what the person in front of her was wearing, it made her gasp again.

The same white silk, the same gold circlets, the same long hair, the woman in front of her was dressed exactly as Adora. As a She-Ra.

And atop the frame of the painting that the woman was living in was a word.

Mara.

Mara did not look happy. She might have been to someone else, but to Adora she didn't. She was smiling, her head was high, her eyes were wide, but she wasn't, Adora was sure of it, and did not know why or how.

On trembling legs, adora finally stood and inspected her surroundings. The entrance was wide and near, she could so easily leave, escape, but she couldn't, not yet.

She was face to face with another She-Ra. She has to know more.

It was completely empty around her, but Adora did not give up. She touched the painting so tenderly so carefully but there was still nothing, she inspected the solid frame, also nothing. Finally adore needed to take apart the painting, her arms bulging as she carried it away.

It almost made her fall, what she noticed in front of her. Adora carefully put down the painting on the side, as if it was a mirror, reflecting someone identical to Adora before she gave it her back and went to inspect her new treasure.

It was extremely dark but it was no problem to Adora and the suns in her hands. When she finally understood what she was looking at, she gasped for the third time.

Books, scrolls. Writings. Adora picked one, it was titled by Mara, und they were all in the same hand writing.

Adora couldn't even begin to comprehend the gift she had so accidentally stumbled into. Everything was here, all the information, all the history. Right at her fingertips. She didn’t need to ask one, she could take it herself.

Adora laughed, so loudly and unabashedly, she could not believe it but she would soon will, as soon as she would start reading.

Adora thanked how the sun in her body supplied her more than sleep and food ever could for days an sat down and read.

And read.

And read.

Adora lived a lifetime with mara through her words. She was there when she became She-Ra, when the sun inside of her erupted for the first time.

When she was brought to the temples, when she mastered her powers, when she served her people, when she became a goddess.

When they hurt her, when they bled her dry.

But then Mara took stops unfamiliar for Adora, did things she didn't.

And Adora finally felt understood.

Mara had thought the exact thing she did, that she can always do more, help more people, the temple was too small, the devotees too little. There was an entire world ahead.

Mara had wanted to do that, go beyond the temple and even Eternia, she wanted to use her power more.

But she couldn't. For it wasn’t her power, not really. The last dated manuscript Adora could find were about Mara planning to tell the priestess her plans.

The implication of no text of what happened afterwards brought hears to Adora's eyes, and in the safety and privacy of this new haven, she let them fall. She finally left her self to cry for the first time since her rebirth.

Everything Adora had written could be as a understood as a warning to leave, escape, not follow in her footsteps, not to follow her destiny.

Mara had failed.

But Adora was too prideful, convincing herself how she could become better than Mara. It must be her prior knowledge that would make a difference, plus she used to be an empress-to-be, she could it. She coulf convince the priestess and make her understand.

With that being her new mission, Adora left her sanctuary.

Days had passed, that was clear from first glance, not everything was untouched by time as she.

Adora decided to go to her inner chambers first thing, to prepare, but the priestess was already there and caught her off guard.

There was no backup, no contingency plans, no retreat, here and now was Adora’s battle, she can step forward or she can escape.

She stopped forward.

"You have left your devotees." Alwahs so emotionless. And yet even now, Adora felt a pang of guilt strike her inside.

"I was doing something more important.” She tried defending herself, both to herself and the priestess.

"There is nothing more important than your people, she-ra." The priestess, finally standing up. "It is your destiny."

"But what if it's not!" Adora finally, finally asked, a question coming from her deep inside of her. "What if can do better, be better. Have a better destiny ."

The outburst had left them both motionless. No sound was heard in the room but Adora’s faint pants, and when the priestess spoke ,her eyes were looking at Adora differently

"You are speaking like Mara." She finally said, voice quiter than usual.

“Why didn’t you tell me?” Adora had never sounded as much of as a child as she did when she asked that.

“There was no need.” Was her answer.

Adora refused to be believe for that, as if Mara herself was of no need, and her memory was too. If anything the honour was getting to know her, the same honour the priestess always talked about. Adora couldn’t not defend her. “She was an extraordinary woman.”

"No, she was not” the priestess fought back. “She was compromised, and dangerous."

"She was a hero!" Adora retaliated. "Or at least, she wanted to become, could have..” and then in a quieter voice, with tears she didn’t notice and didn’t allow to exist falling from her eyes. “She just wanted to do good."

The priestess was unaffected by Adora’s tears. "She-Ras do good by being what they are."

"And what is that!” Adora asked. The sincerity of the question surprised even herself. “Toys, puppets, pawns? " She challenged, an anger brewing for so long inside of her finally breaking free.

"Goddesses." the priestess answered her.

"That doesn’t mean a thing!" Adora screamed. It truly never did, it was just an excuse, a synonym with being used, and hurt.

A strange silence has befallen the room afterwards, and unlike before, Adora could sense something hiding under it.

The same way she could sense the smallest amount of anger and hatred in the voice the priestess spoke with. "I will tell the devotees She-Ra had left."

"What?"

"The sun rises every day, a new She-Ra will rise with her.” Said the priestess. “Eventually."

And she stepped forward. Adora had never noticed how she towered over her, ever in this new tall body.

Realisation slowly dawned on Adora as she backed away.

"No.” She said, pleaded, whimpered. So very pathetically But the priestess did not stop, and what would happen afterwords would not stop either.

The priestess raised her hands and pain exploded everywhere inside of Adora. Escaping from her eyes and mouth, until all pain was housed inside her body. Adora screamed, until the echoing of her anguish was the only thing she could hear.

She was wrong, she did exactly like Mara, nothing changed. She would have her ending, forgotten and hidden. A nothing.

It wasn all in vain.

"No!" Adora’s will screamed louder than the pain.

It was exactly like before. The fire, the heat, the power. The crate in the earth, the burnt bodies. Adora asleep in the centre.

Exactly like before.

The only difference was that when Adora woke up afterwards, she did not repeat her mistake, she didn't stay and wait for someone to tell her what to do.

And she also finally realised that her power was a curse and not a gift, she would never actually help anyone, and she was so tired of hurting everyone.

So she locked it away. Found her trusted companion through her her life: her sword, and poured She-Ra into it. Until its blade was was crystal and its handle was gold. Until Adora stood shorter, with shorter hair and braided now, scarred skin, a smaller body. Back to Adora, not She-Ra.

Not princess, not empress, not goddess.

She was nothing again.

She could not stay a moment longer in eternia, she had hurt it and it hurt her buck too much. So Adora finally did what she should have done a lifetime before.

She left.

Chapter End Notes

Adora’s story really is about how being a good girl won’t save you.

One of the many things camellia flowers symbolise is perfection and excellence.

As always comments are always appreciated

Chapter 6: Protea

Chapter Summary

Checkmate.

Chapter Notes

We’re back on the main story now! Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora has been asleep for days, that was Catra's third surprise.

The first had been what happened after the regent broke the sword. It was a very beautiful swords, catra had always wanted to yield but held off after the first failed attempt, but that didn’t seem like a reason for Adora to scream as she did. Voice cracking as she curled around herself, as it she was burning from within, and after she slumped like a cut puppet, eyes closed and face guant, into Catra’s arms, Catra wondered if she might have.

The second surprise was when she noticed how much of her body had changed. Adora was taller much taller, the tips of her toes escaping the rim of bed Catra had with difficulty placed her in, and her much longer hair was covering as much of the blankets at the mattress, as if Catra could cover herself with it for warmth. Her skin was the most changed, scarless and smooth as marble. Almost impenetrable for touch, and as Catra had to learn repeatedly, extremely hot to touch. Catra had chosen to wearing thick leather gloves when caressing Adora’s placid face and tucking her gold hair behind her ears.

Catra didn’t know what to make out of the situation. The regent had faded into shadows before the thought of asking her what she had done registered inside her mind. She didn’t know what to do. She was confused and scared and absolutely out of her depth. She had never been in a place of caring for someone not to mention someone as full of secrets and mysteries as her beloved.

But Catra did not resent Adora for her secrets, not truly, exasperated of course, but never resentful. Adora had not forced her to doing anything, the least Catra could do was return the favour.

So Catra cared and cleaned and nursed, released all her servants for she didn't trust anyone in the Castle, not like she very much did before and waited. Sleeping with Adora’s dead-like body and searching her face for the littlest twitch until she fell asleep. Adora would wake up someday, Catra believed it.

And Adora finally did.

It was a normal midday. Catra was lounging on one of her many sofas, reading the book about stars Adora had read before. Trying to find any presence of here when her royal ears twitched at the sound of Adora faint groan, and she bolted.

Adora was slow as she came back to the world of living, and confused too, groaning against the kaleidoscope of colours and shapes that took place in her aching mind and equally aching body. She wanted to move around, inspect her surroundings, but

she halted all her efforts when she finally caught sight of Catra's nearby face.

Catra's fourth surprise was seeing Adora weep in front of her. Her knight and friend had such an impenetrable armour on her even when undressed, and it seemed that Catra had forgot that there was still flesh underneath it. That a human wore that armour.

Adora had never looked more human like she did now, tears streaming from her eyes, shocked sobs forcing their way out, hiding her face inside her elbows. And it unnerved Catra.

"Adora, stop!" Catra tried to comfort her, prying her hands from her face. "It's alright, it's all going to be alright."

"It's not alright!" Adora fought back. "It never was. I lied to you, too much and for too long."

Catra had no rebuttal for that, for Adora rule had done so.

"And now you know, and you must hate me." She wailed before concealing herself in shame once again.

Catra knew what to say. "I know nothing, Adora."

Adora slowly tilted her head upwards to face Catra’s.

"The only thing I know is that the regent hurt you, which is something I've learned a very long time, it's not new.” Catra had told her. "But… if there's something new I can know about you, something you can tell me. Then I can wait."

Adora lunged into hugging her. By that time, Catra stopped counting her surprises.

"Thank you." Adora whispered into her hair, voice still tearful.

Catra did not lie, she would wait, but that did not mean the waiting wasn't painful. Especially through the days as she nursed Adora buck to health, discovering that the return of her consciousness hardly meant anything as her body continued to recover so very slowly. It was painful seeing all that pain and not knowing why, only that she had to wait more to get the truth.

But her wait had served her well, for one quiet starry night Adora had finally told her.

Catra woke up due to the cold that managed to chill her body through the absence of Adora’s warmth's and when she searched for her, she found her standing so still on the balcony.

Catra hugged her from behind, Adora stiffened and then relaxed, so Catra kissed the back of her neck as a reward. Adora started crying, it became a regular act yet still managed to unnerve and upset Catra every time.

She wiped the tears on those pale checks with the silk of her sleeve tenderly and whispered. "Come back to bed."

"I can't.” came the choked reply.

"Why not?"

"Because I'm a liar, and my lies can't coexist with your love.”

"Then abandon those lies."

“I can’t, you will abandon me in turn."

She wanted to say that she won’t so very much but she couldn't so she said the closest true thing. "You do not know that. And neither do I."

"I'm a monster Catra! "Adora finally let free. "I've killed so many."

She curled into herself afterwards, waiting for her execution.

Catra could finally find the answer easily. "I've killed so many too."

Adora did not believe her, it was clear through her eyes.

“Important people, royals, nobles. And I'm sure my reason cannot rival yours."

Adora answered catra’s unspoken question. " it was an accident, and a mistake. I lost control.”

"Mine was not accidental. I meant it." said Catra, her voice completely devoid of unsureness. "And it wasn't a mistake, I would do it again if I could."

She stepped closer until Adora’s eyes had no choice but stare deep into Catra’s and asked. "so am I a monster, Adora?"

Adora looked at her with wide eyes, the clockwork of her mind turning as she was found difficulty reconciling this new information with the knowledge of the Catra in her mind, her beautiful and sweet Catra.

She did not answer Catra’s question but rather asked one of her own. "Why did you kill them?"

"Be case I wanted to.” Was Catra’s swift answer.

Adora was not satisfied. “why did you want to?"

"Because—“ Words stuck inside Catra’s throat but she forced them alongside her traitorous tears. "They saw me the was she did. They were about to hurt me the way she wanted to. I couldn’t stop her, but I could stop them. So l did."

Adora could only say. "Alright."

"Alright?” Catra was incredulous. “Aren’t I a monster Adora?”

" I don't know," Adora said. “Am I monster, Catra?”

"I don't care if you are.” Catra replied, truthful. “I still love you.”

“I love you too.”

And so for the second time, in a very long time, they embraced, and they kissed.

Taking that first step meant the rest of the journey came much easier. Catra had told Adora all the atrocities she committed, every victim she lured into the lion’s den, how she felt luring it, how guilt was low.

And in turn Adora told Catra everything. Her life as a future empress, a princess, then conquerer, then the sun goddess. And she told her about the people she hurt and killed too.

They didn't comfort each other, not traditionally, for they didn't know how. But they listened to each other, and they stayed despite it all. And for both of them, that was enough.

And then from the depths of night, the quiet and darkness, from the mess of limbs and fabric, Catra spoke.

"I suppose the children book’s love story of the sun and moons was true after all.”

Laughter was the last thing echoing inside the room that night.

—♕—

The togetherness Adora and Catra had rekindled during that night was the only thing that enabled them to survive the months following it.

Their paradise had turned into hell.

They had enclosed themselves to their rooms. Adora’s health was much more important than either’s joy or entertainment, or rather that's what Catra tried to convince her of.

But then, Catra was forced to leave her side when the regent called her to the glasshouse.

"Hurried, are we?" Asked the regent, desiring no actual answer but giving a hidden threat for catra to stop squirming in her seat or replying too curtly.

But Catra was too exhausted for mind games and so answered truthfully. “I can’t afford much time here; I need to get to back to the tower and check on Adora.”

The regent hummed as her eyes while letting the silence unfold around the, and then said. “How quaint, how new.” Her voice was sickly sweet. “You, for once, not being the weak one, the one looked after. So unfamiliar, isn’t? how does it feel?”

Catra did not answer, at least not to the regent, not vocally, but she did inside her mind.

She loved it.

The regent was undisturbed with Catra's non answer, she carried on. "I advise you to enjoy while you can, it won't last for long."

"What?"

"Well, you will have to go very far away Catra, I doubt you can care for Adora from there. And, of course, you can't bring her with you."

"What on earth are you talking about?" Catra snapped, her patience running thin. "Why would I leave?"

"To be married, of course."

Catra froze in place. Another "what?" escaped her throat.

"You must thank me Catra." The regent never sounded as gleeful as she did now. "You were always going to die, you were getting very old anyway, but due to my mercy I have exchanged your execution with you wedding."

Catra’s heart was beating too loudly that she could barely hear herself ask. “Who?”

“The new emperor, of course. He had been knocking in our borders for months now, so I offered to gift him you and he agreed.”

The emperor. The conqueror. The man.

Catra’s voice was as as tight as a bow when she spoke. “You’re selling me to my mothers’ killer, my orphaner.”

“People die in wars, Catra. This is a way for those people to be less.

Catra stood suddenly, her body primarily preparing to escape. Grasping for straws, anything, anything to make this nightmare cease.

“You need me!” She breathed desperately. “You can’t give me away; I feed you.”

“I don’t.” The regent answered her calmly. “After She-Ra’s reappreance, your services will no longer required. You’ve seen

her, a being of pure magic. One finger of hers will last me months.”

No.

No.

The regent sighed, predicting that explosive tantrum of rebellion. “You cannot refuse Catra, truly. I’ve prepared it all, it will all occur next full moon. It was another act of mercy from me to even tell you. I could’ve easily shipped you off in full ignorance. Do you understand?”

Catra did, fully. There was truly no other way.

None but one.

A way that was always an option, always.

And so Catra unsheathed her claws, and brought them into the meat of her own neck.

Both women moved at the same time.

During it, Catra wondered what would Adora have done, if she would be slower or faster than the regent, if she would be proud of disappointed, if she would understand.

Because the regent clearly didn't.

"A coward!" That's what the regent screamed into her face after her magic wrestled her into submission and complained, with her hands, one slightly bloodier, pinned to her back with her. "A crazed coward, that's what you always have been! I should have treated you as the mindless pawn you are. I should've fixed you. That is what you always wanted, isn't it?"

Catra only wept as a reply.

"I should. Oh, I should do just that. Cut out her your hands since you clearly can't be trusted with them, and your tongue too, I should have done that a long time ago."

"No. No, please." Catra pleaded tearfully like the child the regent always managed to reduce her to. "I can't lose anything else.

Catra was prepared to plead and beg as fight ever more, but surprisingly the regent complied.

"Very well." She said as she finally let Catra go. But then she hissed as she towered over her. "But hear this and hear it wisely,

Catr. If anything happened to jeopardise the wedding, Adora would face the fall. Now leave.”

Catra did.

Her soul seemed to want to leave her own body too. Until she finally she reached her rooms and her Adora.

Adora had taken only one look at her and staggered to be near her, comfort her. As soon as skin touched skin. Catra broke down.

Sobbing and heaving into Adora’s warm embrace. With Adora rubbing her back and tucking hair behind ears and never asking for an explanation.

But Catra provided it anyway.

And when breath finally returned to her lungs enough to speak, she said one thing.

“We must destroy the regent, Adora.”

—♕—

The plan was underway.

The first step, sadly, had to be taken inside the regent's glasshouse by the regent's permission.

Catra had said. "I want a masquerade as a wedding gift."

Maybe it was the pitiful resignation, the regent's annoyance or maybe her own small act of misplaced affection, she agreed.

Every other step would be taken inside the ballroom, by Adora and Catra's will.

Adora pondered as she stood in the middle of that ballroom. Wearing a blue dress of cloud embroidery and sunlight at the hems, wearing the morning sky. Too long hair loosely ties half upwards. No crown or golden circling her every limb, no Eternia lavishness. Only a unicorn masquerade mask on her face. She looked beautiful but she looked inconspicuous, like every other ball guest.

Balls weren't a foreign thing to her, she thrived in them in Eternia. And this wasn't her first ball in halfmoon. But it still was the first ball she attended where she was tasked with something other than charm or guard.

She grew stronger after the weeks of rest, able to stand and dance like any guest , but she needed to be stronger to do more than that, to complete her mission. Catra depended on her, the future of halfmoon did too, this entire plan stood tall on the beliefs that Adora would succeed. But also many other steps had to be taken by Catra, before Adora's crucial step had to be taken, and because of that Catra had told her to enjoy the night as much as she could before it had to end.

Adora had only enjoyed her time in halfmoon when Catra was nearby, so she began to search for that condition.

No princess or regent was spotted in the ball, just as it was supposed to do. Even if they did appeared, none would be the wiser, that was the entirety of the masquerade's significance. No one would know.

No one but Adora.

The one would also know where Catra was. But it seemed as if that skill was reciprocal, Adora concluded, as she felt an arm snake its way around her waist.

"Hello, beautiful." Catra said as her other hand trailed down Adora's arms and interlinked their fingers together. "Shall we dance?"

Catra was the most beautiful she'd ever been. She was dressed vastly different than her earlier ball, her dress was sleeveless, with a shorter skirt at the front for mobility, her hair was entirely braided around her head, small flowers between the curls but as opposed to the wild ones she wore during the festival, these were small gold ones with a central turquoise, and on her bare face, lay a lion's mask.

But most different of all was her demeanour, her smile was wider, her steps were heavier, she was escaping a larger space, her voice was louder.

And she was the one leading the dance, Adora came to realise.

She looked the happiest she'd ever been, so Adora had to make sure that she truly was.

"Are you happy, Catra?" Adora asked as they twirled around the ballroom, their skirts swishing like cyclones around them.

Catra titled her head closer, the marble of their masks clinking as she whispered into Adora's ear, a confession only meant for her. "Yes, I am. I have never been happier."

She truly wasn't. Adora was near her, she was conducting a plan of her own making, they were dancing and holding and smiling and in the blink of an eye it seemed like a paradise.

She wanted to live in this paradise forever.

And if the night was successful, she could.

They, together, would.

The music was coming to an end, their dancing following it, but Adora didn't want to be wrenched away.

Catra didn't either.

So she had to make it count.

As the music climaxed, she dipped Adora low. Hands around her back, Adora's hands around her neck. And they gazed in each others eyes she whispered, "I love you, Adora. I don't think I can love any thing in the world more than I love you."

And Adora's answer came after they regained their posture. She's wrapped her arms around Catra's waist and twirled her until her toes left the marble floor and kissed her.

It was the first time they kissed among people, declared their love publicly.

When their kiss finally ended, and Catra was back on the tilework, Adora whispered. “I love you, too.”

It was done. There was work to do.

With one final chaste pick on the lips between them, they separated and went in different paths. Adora to the outside of the ballroom, and Catra to her least favourite councillor.

The councillor of education. The one most similar to the regent.

Catra had curtsied and charmed and purred her way into closeness and went the councillor finally gave her attention she said. “I have been having thoughts of how I would transform halfmoon after my coronation…”

Catra could see in the councillor’s eyes when the realisation of who was tugging at her arm was, and the clear reassessment of the infamous princess. But Catra did not let her think any deeper, her prey was caught, there was no use in playing with it. “And you have always been my favourite councillor. So here I am seeking your councils. May I?” She asked with her hand outstretched.

The councillor said yes because of course she did, and easily allowed her princess to lead her outside the ballroom, into the garden, into the glasshouse.

The councillor has realised much faster than Catra's other victims so she had to think fast. She threw her with enough force to shatter the glass doors and land her on her back.

The councillor screamed as broken glass dug unto her back, and then screamed louder when the regent attacked and engulfed her. Until there was nothing left.

Catra did not budge from her spot until the regent growled at her uneasy composure and hissed. "Leave."

And so Catra left, and gave a clear few to the ball guests of the carnage their regent had conducted on their councillor.

Gasps echoed around the gardens.

The councillor had only been one small part of the puzzle, a small minute particular Catra was very content to sacrifice. Most other parts of the puzzles were about giving the time of day to every important person in the ballroom and telling them to meet her in the garden in the same exact minute. So her plan could work. So halfmoon could finally see the cruelty of the regent she had cried about for so long.

And they were all seeing it, watching it, watching their oh so beloved regent ravage one of her councillors like, a wild animal, like a monster, like danger.

Catra would gave them the first head start.

She screamed, loud and shrill, and escaped the threshold of the glasshouse, half performance and half true.

Every one screamed as they battled each other for escape.

Catra, herself, couldn't get very her. Something pulled form her highly braided hair and threw her aside like a ragdoll.

Catra choked in pain as her back arched against the marble.

"You foolish girl!" She regent screamed like she never did before, her voice echoing around the glasshouse and causing Catra to cover her ears. "You absolute nothing! I will give the emperor a corpse as a bride if I have to."

The regent charged at her and Catra knew, she knew this was it. No more playing with prey, no more drying her of use, no more waiting, no more future plans. The regent was going to kill and nothing inside either of them could stop it.

“You ruined everything!” The regent lunged.

But there was one person that could stop her.

Adora stood between them, glowing like the sun.

Large, powerful, invincible.

She silent resisted the regent’s attacks before turning to face Catra and giving her one sure nod.

And Catra understood, and left.

She entered the ballroom.

“My people!” She screamed, commanding the attention of everyone, until they all fell silent and turned to face her. She took of her mask, revealing her true self. “I apologise for my weakness in resisting the witch’s magic, she had forced me to do all those horrible things for so long.”

If the regent wanted to control of Catra’s being, she can be in control of her mistakes and flaws and all of her wrongdoings too.

Catra was innocent.

"But no longer! I will vanquish that witch, and be our great and rightful queen, for you are my dear subjects, and you deserve it. You have my word!"

The speech, coupled with the experience many had about the fiery charismatic woman later realised to be their princess made all that were in the room accept her. Every single person in the ball knelt and bowed and they bellowed. "My queen!"

Catra teared up at finally getting her heart's desire.

Or half of it. As soon as the ball guests were comforted and compensated and went home, Catra ran for her beloved.

The battle between the regent and the goddess was mesmerising to see. A magical clash of dark shadows and gold light. A paradox.

But there were differences. The regent had more experience, more time, more fuel.

But Adora had more reason to win.

And so she did.

When the regent became robbed of her magic, she turned to use her other weapon: words. “She will never last you! You’ve seen how weak she is, how breakable. Whatever love or flesh she promised you, it would not last, and it certainly wouldn’t be enough when she destroys you by destroying herself.”

“Silence.” Adora hissed as she towered over her, while the regent was grovelling on her knees.

Luckily, she did not have to praise herself for another verbal attack, for very familiar footsteps were sounding before her.

Adora stood aside to present her triumph to her queen.

“Oh, how much have I wished for this glasshouse to shatter.” Catra drawled as she stepped over the broken glass.

The regent laughed mirthlessly as she replied. “Don’t kid yourself, you have loved it. Your eyes sparkled whenever I brought you here.”

“When I was a child.” Catra said with conviction.

“The child that you still are,”

“Because of you! You made me this way childish, mindless, out of control.” Catra seemed on the verge of breaking, but regained her composure one last time, she will never give the regent the satisfaction, never again. “But not anymore. I have vanquished you, I’m triumphant and victorious and I will sit on that throne and wear that crown and become the queen I was always meant to be.”

The regent’s composure began to break, she finally seemed unsure but covered it with a sickly drawl. “Do you not desire my death, your highness?”

Catra was silent.

“Do you not remember how I hurt you, with no regrets? How I made bleed, and cry, and betray your own self and others?”

“I do.” Said Catra with the calm of a hurricane. “I do not just remember it, I live it, in days and nights I can’t begin to count. That’s why I will not kill you; death is too merciful for someone like you.”

She walked closer, far closer than she ever been to the regent out of her volition. Danger bells were ringing in her mind, but she wanted to face the regent directly as she said. “I will imprison you deep inside the earth’s crust, I will make you feed on rats and crows, I will make you hear silence until the regrets of what you’ve done to me echo all around you. And if they don’t, if your

heart is incapable of even that, I will come down every once a while to remind you, it could be a few days, or years, and you will not know because you will only have the darkness as your friend, how you always did.”

Catra stood and regarded the regent was utter contempt, before screeching “guards!” and standing motionless as she The regent was hauled away in chains. And she turned her back to that glasshouse one last time.

Th rest of the night was all too quiet. Catra had looked adora but no smiles or nods graced her face, she was too lost inside her head. And that quietness persisted up until they entered their rooms.

As soon as the doors closed behind them and Catra was again in the haven of privacy and safety she and Adora cultivated with each other, she broke down. Falling to her knees and weeping loudly.

Adora was by her side in an instant, a comfort always and forever, but she didn’t understand. “ I thought you would be happy.”

“I did too.” Catra sobbed. “But I can’t stop thinking about what ifs. What if it never gone to this. What if I didn’t have to stop her. What if she didn’t hurt me. What if it was better than all this.”

Adora had no answer in words, but she did in an embrace as she pulled Catra tightly to her chest and brushed her hair out of her tear stained face and kissed it.

After a moment, Catra pulled herself back, all her tears dried out, and her love for the regent alongside it. She looked at Adora with overflowing love and small smile and said. “I doesn’t matter anyway, I don’t need her nor want her. Not anymore. I have you and you are the best thing in this entire world, Adora.”

She pulled her for a kiss and Adora faltered for a moment and then returned it. “I love you.” She breathed because she can say no other thing.

“I love you too.” Catra breathed into her cheek before pulling her into another kiss.

—♕—

Adora awoke while everyone was a sleeping, the sun behind the horizon, Catra in bed beside her, the world and all its birds and winds and trees. They all were content with slumber, quietness and rest.

But Adora could not be.

She could only stand and leave the bed she had found such comfort in.

She could only cloth herself in what she used to before knighthood was thrust upon her.

She could only reach for a piece of parchment and a feather and begin writing.

She could only look at Catra for long minute, memorising her face and all its shapes and slopes and everything and searing it into memory, for that memory would be the only thing she will have.

And she could only turn around, giver her back to that room, open the doors, and leave halfmoon.

—♕—

My dearest, Catra.

I wish from the deepest part of my heart that there exists another way, but there doesn't.

My powers are too strong, my battle against the regent, as happy as I am that I defeated her, proved that. And I cannot risk hurting

you, I do not think I could survive if I did. It scares me beyond anything else in the entire world.

Initially I had only stayed because you needed me, and I had to help you reclaim what is yours. But you do not need me anymore, you proved that tonight as well. You will become a great queen. Even more without my burden weighing over you.

I am returning to Eternia. You have inspired, I, too, will reclaim what is mine. And it is only fitting that I return where it all started, hoping I can master my powers there.

We will meet again, I promise you this. I do not know if it will take days or years, but someday, Catra, you will behold my face and I yours. We can never be forever apart.

With love,

Adora.

Chapter End Notes

Protea symbolises strength and victory.

As always comments are highly appreciated.

The last chapter is next!

Chapter 7: Lily

Chapter Summary

The very end.

Chapter Notes

We have finally reached the end, I hope it will satisfy you all

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Dear Catra,

Eternia has changed, and not for the better. It was almost destroyed. My brother did not become emperor as I had suspected. They need me. I'm going to fix it.

Love, Adora.

—♛—

Dear Catra,

I have found more Mara manuscripts on how to control my power. There were so many. The priestess had hid them all, she lied to me so much and for so long. I am going to be a much better goddess, just as an empress.

Love, Adora.

—♛—

Dear Catra,

It’s been more than two months since we parted. I miss you every waking hour, while asleep too. You haunt my dreams. And yet it’s not enough, please write to me. I need you.

Love, Adora.

—♛—

Dear Catra,

Eternia is progresses, and my power too. I’ve done so much. And yet I don’t know why it feels empty.

Maybe it is your lack of letters.

But I understand, you need time. I will give you time.

Love, Adora.

—♛—

Dear Catra,

Please write to me. I need it, please.

Love, Adora.

—♛—

Dear Catra,

I entrust my letters with my best messengers, they will die before they missend them.

That’s enough for me. That you at least read my letters.

Love, Adora.

—♛—

Dear Catra,

I’m sorry. I’m sorry. I’m sorry.

Why did I do it. Why did I leave you. I want to turn back I don’t want to be without you anymore.

I think I want to die.

I don’t think I will send this letter, I don’t want to hurt you more than I already did.

—♛—

Dear Catra,

News of the emperor’s audacity and attacks on your borders have reached us here. If you need help please tell me, I can give it to you all. Soldiers, weapons. You don’t even have to answer my letters. Just ask me and I will do it.

It terrified me that he’s angry at you, at us for destroying the regent and his wedding.

It terrified me to imagine what would happen if he won.

He won’t, as long as I breath. Believe me.

Love, Adora.

—♛—

Dear Catra,

Please write back to me. If only it a letter. A word. It would be enough.

Love, Adora.

—♛—

Dear Catra,

News have reached of his attack! Why does your queendom carry his banner what happened? did he win. Did you surrender. There's no news of bloodshed.

I need answers. I Can't sit by while the worst might have been.

I'm going back. You can hate me all you want. I just need to know that you're a alive.

Love, Adora.

—♛—

Adora was not crowned yet. But she still empress.

She had the rooms, the clothes, the actions.

But her actions of leaving with her dress and half armour on swift wind's back without anyone knowing was not the action of an empress.

It was the action of a lover.

The journey was long and difficult, the weather was hard, and strength was stolen. But as soon as adora's feet touched the earth, no, swift wind's hooves, Adora could finally breath.

She ran through the stairs to the castle, to the throne room, where Catra soon to be queen must reside in.

But when Adora pushed the doors of the throne room, it was not Catra who was seated at the throne.

But the regent.

Adora was confused in a familiar way. As was the norm in halfmoon. But now anger occupied it.

She attacked with all her power, stopping her from tainting the throne any longer, but the regent escaped.

"What did you do?" Adora hissed. Mind playing tricks of what crimes the regent must have done to Catra.

But the regent cackled loudly. "The question is, what did you do."

Adora scowled, understanding the insinuation. “I did what I had to.”

“You left is what you did.”

“Not forever. I always would have came back!”

“And you think that she believed that.” The regent laughed again. “I must congratulate you, truly. You succeeded in breaking C’yra’s heart much better than all the times I’ve tried.”

Adora’s heart was crushed. But she tried to hold on.

“She will understand, when I talk to her. Where is she?”

“Nowhere you can find her,”

Adora levelled her with her sword. Weighing her life and death in her hands.

“I’m not the foe you just defeat here.” The regent grunted.

“You always are.”

“Not always, I’m not who conquered this queendom first nor who killed its queens, I’m not who send soldiers until you killed ghee like a murderous star. I’m not who caused all this.”

“The emperor.” Adora breathed. “How? There was no attack. How could he do it.”

“It was not him. It was her.” The regent was gleeful as she said it.

“What?”

“I didn’t expect that strength of her either. Understandably. But she sacrificed herself in A political act. Serving him in his court in his empire, with the contract of leaving the queendom bloodless. It became his, without hurting anyone. Brilliant. Likely remains of what I tried to to teach her.”

The realisation was painfully dwelling on Adora.

“We must save her!”

“For what, bringing the peace.”

“He will never hold his side of the bargain. He could hurt her or worse, and none would know. You know that!”

“Of course, I do! But she chose that and I’m letting her live with what she chose. Or die with it I suppose.”

Adora can’t do it alone. She needed the regent’s magic.

“Please. I can give you anything Eternia can give. All power.”

“I have power in halfmoon enough.” She said before disguising herself in illusions, and retaking the throne.

Adora truly looked at her, how miserable she was, at resorting to illusions and lies once again.

“Than I can give you more than enough.” Adora finally said. “If you help me save Catra, I will convince her to pardon you and assign again at her court.”

The regent took much less convincing that Adora thought. They clasped hands and were transported the emperor’s fortress.

“He put her in a tower.” The regent said, and Adora almost laughed at the irony, if it didn’t make he absolutely sick.

They ran across the stone and metal, fighting glutes and soldiers, until the regent had to stay behind and Adora to carry on.

Until she stood before the door that hides Catra behind it.

Until she opened.

And saw Catra inside.

Wearing a white loose blouse and red breeches, hair tied high by a ribbon, the same clothes Adora wore during their first kiss.

Catra turned to face Adora, but Adora had already raced for her, to hug her, to love her.

“Oh, Catra.” Adora breathed lovingly.

She then felt burning pain like knives in her back.

Adora backed away with a yelp, and fell to the ground.

In times to tilt her head outwards and face Catra as she seethed. “Leave.”

—♕—

When Adora left, time was transported back a year ago.

When Catra had immediately woken up due to the absence of Adora’s warmth, searching for her fair body with clutching sleepy hands and finding a letter in her place, she had realised it.

And she had continued to realise every day afterwards.

The first day, when she read and reread the letter until she could finally understand it, when she screamed Adora’s name and searched for her in the entirety of her tower, she thought it was all just a cruel joke.

When she finally understood the truth of her reality, that Adora’s had left her, that she was all alone, and she wept like she never did before, voice growing hoarse and raspy from the sobs and screams, tears flooding her entire being.

When she couldn’t leave her chambers, clutching a blanket that smelled faintly of her escaped love, her body entirely devoid of energy or life.

She had realised it all those times. That nothing had changed, that she was still the Catra of the yesteryear, or before. Weak and unloveable and alone.

She was only busy with one task during those days: answering the questions.

The why.

Was she too much. Rushing one point from another, bearing way more than one can, bringing way more chaos than she was worth.

Or was she less than she thought she was. Too small, too ignorant, too undeserving of the greatness that influenced Adora's life.

And if she stopped asking why, she's start asking when.

When did Adora start hating her?

Was something in the back the catalyst of it all, or as it before, when Catra's involvement hurt her in the form of the regent.

Or was it way before that, when Catra tired her and pulled her from one place to another, chasing something she couldn't name.

Or was it even before that, when she beheld her for the first time. Maybe the love was never there. Maybe it was all a lie.

She couldn't bear it anymore. Her eyes burned from the hears, her head pounded from the headache, her voice hoarse from misuse, her bed a central point of her melancholy.

She had left her tower, she needed it to.

She needed the regent.

She was barely in control when she reached the dungeons, when she opened the bars, and when she collapsed in front of her.

The regent was gentle with her, in a way. She collected her in her arms, brushed her hair out of her face, shushing her to inhibit her painful sobs.

While while saying, "I told you so."

After that night, Catra began slowly, so very slowly, standing again.

She found letters, and she burned them to ashes, they did not deserve it each other.

She was a queen, or rather soon to be one. So much duties, so much to oversee, so much to keep in control.

Except, Catra might not get to do any of that.

The armoury the one from before she was born, the one who was a constant invisible threat, the ignored nightmare, reappeared again.

It seemed his attacks were one of the very few things the regent hadn’t lied about.

It was hopeless, halfmoon did not have the soldiers nor weaponry nor money nor time, if it came to a war. Violence and bloodshed would paint the queendom red.

And so Catra decided to endure that violence and bloodshed, it would not be a new things to her.

The emperor agreed to her sacrifice, and the conditions of her not being a wife but an advisor, or rather the unspoken whisper between them, a prisoner.

It was the only way.

The perfect answer. Halfmoon would escape war, and Catra would escape sadness, if it came to so.

Yet, Adora was not there to praise her for her ingenuity. She left her, and so Catra left her memory. Refused to remember her, her face, her voice, her anything. She was stubborn, and kept reappearing, but Catra was just as stubborn.

Until Adora overpowered her, and appeared right in the tower the emperor placed her in.

Until she hugged her like she wanted her, missed her, loved her.

Until she hurt her for the very first time.

She told her to leave, and Adora was confused and hurt. It should’ve been easy to repeat hat she has already done.

“Catra, I came to save you.” Adora said.

Catra laughed until it echoed viscously around them, “of course, you did. Save me from myself, right? Of my own decisions.”

Adora hardened at that, viscerally rejecting the belief. “No, no, of course not. This was a last resort, I understand that. But you don’t have to anymore. I can help you, Eternia can, I’ll give you all the soldiers and money you want.”

Adora did not stand since she fell to the ground, and she still haven’t, she crawled on her knees to clasp Catra’s hand and say. “Just please come home, Catra.”

Catra’s eyes were empty when she wrenched her hand out of Adora’s and said. “Home never existed to me. Not anymore.”

Adora closed her eyes in guilt and reopened them to face Catra’s own face with all its vulnerability and say. “I’m sorry.”

“You’re not!” Catra finally exploded, the tristhfulness of the situation finally reigning in.

“I am!” Adora said tearfully.

“Well, it’s not enough.” Tears finally streamed down Catra’s face, showing a minuscule of her anguish. “It never will be. You left me, Adora!”

“I know.” Adora could only breath jaggedly. “I know, I’m sorry. Please just give me one chance. I’ll fix it.”

Catra shook her head slowly as she backed away, hurting herself more than Adora.

“Please, Catra. I’ll anything, everything.”

“I don’t want everything.” Catra whispered. “I want you.”

“Then you have me! I promise I’ll never leave again. I promise.”

Catra collided with Adora like a meteorite, hugging her with tighter arms and a tighter want. Adora returned it immediately. Both embracing themselves tightly as they softly cried.

“I don’t know if I can trust you again.” Catra whispered a little afterwards.

“I know.” Adora whispered back. “I can’t say anything now, but I promise i’ll be worthy of that trust.”

Catra sneered her by a kiss to the lips.

Both missed each other’s lips, as they kissed passionately.

After they separated, Catra said. “Let’s leave.”

And so they did.

An explosion caught their attantion as soon as they left the tower, and Catra’s eyes easily located the regent. She slowly turned to face Adora incredulously.

“I needed her help.” Was Adora’s pitiful excuse.

Catra opened her mouth to retort but stopped herself with a shaken head. “It doesn’t matter anyway, whatever you promised her. We need to leave.”

They ran to outside of the fortress, with the regent unwantedly close by their tail.

Catra turned to face her as soon as they reached a clearing. “You should be in a dungeon.” She said.

“I escaped easily with your departure. Do you want me to demonstrate how?” The regent answered.

“No.” Catra said curtly. “It’s not needed, you are not needed. We can very easily escape without you. And afterwards, you will be rotting exactly where I had put you in.”

The regent was surprised, and yet trudged ahead. “Your beloved promised me pardon.”

Catra smiled. “She have no power to back that promise, not like I do. Surprising isn’t it? I haven’t forgotten all you’d done.”

But then their conversation and escape was interrupted. They had miscalculated, hordes of soldiers were closing up on them. There was no escape. No retreat. No plan.

Neither Catra or Adora had one, but the regent did.

She grabbed Catra’s jaw to ensure her focus and told her in the clearest voice ever. “You’re welcome.”

Before engulfing the entire fortress in flames. The force of which pushed both remaining women off the edge and into the waiting waters.

Neither Adora or Catra could find the other. Both were struggled to resurface among the dark waters, Catra much more difficulty, having never learned how to swim.

But she succeeded, managed to pull her coughing and dripping body into dry land, and breathed in air.

Until the air was stuck in her throat from pain, a sharp pull from her hair wrenched her head upwards to face him.

The emperor. The cause of all this, for both Catr and Adora's story. He was truly an emperor, in extravagant robes and crowns and blades. And he was angry, have his body burnt and bleeding.

"You." Catra hissed in absolute hatred.

The emperor's answer was submerging back into the waters with a tight grip on her throat.

Catra struggled against death like she had her entire life. Claws at any surface she can find of her executioner, until red blood intermingled with the blue waters dooming her. And yet the grip didnt falter, Catra couldn't escape. And as air began to fail her, so did her strength. With a final strike, Catra gave in. Her limbs drowning a little bit sooner than her head would.

Except it did not. Suddenly, the grip on her throat was wrenched free. She surface with aloud cry of pain, and even louder coughs follwoing it, gulping for much needed air.

And tge air began to fill her lings, more senses were began to work again. Her ears were first as she heared the painful loud screeched of the empror, and then her eyes as she sw him cradle his chopped arm.

Adora was standing between the two of them. Her sword was bloody. But she fid not execute the emperor, not yet. She turned to face Catra.

“Are you okay? Are you alright?” Were repeatedly breathed depratly, as gentle hands bruhsed back her drenched hair to einsepct her face.

But Catra’s focus was not on ber, but him. That monster, that nightmraish presen of the world. The start of it all, the story of both her and Adora.

“Help me up.” She rasped. Adora immediately did, and with no speaking, helped make her way to his still screaming pitiful form.

With a trembling hand, Catra circled his throat the way he did to her a moment ago.

She opened her mouth there was so much she wanted and need to ay. So kuch hatred and anger and tesent to break free. But when she moved her tongue she realised that she was ao cery tired and she did want to give him anythin at all.

So she said in an unwavering voice. “You don’t even deserve my hatred.” And clawed at his throat free, wripped the bone fo his wind pipe in her fost, letting the blood run free, watching him gulp with wide eyes for air, and then leaving him to die.

They did not waste a moment. They immedtly ran to the closest boat they could find, very ready to finally leave this entire chapter behind.

Both were weakly rowing with wooden oars, and only stopped when the current begab to softly carry them away and to home.

As soon as the silent fell on them, so did their tears. All the realisation being understood finally, so much death, so much pain, so much darkness.

Neither knew if it was Adora ot Catra eho rrached for te otehr, and it didnt matter it never did, for soon enough, they were in a tight warm loving embrace whispering ijto each other.

“I’m sorry.”

“I’ll never leave you.”

“I love you.”

Over and over and over, until it echoed over the waves and clouds and star if the night sky.

They did not sleep, couldn’t, not yet. But they lay atop each other on that wooden small boat, and held each other and didn’t speak of uncertainties.

For their were many uncertainties. But some things they were vet certain about.

They will become queens.

They will be together.

And they will have their happily ever after.

Chapter End Notes

Lily flowers are a huge symbol for love between women in East Asian cultures.

Thank you all so much for each person who accompanied me on this journey, I’m beyond grateful!

End Notes

If you made it this far I want you to know that I'm eternally grateful and thank you so much.

Any thoughts, opinions and any general ideas about the story are greatly appreciated! Just please make sure to be kind and respectful.

Again, thank you so much and I hope to see you again.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!